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PHARAOHS, ON BRINK OF AN INCREDIBLE WORLD CUP UPSET, CRUMBLE AT CLOSING

Messi Magic Steals Egypt Dream

Two goals down and 11 minutes to go, Argentina script heart-stopping fightback

Sandip G
New York, July 7

YEARS, AND maybe decades, later, Lionel Messi would remember the game of wildly fluctuating fortunes in graphic detail. The penalty he missed in the first half, the free-kick that cannoned off the post, Egypt's

counter-attacking goals, Cristian Romero's goal that fired the comeback, his own equaliser on the half-volley, the heart-stopping moments during the VAR check of Enzo Fernandez's headed winner. And, after all that, the night he cried like a child when he heard the final whistle.

He would recollect it as one of the greatest comebacks he and his country has made, the afternoon he could see darkness creeping through the roofed canopy of the arena in Atlanta. Just 11 minutes remained



Messi celebrates his goal during the match against Egypt, Tuesday. REUTERS MORE REPORTS, P 21, 22

for Egypt to close out a game they were deservedly leading 2-0. They stopped everything but not the iron-clad resolve of Argentina, the impenetrable genius of Messi, and their own muddled thinking, their naivety on the biggest stage. Cruel as the 3-2 reversal was for Egypt, they lost to a team that is shaping its own destiny, carving its own legacy.

Egypt's resistance would not be forgotten, but Argentina's comeback would acquire epic status. The match would be a touchstone for fightbacks in the tournament's history. And another occasion to celebrate Messi and Argentina. The champions never lost

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'Bureaucrats also had responsibility... Champat Rai's trust in driver misplaced'

Maulshree Seth
Ayodhya, July 7

AMID THE Ram Mandir donation row, which has led to a major organisational shake-up in the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra, treasurer Govind Dev Giri on Tuesday told *The Indian Express* that work should have been decentralised and red flags addressed earlier. However, he asserted that bureaucrats associated with the Trust and SBI officials were equally expected to ensure administrative oversight and flag shortcomings before the situation escalated.

On Monday, the Trust accepted the resignation of its general secretary, Champat Rai, and member, Anil Mishra, and appointed senior RSS functionary and retired Indian Forest Service (IFoS) officer Krishna Mohan as interim general secretary. It also announced the creation of a new chief executive officer (CEO) post.

Speaking to *The Indian Ex-*SWAMI GOVIND DEV GIRI
RAM TEMPLE TRUST TREASURER

EXPLAINED

WITH CEO POST, HOW
RAM TEMPLE TRUST
IS CHANGING PAGE 16

NATION

SIT FLAGS 'LAPSES' BY
FORMER TRUSTEE
ANIL MISHRA PAGE 8

press, Giri defended Rai's personal integrity and said his "working style" rather than his

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Ahmedabad terror attack that killed 56: 18 yrs on, HC upholds death sentence for 38

Parimal A Dabhi
Ahmedabad, July 7

THE GUJARAT High Court on Tuesday upheld the sentence awarded by a special trial court four years ago in the 2008 Ahmedabad serial blasts case, confirming the death penalty for 38 of the 49 convicted and life imprisonment for the remaining 11. The blasts on July 26, 2008, had killed 56 people and injured over 200.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* after the verdict, Special Public Prosecutor in the case, Mitesh Amin, said this is the first instance in the country where a high court has simultaneously confirmed death sentences for as many as 38 people.

The prosecution had contended during the trial that the accused were associated with Indian Mujahideen, an offshoot of the banned outfit SIMI, and had planned the blasts as "revenge" for the 2002 post-Godhra riots in Gujarat and to overthrow an elected government.

A Division Bench, comprising Justices A Y Kogje and Samir Dave, also dismissed the appeals filed by the accused against the trial court's judgment of February 2022. The



As many as 22 bombs went off in Ahmedabad on July 26, 2008. FILE

INSIDE PAGE 9
APPROPRIATE, FAIR,
JUST DECISION, SAY
FAMILIES OF VICTIMS

High Court directed the state government to pay compensation to the victims in the case — Rs 10 lakh each in cases of death, Rs 5 lakh for grievous injury and Rs 1 lakh for minor injury — by March 2027.

Among those facing the death row, at least 14 are from Gujarat, followed by eight from UP, six from Maharashtra, five from MP, two each from Kerala and Karnataka, and one from Hyderabad.

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PM MEETS INDONESIA PRESIDENT, ADDRESSES PARLIAMENT

Missiles, minerals and port: Delhi, Jakarta seal key deals

Eye on China, Modi says India on path of development, not expansionism

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA AND Indonesia signed pacts on the supply of BrahMos and Air-to-Air missiles, along with cooperation on critical minerals and rare earths, maritime security, and space and agriculture as Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto in Jakarta on Tuesday.

Modi also addressed the Indonesian Parliament as part of his two-day visit, making a thinly veiled reference to China's assertive behaviour in the Indo-Pacific. "India is a strong advocate of a free, open and inclusive Indo-Pacific. India believes in freedom of navigation in the Indo-Pacific... India is a nation that follows the path of development, not

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi with President Prabowo Subianto after being conferred the Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia, the country's highest civilian honour, in Jakarta, Tuesday. PT I AM A GREAT ADMIRER OF PM MODI: SUBIANTO PAGE 6

On table: Two BrahMos missile batteries worth \$200 million

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA IS set to supply Indonesia with two batteries of BrahMos supersonic cruise missiles valued at \$200 million as part of several landmark defence agreements signed between the two countries on

Tuesday, including Astra air-to-air missile systems, major defence technology transfer, and maritime security cooperation, officials told *The Indian Express*.

The BrahMos missile has been operationalised in India across all the three defence services and played a key role in striking designated targets inside Pakistan during Operation Sindoor.

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THE BIG PICTURE

THE SCOTLAND
REDEMPTION: MURDER
IN GLASGOW, ARREST
IN MUMBAI PAGE 11

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



• PROPOSAL IN FINAL STAGES, WAS DISCUSSED AT HIGH-LEVEL MEETING WHERE CM WAS PRESENT

Kejriwal's former residence will be Delhi state guest house and cultural centre

To have rooms for guests, conference hall, meeting spaces and an auditorium for various cultural and artistic events

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 7

THE DELHI government will develop the official residence of former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal as a "Delhi State Guest House-cum-Cultural Centre", *The Indian Express* has learned.

The renovation and beautification of the bungalow at 6 Flagstaff Road in Civil Lines in North Delhi by the previous

AAP government was made a major issue by the BJP before the 2025 Assembly election. The bungalow, described as "Sheesh Mahal" by the BJP, has remained unoccupied since October 2024 when Kejriwal moved out.

"The proposal to develop the Civil Lines bungalow is in the final stages. It was discussed in a high-level meeting where Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and senior officials were

present. The Public Works Department (PWD) has been asked to submit details of the present condition of the property," a source in the Delhi government said.

According to officials, the bungalow was on the agenda for the meeting of the Delhi Cabinet last week, but it could not be discussed because the government was focused on rolling out the Electric Vehicle (EV) policy at the time. "The proposal will be taken up for final approval soon," a senior official said.



Kejriwal's official residence was dubbed 'Sheesh Mahal' by BJP

Unlike other states, Delhi does not have a designated state guest house or bhawan to

host guests and national and international delegations. Turning the bungalow into a

state guest house has been among the options on the government's table, but it has now been decided to include a cultural centre, and to also develop the premises next door to build a larger complex, officials said.

"Whenever there is a meeting or event with guests from elsewhere in the country or abroad, the government has to make arrangements for their stay and hospitality," the senior official said. "As this property is readily available, it was proposed to develop it into a state guest house," he said.

"There is space at the back which will be developed. The AAP government was also constructing a building next to this

bungalow, which too will be developed," the official said.

The premises would have rooms for guests, a conference hall, meeting spaces, and an auditorium in which various cultural and artistic programmes, exhibitions, and official ceremonies can be held, officials said.

Kejriwal and his family lived in the bungalow for almost a decade from 2015. Following allegations of irregularities in its renovation and construction, the Directorate of Vigilance had opened an investigation, and the BJP had sought to portray the so-called "Sheesh Mahal" as an example of the alleged corruption of the AAP

government. During the 2025 election campaign, the party had displayed miniature replicas of the bungalow at its rallies and public meetings.

The renovation of the premises led to its built-up area increasing by more than a third from 1,397 sq m to 1,905 sq m, and the PWD had revised its preliminary estimates of the cost of renovation four times.

A report by the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) put the cost of the renovation at Rs 33.66 crore, more than 340% higher than estimated. Of this, Rs 18.88 crore was spent on "superior specifications, artistic, antique and ornamental" items, the CAG said.

New Delhi

epaper.indianexpress.com

Rath Yatra abroad: At odds with ISKCON, Puri royal writes to President and PM

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 7

THE ROW over ISKCON holding Rath Yatras outside India intensified on Monday, with the chairman of the Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee Gajapati Maharaja Di-byasingha Deb, writing to President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, urging them to intervene. He described the plans as “untimely”.

In separate letters to the President and the Prime Minister in his second such appeal in the past 10 months, Deb alleged that ISKCON was organising Snana Yatra (the ceremonial bathing ritual) and Rath Yatra in several countries on dates that did not conform to Hindu scriptures and the centuries-old traditions associated with Lord Jagannath.

“In spite of strong protests from the Hindu community both within India and abroad, ISKCON continues to organise untimely Snana Yatra and Ratha Yatra in various cities abroad on random dates throughout the year, thereby hurting the religious sentiments of countless devotees around the world,” wrote Deb, who is also the head of the house of the Bhoi dynasty, the erstwhile royal family of Puri.

He said ISKCON had organised several such events in recent months and had scheduled more in the coming months.

According to tradition, the annual Rath Yatra is held on the second day of the Odia month of Ashadha Shukla Tithi (bright fortnight), when Lord Jagan-

nath, along with his siblings Lord Balabhadra and Goddess Subhadra, travels from the 12th-century Jagannath Temple in Puri to the Gundicha Temple.

Deb said the Shankaracharyas and Vaishnavacharyas had consistently maintained that these festivals should be celebrated only on the tithis prescribed in the scriptures.

He said repeated efforts by the Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (SJTA) over the past two decades, including several rounds of discussions with ISKCON, had failed to resolve the issue.

Appealing to the President and the Prime Minister, Deb urged them to initiate appropriate steps to stop the conduct of Snana Yatra and Rath Yatra outside the prescribed dates.

The latest appeal comes days after Deb, on July 4, wrote to the chairperson of ISKCON's Governing Body Commission at Mayapur in West Bengal, requesting the organisation to celebrate the festivals “in conformity with scriptures and tradition”.

The Odisha government has also weighed in on the issue.

Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi recently criticised the conduct of “untimely” Rath Yatras and said the state government would take steps to address the matter.

Last year, the SJTA had said it could consider legal action as a “last resort” if Rath Yatra and Snana Yatra continued to be held in violation of what it described as established scriptures and traditions.

ISKCON could not be reached for comment.

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Delhi and Jakarta seal series of key deals

expansionism,” he said.

Modi said, “In recent years, the relationship between India and Indonesia has acquired renewed energy, greater confidence, and deeper strategic depth. Our Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, established in 2018, is reaching new heights today. We are making significant strides across every domain of cooperation, including development, security, technology, culture, and education. I am confident that today marks the beginning of a golden new chapter in the India-Indonesia partnership.”

The Indonesian President also awarded PM Modi the Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia “Medal of Honour”, the country’s highest civilian honour for individuals who have rendered exceptional service to its unity, continuity and prosperity.

Modi, who is on a three-nation trip from July 6 to 11 during which he will also visit Australia and New Zealand, said, “The growing trust between our two countries is strengthening our cooperation in defence, security, and the maritime domain. Today, we agreed to further enhance collaboration in defence exchanges, disaster management, and industrial cooperation.”

According to a joint state-

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBdF>

ment issued by both countries, both leaders “agreed to further strengthen cooperation and enhance engagements in both traditional and emerging areas of defence cooperation”. It said that “they welcomed the elevation of defence cooperation, including through cooperation on BrahMos Missile System, and the Air-to-Air Missile Cooperation Agreement”.

The statement quoted Modi as saying that the Coast Guards of the two countries “will now work together to enhance maritime safety and security in the Indian Ocean”. “As two close maritime nations, we have also decided to deepen our cooperation in the blue economy, port development, and maritime trade,” Modi said.

According to the joint statement, President Prabowo “welcomed India’s interest in partnering on the integrated development of the Sabang Port”.

“Both leaders recognised that such a partnership -- spanning cruise and marine-tourism facilities, maritime industries (ship-repair and shipbuilding), and shore-based services supporting offshore energy activities in the Andaman Sea -- would foster institutional, physical, digital and flow of people and commodities between Andaman and Nicobar Islands of

India and Provinces in Sumatra Island, that contribute to generating investment, employment, transfer of technology and shared regional prosperity,” the statement said.

Sabang port is located at the northwestern entrance to the Strait of Malacca, a critical global maritime corridor through which roughly 25 to 40 per cent of global seaborne trade passes. It lies just 160 kilometres, or less than 100 nautical miles, from India’s upcoming trans-shipment hub at Great Nicobar.

As the two sides signed pacts on rare earth and critical minerals, Modi said, “We have also concluded an important agreement to strengthen supply chain resilience in the areas of critical minerals and steel. In addition, our companies are embarking on a new phase of partnership in stainless steel and rare earth magnets.”

Indonesia dominates the global critical minerals sector, commanding roughly 21% of the world’s nickel reserves and ranking among the top global producers of copper, bauxite, and tin.

The other pacts signed between the two sides included the opening of an IIM Bangalore campus in Indonesia, supply of medicines and medical products to Indonesia, telecom technology including wireless and

quantum systems, and conservation and restoration of the Prambanan temple complex in Yogyakarta, among others.

“Tomorrow, I will have the privilege of joining President Prabowo in Yogyakarta to launch the conservation project for the Prambanan Temple. More than 1,000 years old, the Prambanan Temple stands as a timeless symbol of the shared cultural heritage of India and Indonesia,” Modi said.

On global issues, Modi said that there “is strong synergy in our respective outlooks on the Indo-Pacific” and that “India has always attached special importance to ASEAN centrality”.

“In this period of global turbulence, India believes that the role of dialogue and diplomacy has become more important than ever before. On the issue of Palestine, we continue to support a Two-State Solution and the pursuit of lasting peace,” he said.

On Monday, as Modi landed in Jakarta, he was received at the airport by President Prabowo and four ministers, including the Foreign Minister, Minister of Palace Affairs and Cabinet Secretary. This is the Prime Minister’s fourth visit to Indonesia and his first bilateral visit since ties were elevated to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership in May 2018.

brothers were with our father to learn how to ride a bicycle in the open area there. We were about to return home when my father got a call seeking help for a patient reaching the Trauma Centre. We had reached the centre when the blast occurred. My father and brother died while I sustained injuries,” Vyas had said earlier.

Welcoming the High Court verdict as “historic,” Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi said the state government will comply with the court’s directions on providing compensation to victims.

An official press release quoted Sanghavi as saying, “With today’s verdict, justice has finally been delivered to the victims, their families, and the people of Gujarat. By upholding the trial court’s judgment, the Gujarat High Court has confirmed the death penalty for 38 terrorists and life imprisonment for 11 others, making this one of

the most significant judgments in the history of India’s judicial system.”

Sanghavi expressed gratitude to the High Court, the trial court and the investigation team in the case. “The investigating agencies deserve appreciation for their dedicated efforts over the years, ensuring the case was pursued without any legal lapses or compromise. The verdict sends a clear message that there is no place for terrorism or anti-national activities on Indian soil,” he said.

Among those present in the High Court Tuesday was former IPS officer Abhay Chudasama, who was part of the investigation team as Deputy Commissioner of Police at the Ahmedabad City Detection of Crime Branch.

Speaking to reporters, Chudasama said, “The judgment given by the Sessions court has been confirmed by the High Court, which means our investigation was right.”

effect from June 11, 2024, on “co-terminus basis” or until further orders.

The Ministry has not issued any explanation for his removal, or that of the other three aides -- Private Secretary Amar Singh shunted out on “administrative grounds”, Additional Private Secretary Shailesh Kumar Singh “prematurely repatriated”, and Additional Private Secretary Ayush Saran’s appointment “terminated”.

Meanwhile, the Opposition Congress on Tuesday questioned the reason behind the move. In a post on X, Jairam Ramesh, Congress general secretary in-charge communications, said it was shocking. “It is

no secret to anyone how such appointments are made in the Modi regime. Can so much smoke rise without fire? Could this be a case of the Pradhan Mantri Chando Do, Dhandha Lo (give donation, take business) scheme going awry?”

Congress Rajya Sabha MP and senior national spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi said on X: “When ministerial office gets a ‘clean sweep’ overnight, it’s a story waiting to be told. Pvt Secy & multiple officials removed with immediate effect? Not a minor administrative footnote; that’s a headline. Public deserves answers: What went wrong? What (was) discovered? Who is accountable?”

Ahmedabad blasts

As many as 22 bombs went off in Ahmedabad on July 26, 2008, at various spots, including the state government-run civil hospital, the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation-run LG Hospital, on buses, parked bicycles, in cars and other places.

Two other bombs, at Kalol and Naroda, did not go off.

Earlier, a special court presided over by Special Judge A R Patel had held the criminal trial against 77 accused. It convicted 49, awarding death sentences to 38 and life terms to the other 11. The court acquitted 28 accused, giving them the benefit of the doubt. One of the accused in the case, Ayaz Saiyed, had turned approver.

The special court’s judgment was also a first in the country in terms of simultaneous death penalties awarded in a single case.

The trial was based on 35 cases -- 20 registered in Ahmedabad and 15 in Surat, where similar bombs, which did not detonate, were found after the Ahmedabad blasts.

The 49 convicts were found guilty under various provisions of the Indian Penal Code, the Explosive Substances Act, the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

Welcoming the High Court judgment, one of the victims in the case, Yash Vyas (28), said, “The judgment is appropriate. My father, my brother and many others were killed in the blasts.”

Vyas was just eight when an explosion outside the Trauma Centre of the Civil Hospital killed his father Dushyant, a hospital employee, and elder brother Rohan. “The two of us

‘Clean sweep’

Climate Change is terminated with immediate effect. Shri Siddharth Yadav is relieved of his duties immediately,” said the order, signed by Under Secretary Vibhuti Panjiyar, and marked to the Prime Minister’s Office, Cabinet Secretariat, Department of Personnel and Training, and senior officials of the Environment Ministry.

BJP sources said Siddharth Yadav is one of the Minister’s “oldest and closest aides”, with their association going back to their early ties with the RSS.

According to sources, in ad-

dition to handling the Minister’s administrative work, he also oversaw incoming and outgoing communication for his office and routinely interacted with Chief Ministers, Cabinet colleagues, and members of the bureaucracy.

Sources said Siddharth Yadav was appointed to the post as a “political individual” -- a private nominee with ties to the BJP, similar to some other occupants of such posts across Union Ministries. He was appointed as part of the Minister’s personal staff with

Bengal

on Saturday, a complaint was lodged at 11.50 pm. We have done a preliminary analysis (of the role of police). I have asked the DGP to send me a detailed report on any possible lapses, then action will be taken. We will not tolerate even one per cent lapse,” he said.

Adhikari, who visited Baruipur on Tuesday, met the families of the minor girl and the man

whose identity has not been revealed.

The girl, who went missing on Saturday afternoon, was found dead in a pond on Sunday morning. “The preliminary post-mortem report confirmed sexual assault. She was alive when she was dumped in the pond,” a senior police officer had said.

Three persons -- Ananda Sardar, Prabhash Mondol and Dibakar Sardar -- have been arrested in connection with the rape-murder, while police are looking for a fourth suspect

whose identity has not been revealed.

After her body was found, there were violent protests in Baruipur on Sunday.

Adhikari on Tuesday alleged a political conspiracy behind the protests. “There are political people who instigated the arson... those who have been rejected in the elections, those who gained one (seat) from zero... There are also anti-national elements and radical factions behind all this. The police have identified 200 such people

Messi Magic Steals Egypt Dream

their belief. The tight-knit group has survived several setbacks together. Guided by Messi, they have walked through water and fire, rose from the depths of seas and scaled the peaks. But the latest, impending tragedy looked different. The stakes were immeasurable, it equated to the unquantifiable genius of Messi making his last show on the stage.

Revoking Argentina’s romanticised spirit of resilience, Messi and his colleagues fought on. The opening passage of the second half was compressed to 30 yards from the Egyptian goalmouth. The first time Egypt broke the stranglehold, it nearly settled the game, but a Mostafa Zico goal, orchestrated by Hos-

seim Hassan’s bolting sprint, was rubbed off due to a foul on Lisandro Martinez in the build-up.

But having pushed numbers upfront, Argentina was a walking invitation for counter-attacks. A goal was inevitable; Hassan was the creator with a tearing run down the heart of the field, before cutting back for Zico, running cleverly into space and slamming the ball home to block the comeback route.

Time was dripping away. The shutters on the greatest footballer that has walked the planet was rolling down. Then it rolled itself up. Four minutes after Romero’s header came Messi’s spanking half-volley,

propelled with a non-existent back-lift.

Messi winced. For the second time in the tournament, he missed a penalty. Perhaps, the simplest, taken for granted chore, is his tragic flaw. The man who can make the ball travel improbable paths, who can perplex geometicians with the bends and curls of his free-kicks, who has scored every possible variety of goal mankind could, who can run through an entire village to find the target, can also miss a simple strike from 12 yards with just the goalkeeper to beat. It’s a theatre of the absurd, and for nitpickers, the only blot to nitpick.

Football’s immortal has

mortal numbers in converting penalties -- roughly 77 per cent. He has spilled the last three of his six spot kicks. The attempt was weakly-stuck, his feet wobbling in the follow-through. The Egyptian goalkeeper, Mostafa Shobeir, lunged to his left and staved it away without straining. It was the second penalty he has saved this World Cup, the first man to do so in the tournament’s history.

A crestfallen Messi apologised and stared bewilderingly towards the skies. Could he see his endnotes flickering gloomily above? Among the stack records, he would have an unwanted one too -- the first player to miss two non-shoot-out penalties at the same World Cup. He would not bother. The day, eventually, was to be his.

As the afternoon grew, so did his angst. Almost instantly, he

Ram temple Trustee

integrity had become an issue.

“It was not a question of dishonest intent. Champat ji placed excessive trust in his driver. In an institution of this scale, work has to be decentralised and monitored continuously,” he said, adding that concerns about decentralising responsibilities had been raised earlier but were ignored as Rai continued to take on more work himself.

“Like Sita trusted Marich, Champat ji trusted his driver. That trust proved misplaced,” he said. “While everyone feels that he should not have gone (resigned), it is also true that his lack of vigilance allowed a major crisis to emerge, even though there was no malicious intent.”

Asked about opposition within the Trust to accepting Rai’s resignation, he said several trustees wanted him to continue because of their confidence in his character. “It is true that many members felt the resignation should not have been accepted because of the faith they have in Champat ji’s integrity. I, too, share that faith. We were deeply pained,” he said, comparing the Trust’s anguish to “the pain Lord Ram must have felt while parting from Sita”.

He said the Trust, however, had no legal option but to accept the resignation after senior trustee K Parasaran, who argued the Ram Janmabhoomi title suit before the Supreme Court, pointed out that a resignation is deemed accepted once tendered under the Trust’s constitution.

On the issue of accountability, Giri said the Trust had assigned responsibilities to different office-bearers.

“Hundis and donation boxes were looked after by Anil Mishra ji. Once the money entered the treasury, it became my responsibility,” he said.

“But SBI officials and bureaucrats... associated with the Trust also had responsibilities. They, too, should have paid attention to these issues. If they had concerns, they should have raised them before matters reached this stage,” he said.

He said bureaucrats were included in the Trust along with saints and social workers to strengthen governance.

“The idea was that each would contribute according to their expertise. The bureaucrats were expected to identify administrative shortcomings and offer timely suggestions. Those suggestions should have come before the crisis,” he said.

He acknowledged that the

Trust should have acted sooner after the first indications of irregularities. “The moment there was any indication of wrongdoing, it should have been reported. That expectation exists in every institution,” he said.

Referring again to Rai, he added, “This reflects his simplicity. However, excessive simplicity does not work in administration. Practicality is equally important.”

The controversy has also prompted the Trust to create the post of a CEO, a move, Giri said, was aimed at strengthening administrative systems rather than bringing the temple under government control.

“The CEO will be appointed by the Trust and will be a salaried employee of the Trust. Government control comes when an administrator is imposed by the government. That is not happening here. The committee would suggest three names and the Trust would make a final call,” he said.

A three-member committee comprising retired Justice Pramod Kohli, retired Lieutenant General Vishnukant Chaturvedi and trustee-industrialist Suresh Haware has been tasked with recommending candidates for the post.

Giri said the three were carefully chosen to bring discipline and accountability.

He said Haware’s experience in introducing administrative reforms at the Shri Saibaba Sansthan Trust in Shirdi would help the Trust build a more robust and leak-proof system. “Shirdi also once faced similar challenges. Haware ji gave 10 years to find leaks and prepare a foolproof system. His expertise would help us as well,” said Giri.

On their next plan of action, he said, “The first priority is to restore faith. We need to overhaul the entire system, beginning with the counting process. Every person working in sensitive positions should undergo proper background verification before being assigned responsibility.”

The Trust maintains records of over 2,800 ornaments, idols and other valuables, he said, adding that “what has happened is the result of negligence, inadequate supervision and lack of vigilance”.

“Institutions of this scale require discipline, systems and professional administration. That is why the Trust has decided to move towards a more structured framework,” he said, adding that the proposed reforms would be discussed at the next meeting on July 22.

BrahMos batteries

A BrahMos battery typically comprises four launchers and 12 ready-to-fire missiles, along with other equipment and vehicles, though the composition can vary between land-based regiments and coastal defence batteries.

With this deal, India is set to export the system to three countries, also including the Philippines and Vietnam, even as it holds talks with at least half-a-dozen other nations on the missile system.

The Philippines had procured three batteries of the weapon system from India in 2022. In May this year, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh officially confirmed at the Shangri-La Dialogue in Singapore that India had signed a deal with Vietnam for the sale of BrahMos missiles, and that a similar deal with Indonesia was in “final stages”.

New Delhi has been in talks with Jakarta over the sale of Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2rVdL_RGf9mJlMzgl

the missile system under a joint venture between the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and Russia’s NPO Mashinostroyeniya.

The Indian Express had earlier reported that the finer details of the deal were discussed during the third India-Indonesia defence ministers’ dialogue, co-chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and his Indonesian counterpart Sjafrie Sjamsuddin in New Delhi last November.

Brahmos Aerospace Private Ltd is also looking to export a compact next-gen version, BrahMos NG, to at least 10 countries, including South Africa and West Asian nations such as Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Egypt.

Work is also underway to extend the range of existing BrahMos missiles from 290 km to 500 km for land attacks, and to 400 km for ship attacks.

could have atoned. But his free-kick, swerving, tucking and arcing inwards rammed onto the upright. He cursed his luck, a rare outburst of anger. His troops rallied around him, and nearly produced the equaliser in the 40th minute. Julian Alvarez, starting ahead of Lautaro Martinez, saw Shobeir’s strong long hands redirect his side-footed shot from the goal. Shobeir absorbed the heat of Alvarez’s header from point-blank range.

Egypt’s strike was not against the flow of a game where both teams were inclined to keep their shape, defend compactly and not concede an early goal. Excursions into the penalty box were rare. It was akin to a pair of boxers shadow punching before landing the blows. One blow could ignite a series of blows. And then the

goal happened, and Egyptian fans celebrated with as much shock as awe.

It was Egypt’s first incisive run upfield. Figurehead Mo Salah was involved for the first time in the game, and the right-back Mohamed Hany induced a corner off Lisandro Martinez. Egypt worked the corner shot, near the right channel outside the box, Marwan Attia swung a scything cross to the opposite postcode, where Yasser Ibrahim beat Martinez to the ball and powered his header across the goal, past a reaction-less Martinez. The strike roused the contest from its slumber.

The drama that unfolded would make it an all-time classic. It was heart-breaking for Egypt; their courage would be remembered. But the script that Messi and his teammates wrote was simply more forceful.

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SC refuses to bar Vijay from meeting with kin of Karur stampede victims

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

THE SUPREME Court Tuesday refused to entertain an application filed by a Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) leader seeking to restrain Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay and other members of the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) from making public comments regarding the September 27, 2025, Karur stampede or interacting with families of the victims.

A two-judge bench of Justice K V Viswanathan and Justice Alok Aradhe pulled up the petitioner, stating that the Supreme Court cannot be used as a platform to settle political scores.

"You want the chief minister's visit to be regulated by the Supreme Court and fix his itinerary?" Justice Viswanathan asked, pointing out that Vijay was not named as accused in initial FIR.

Following the bench's strong disinclination to entertain the matter, Senior Advocate Ranjit Kumar, appearing for the petitioner, DMK Rajya Sabha MP and organising secretary R S Bharathi, chose to withdraw the application.

Bharathi's application was filed just ahead of CM Vijay's

scheduled July 10 visit to Karur, where he plans to meet the victims' families to distribute ex gratia compensation and compassionate government appointment orders. The stampede, which claimed 41 lives during a TVK rally last year, has been under investigation by the CBI following a SC order in October 2025.

The plea application filed to add petitioner as party highlighted a July 2 public speech by minister Aadhav Arjuna, who blamed the DMK administration for the stampede and having "a score to settle". Kumar contended that such public statements could set a "narrative" about the merits of the case, thereby violating the SC order entrusting the probe to the CBI. He clarified that there was no objection to providing compensation to victims.

Justice Viswanathan questioned the underlying intent of the application, asking, "So you want us to impose an injunction on free speech?"

"You counter their speech with your speech. How does the Supreme Court, in a matter where it ordered a CBI investigation, allow the impeachment of a political rival and pass one order after the other?"

Four beneficiary states sign pact on Narmada outstanding dues

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

CHIEF MINISTERS of Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Rajasthan signed an agreement on Tuesday relating to the settlement of outstanding dues of the Narmada Water Disputes Tribunal (NWDT) Award Projects.

The "historic agreement" was signed in the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Union Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil.

CMs Devendra Fadnavis (Maharashtra), Bhupendra Patel (Gujarat), Bhajan Lal Sharma (Rajasthan) and Dr. Mohan Yadav (Madhya Pradesh), along with senior officials from the Centre and the states, were present on the occasion.

The Centre had constituted the NWDT in 1969, which gave its Award in 1979. The NWDT Award specified the quantum of water that could be utilised by the four states, as well as determined their share of the net power produced at Navagam at Canal Head and River Bed Power Houses. While most issues were resolved after the Award's distribution, issues like dues pertaining to the cost-sharing of the Sardar Sarovar Project and the Indira



(L-R) Madhya Pradesh CM Mohan Yadav, Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel, Union Minister of Jal Shakti C R Patil, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis and Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma during the Narmada agreement signing. PTI

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Commending Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, Shah said several historic initiatives have been undertaken to strengthen water security and promote cooperative federalism in the water sector.

He [Amit Shah] said that the formation of double-engine governments in several States under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi has enhanced the ability to understand one another, reduced political differences, and accelerated the resolution of many long-pending disputes across the country," the statement said.

Shah also lauded Jal Shakti Minister C R Patil's role in resolving water-related issues.

Bihar bypoll: BJP names BJYM leader to contest from Nabin's seat

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 7

THE BJP on Tuesday named Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM) state vice-president Abhishek Kumar as its candidate for the high-profile Bankipur Assembly bypoll, setting up a triangular contest against the RJD's Rekha Gupta and Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor.

The bypoll, scheduled for July 30, was necessitated after BJP MLA Nitin Nabin was elected the party's national president and subsequently nominated to the Rajya Sabha. The BJP has held the seat, known as Patna West until the 2005 Assembly polls, continuously since 1995. Before that, Janata Party's Thakur Prasad had won it in 1977.

BJP national general secretary Arun Singh announced

Kumar's candidature. Bihar BJP media in-charge Danish Egbal told *The Indian Express*: "Abhishek Kumar has been a committed worker of the party for 27 years. He has previously served as the Patna Mahanagar BJYM president and as a mandal head twice. He has risen to this level from being a booth president, showing how much the party values its grassroots workers."

Party leaders said Kumar's selection reflects the BJP's preference for organisational workers with local roots. A BJP source said two factors worked in his favour. "First, he comes from the Kayastha community, which has a sizeable population in Bankipur. The party has always fielded a Kayastha candidate here, from Thakur Prasad to Naveen Kishore Sinha to his son Nitin Nabin. Second, Abhis-

hek Kumar has been a close aide of Nitin Nabin and also enjoys the confidence of CM Samrat Choudhary," the source said.

While Kumar has not been part of the BJP's core state leadership or held senior organisational posts such as state general secretary or state vice-president, he described his candidature as recognition of grassroots workers.

"I am overwhelmed by the party's decision. The party has honoured me by considering my candidature," he said.

The contest has gained prominence after Jan Suraj founder Prashant Kishor decided to contest the bypoll himself, turning it into his first direct electoral battle. The RJD has fielded Rekha Gupta, who finished runner-up to Nabin in the 2020 and 2025 Assembly elections.



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Audit performance of disciplinary mechanism for lawyers: SC to BCI

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

WHILE SELF-REGULATION lies at the heart of the independence of the legal profession, it is also important to maintain public confidence in the institution of lawyers, the Supreme Court said Tuesday. The top court also asked the Bar Council of India (BCI) to undertake a "comprehensive performance audit of the disciplinary mechanisms administered by it and the State Bar Councils under the Advocates Act, 1961".

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe also called for setting up a National Legal Academy (NLA) that will provide continued legal education to lawyers so as to enable post-enrolment structural learning, enhance professional competence and other skills.

The bench set aside an Allahabad HC order which refused to give a lawyer any relief in a matter in which his name was removed from a panel of advocates by the Canara Bank and included in a "Caution List" titled "Third Party Entities Involved in Fraud", maintained by the Indian Banks' Association (IBA). This happened after a legal opinion given by the advocate turned out to be wrong and exposed the bank to loss. The SC held that the IBA's Caution List is intended to operate only in cases involving serious misconduct and not to address cases resting merely on alleged negligence or errors of professional judgement as in the present case.



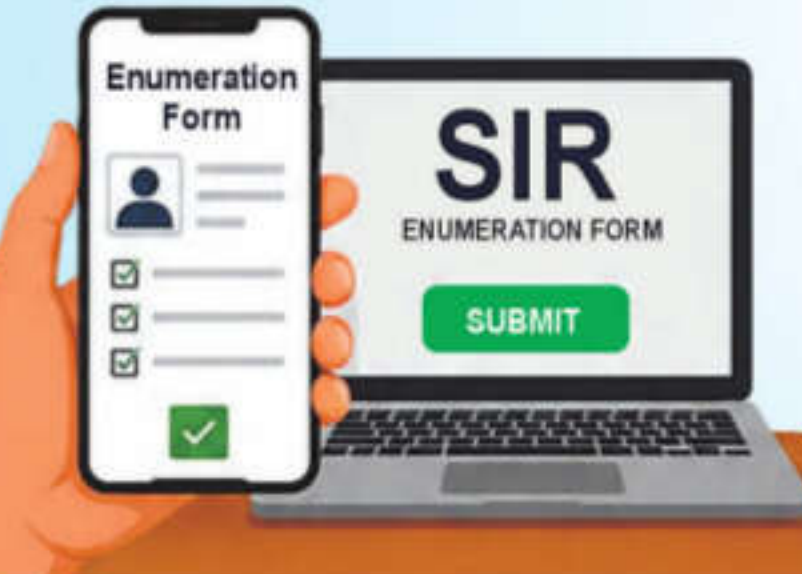
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Jaishankar talks ties with Deputy PM of Bahrain

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS Minister S Jaishankar, who is on a four-nation Gulf tour, on Tuesday met Bahrain's Deputy Prime Minister Khalid bin Abdulla Al Khalifa on Tuesday.

The meeting came a day after Jaishankar held an audience with Bahrain's King Hamad bin Isa Al Khalifa and Crown Prince and PM Salman bin Hamad Al Khalifa.

"A pleasure to meet Deputy Prime Minister of Bahrain H.E Khalid bin Abdulla Al Khalifa this morning. Discussed taking forward our bilateral cooperation across various sectors. Also exchanged views on the regional situation," Jaishankar posted on X on Tuesday.

Jaishankar arrived in Bahrain on Monday from Qatar. He is on the second leg of his four-nation Gulf visit from July 5 to 10, which also includes Kuwait and Oman



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New Delhi



Global Capital

DELHI LIEUTENANT Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu donned his career diplomat hat on Tuesday while addressing members of the Foreign Correspondents' Club of South Asia in the national capital. Said to have been appointed to the post to ensure Delhi's evolution into a "global capital", Sandhu, during the interaction, sought to underline Delhi's story as one of continuity and not mere transformation through the ages. The LG also took the opportunity to reiterate that the city has a special responsibility to live up to PM Narendra Modi's vision of the world looking at India "with new confidence, and new expectations".

Making Room

AFTER THE government increased the strength of the Supreme Court judges from 34 to 38 in May and five new judges took office in June, the court complex is seeing an expansion too. The CPWD is converting seven different rooms on the first floor of the West Wing of the main complex into two additional courtrooms, it is learnt. The work involves demolishing the existing walls between the rooms to make courtrooms. The contractor has been told not to use explosives or make too much noise so that the judicial work doesn't get hampered, it is learnt.

Domicile must for bike taxi drivers in Maharashtra

Mumbai: In a departure from its earlier attempts to curb app-based bike taxi operations, the Maharashtra government will begin issuing permits for such services from August 1 under a new regulatory framework that will require drivers to possess a Maharashtra domicile certificate, fulfil prescribed eligibility conditions and operate through registered aggregators, State Transport Minister Pratap Sarnaik told *The Indian Express* on Tuesday.

The move seeks to regularise app-based bike taxi services that have so far operated without a legal framework in the state. Replying to a discussion in the Legislative Assembly, Sarnaik said around 4 lakh to 4.5 lakh app-based bike taxis are currently operating in Maharashtra without valid permission. The issue was raised by Shiv Sena MLA Dilip Lande. ENS

PM ADDRESSES INDIAN DIASPORA

'1.4 bn aspirations in motion': Modi sums up India's growth in Jakarta

Indonesia President Prabowo says he is a great admirer of PM Narendra Modi

Divya A
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA IS moving forward with the mantra of "reform, perform and transform", Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in Jakarta on Tuesday, underlining that self-reliance is a multiplying force not only for Indonesia but for the entire ASEAN region.

Speaking at a diaspora event in Jakarta, also attended by President Prabowo Subianto, Modi said: "India has carried out one reform after another. We have consistently performed, and that's why the country is transforming today. We are moving forward with the mantra of reform, perform, and transform."

In his address, Prabowo highlighted his "Indian DNA" and his great admiration for PM Modi. Modi said if he had to describe the speed and scale of in-



PM Narendra Modi with Indonesia's President Prabowo Subianto during the Indian Community reception, in Jakarta. PTI

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> dia's growth in one line, he'd say "1.4 billion aspirations in motion". "India is not just the world's fastest-growing economy; it's a nation with a billion-plus dreams in motion," he said, adding that India's economy is playing a major role in driving global growth.

"From energy to connectivity and chip manufacturing, India is unstoppable. Today's

India is not just fulfilling its own dreams but also fulfilling those of every friendly nation. India walks on the mantra of 'sabka saath, sabka vikas', Modi said.

"As India is modernising its ports, building new ships and exploring new sea routes to strengthen its maritime sector, Indonesia stands as our favourite friend... Whether in Indonesia or India, our shared goal is de-

velopment. We cannot afford to wait or stop," Modi said.

Addressing the gathering ahead of Modi, Prabowo said Indonesia draws inspiration from Indian democracy. "I don't want to be involved in domestic Indian politics. I'm a friend of all Indians but I want to admit one thing and my close associates and colleagues will testify that I am a great admirer of Narendra

Modi ji. I'm not a professional politician. The proof that I'm not a professional politician is that I took part in five general elections. I lost four times... Even before I became President, I studied the policies of the Prime Minister (Narendra Modi) and because there are no copyright, I copied many of his policies. But, Prime Minister Modi graciously allowed me to copy his policies. So, I cannot be sued in any court," Prabowo said.

Highlighting his "Indian DNA", Prabowo, who was the chief guest at the Republic Day celebrations in 2025, shared how gene testing confirmed his Indian DNA just before he visited India. "Whenever I hear Indian music, I find my body moving... my ministers and generals all like to dance and sing. Maybe most of them have Indian DNA also... It's true. Most of my ministers sing Indian songs really well," he added.

On this, Modi said, "Your statement has touched the hearts of Indians. And this DNA is made of mutual trust, shared heritage, shared memories. The relationship between India and Indonesia is rooted in our shared civilisational heritage and the seas that connect us."

EXPRESS special

'A united Cong can hold AAP accountable more effectively'

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, July 7

WITH THE Punjab polls likely to be held early next year, the Congress's state unit is grappling with a crisis following recent election-related appointments. The Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, Partap Singh Bajwa, speaks to *The Indian Express* on the situation in the party and possible solutions, among other things. Excerpts:

How do you view the recent developments... especially the high command's decision to continue with Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the state chief?

The Congress believes in internal democracy and every leader has the right to express views on organisational matters. At the same time, there are well-established forums where such concerns must be discussed. It is the responsibility of every leader and worker to respect the decision and work towards strengthening the party. Any concerns should be discussed within the party and not in the media. Right now our priority must be to prepare for the 2027 elections.

You maintained a studied silence until AICC in-charge Bhupesh Baghel arrived and also did not attend the dissidents' meeting...

I deliberately chose not to react publicly as I believe internal matters must be solved within the party. Public statements often complicate matters.



PARTAP SINGH BAJWA
LEADER OF OPPOSITION
IN PUNJAB ASSEMBLY

As a senior leader, I consider it my responsibility to promote dialogue and encourage consensus. My commitment has always been to the Congress, not to any particular camp or group.

Does the present situation bring back memories of 2021, when Channi replaced Captain Amarinder Singh as CM months before polls?

Every political situation has its own circumstances. Hence, it will not be appropriate to draw comparisons to 2021. As elections approach, it is important that every Congress leader keeps the larger interests of the party above individual preferences.

In the run-up to the party's restructuring, you were part of several meetings with the high command. What concerns did you convey to top leadership?

I emphasised that experience, contributions and political stature of senior leaders must be effectively utilised to strengthen the organisation. I

stressed on greater consultation before taking key decisions and also on more structured and regular communication between the state leaders and the AICC. Every leader must be assigned a role so that the party can reap the benefits of the collective strength of its leadership.

Why did the party decide to continue with Warring as the state chief and you as the LoP despite voices demanding change?

The high command, after considering different viewpoints and assessing the political situation, concluded that continuity would serve the party's best interests at this stage. Once such a decision is taken, leaders need to respect it. However, genuine concerns and reservations must be heard with an open mind and through the party's internal mechanisms.

Will internal rifts affect the Congress's ability to challenge the AAP govt on key issues?

Any internal difference (within the Congress) inevitably diverts attention from real issues. Today, Punjab is grappling with law-and-order challenges, drug menace, unemployment, financial stress and administrative failures. The Congress must focus its energy on these issues. A united Congress will be more effective in holding the AAP government accountable and present a credible alternative before the people. Every Congress leader understands this responsibility.

India extends US lobbying contract with Trump aide's firm for another year

Divya A
New Delhi, July 7

THE INDIAN government has extended its lobbying contract in the United States with SHW Partners LLC, led by President Donald Trump's close aide Jason Miller, for another year, according to filings under the Foreign Agents Registration Act (FARA). The renewed contract, signed by the Indian Embassy in Washington, involves a monthly payout of \$150,000 (Rs 1.43 crore) and will run until April 23, 2027.

This is significant at a time when President Trump is expected to visit India in the same timeframe, while New Delhi and Washington are also closing in on a bilateral trade deal.

The scope of work includes "strategic counsel, tactical planning, and government relations assistance on policy matters before the US government, the US Congress, state governments, academic institutions, think tanks, and other relevant stakeholders", as per the documents.

As Trump took office early last year, the Indian Embassy in Washington hired two major lobbying firms, helmed by those considered part of the President's inner circle.

On April 24, 2025, SHW Partners LLC was signed on for \$1.8 million (Rs 17 crore) annually. The firm is led by Miller, Trump's chief spokesperson during the 2016 campaign and his subsequent presidential transition. The other firm was Mercury Public Affairs, signed at a monthly retainer of \$75,000 (Rs 71.4 lakh), with Bryan Lanza, communications director for the 2020 Trump transition team, in its core team.

Susie Wiles, now Trump's Chief of Staff, was also a registered lobbyist with the firm until late 2024. When Operation Sindoor ended on May 10 last year, New Delhi reached out to Washington four times through Miller, as per FARA filings. The four calls made on the day were to Jamieson Greer, US Trade Representative; Ricky Gill of the US National Security Council; Steven Cheung of the White House; and Wiles, to discuss media coverage of Operation Sindoor, as reported by *The Indian Express*.

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

Even as there was no public announcement about the agenda of the Trump-Miller meeting, days later, President Trump called Prime Minister Narendra Modi, describing the India-US relationship as "special" and that they would always be "friends".

Along with Ambassador Gor, who has a direct line to President Trump, Miller is considered India's person in Washington, as his longstanding association with Trump could shape how effectively he navigates Washington's power corridors for India.

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 7

DOCTORS AND nurses at the Kalyan Dombivli Municipal Corporation's Shastrinagar Hospital in Dombivli alleged that they were assaulted by Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre and some of his supporters following a dispute over the referral of a pregnant patient, triggering a strike by hospital staff.

ACP Suhas Hemadesai said that an offence has been registered against five persons including four men and a woman in connection with the case.

According to doctors, a preg-

The renewed contract, signed by the Indian Embassy in Washington, involves a monthly payout of \$150,000 (Rs 1.43 crore) and will run until April 23, 2027

Documents also reveal that SHW Partners LLC assisted the Indian Embassy in Washington with trade deal negotiations and organised meetings for Indian officials.

Miller, who frequently acts as a bridge to Trump's inner circle during major diplomatic engagements, made his first public appearance in India in May this year. He was among those walking the red carpet at the reception hosted by the US Embassy for Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

As per the American Embassy, Miller was here as a private citizen to meet his friend Sergio Gor. "Miller is visiting India as a private citizen to join the America 250 celebration and to visit his longtime friend, Ambassador Gor," a US Embassy spokesperson said in response to a query by *The Indian Express*.

It is believed that Miller has leveraged his longstanding ties with Trump to set up meetings and facilitate policy discussions on behalf of Indian diplomats. In September last year, against the backdrop of tensions in ties between India and the US over Washington's policy on tariffs, Miller met the US President and a few officials of his administration.

Even as there was no public announcement about the agenda of the Trump-Miller meeting, days later, President Trump called Prime Minister Narendra Modi, describing the India-US relationship as "special" and that they would always be "friends".

Along with Ambassador Gor, who has a direct line to President Trump, Miller is considered India's person in Washington, as his longstanding association with Trump could shape how effectively he navigates Washington's power corridors for India.

Sena man 'assaults' docs over referral of patient

Express News Service
Mumbai, July 7

DOCTORS AND nurses at the Kalyan Dombivli Municipal Corporation's Shastrinagar Hospital in Dombivli alleged that they were assaulted by Shiv Sena corporator Ramesh Mhatre and some of his supporters following a dispute over the referral of a pregnant patient, triggering a strike by hospital staff.

ACP Suhas Hemadesai said that an offence has been registered against five persons including four men and a woman in connection with the case.

According to doctors, a preg-

nant woman had been admitted to the civic hospital for delivery. After examining her, doctors informed the family that the newborn might require treatment in the NICU. As all NICU beds at the hospital were occupied, the family was advised that the patient could be shifted to another hospital if specialised neonatal care became necessary.

Hospital staff alleged that the referral decision led to an argument, after which Mhatre and his supporters entered the hospital and assaulted a woman doctor, two other doctors and three nurses on Monday evening.

On tricky turf, how Punjab polls challenge key contenders – AAP to Cong, SAD to BJP

CAPITAL CONTEXT

BY LIZ MATHEW

A WEEKLY LOOK AT POLITICS IN A STATE FROM THE VANTAGE POINT OF NEW DELHI

HEADED FOR the Assembly polls in about seven months, Punjab has emerged as one of the most unpredictable political battlegrounds in the country, where every major contender sees a path to victory in what could be a fierce, multi-cornered election.

While the ruling AAP hopes to retain power by taking advantage of a fragmented Opposition, the Congress, despite its intensifying internal strife, believes it can ride on the "anti-incumbency" factor to oust the Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann-led AAP government from power.

The Sukhbir Badal-led SAD, which once dominated Punjab, may be reeling from an existential crisis, but has still continued its attempts to make a comeback in state politics. Even the BJP, despite its smaller support base, harbours aspirations to come to the helm in the border state. The party is buoyed by its landslide victory in the recent West Bengal polls, where it stormed to power for the first time.

Sacrilege video row

The principal Opposition Congress, which has only 16 MLAs in the 117-member state Assembly, has aimed to capitalise on the sacrilege video row allegedly involving CM Mann that has landed the AAP in a crisis.

On June 15, the Akal Takht, the highest temporal authority of Sikhs, declared Mann "Guru dokh" (anti-Guru) and "Khalsa panth virodhi" (anti-Khalsa

panth) over the alleged sacrilege video, even as the CM has maintained that he was not in it. Mann has held that the video was "fabricated" to defame him.

The AAP has also been beset with some high-profile defections in recent months. In April, seven of the party's 10 Rajya Sabha members, led by Raghav Chadha, jumped ship and "merged" with the BJP. Six of these defectors were elected as the AAP MPs from Punjab.

Despite these setbacks, the AAP registered a resounding win in the May local body elections, securing a majority in five of eight municipal corporations, 39 of 75 municipal councils, and nine of 20 nagar panchayats across the state.

Congress rifts

While the Congress was expected to benefit from the AAP's troubles, it has been struggling

to put its own house in order amid growing dissension and infighting in its ranks.

The Congress high command recently did a balancing act to revamp the Punjab unit, retaining Amrinder Singh Raja Warring as the state chief and Partap Singh Bajwa as the Assembly LoP while naming ex-CM and Warring's detractor Charanjit Singh Channi as the party poll campaign committee's chairman. However, the exercise seems to have widened the cracks, with Channi's supporters launching a campaign against Warring. An aspirant for the state Congress chief's post, Channi has apparently rallied a slew of senior leaders to put pressure on the party leadership.

The Congress circles are also abuzz with speculations that there could be defections from the party to the BJP. The developments have given a jolt to the

Congress's rank and file, which have been projecting the party as a challenger to the AAP.

BJP play

BJP insiders say the party is looking to tap into the "contradictions and conflicts" in its rivals to make its mark in the upcoming elections. BJP leaders flag several issues that they claim have fuelled "anti-incumbency" against the Mann government, citing "the AAP dispensation's mismanagement of last year's floods, stagnated infrastructure projects and the state's growing debt crisis".

The state BJP has been in informal talks with its erstwhile ally SAD in a bid to forge alliance again. It has pinned hopes on the Centre's decisions on some issues that could create resonance among the people of the state.

State BJP leaders say the Centre may take initiatives for

the release of Bandi Singhs (Sikh prisoners) – who have been in jail for alleged involvement in militancy – and for increase in the percentage of Agniveers (from current 25%) who can be retained in the services after completing their four-year tenure. "Such steps will endear the BJP to the people, creating fresh ways to expand the party in Punjab," said a state party leader.

Party leaders also claim that by projecting PM Narendra Modi as the BJP's face, the party could dominate six Hindu dominated districts of the state.

The BJP has recently appointed Kewal Singh Dhillon, 76, as its first-ever Jat Sikh state chief. The move is aimed at reaching out to Jat Sikhs, who account for 20-25% of Punjab's population.

While Nayab Singh Saini, the BJP CM of Haryana, campaigns extensively in Punjab these days,

senior party leaders like Tarun Chugh and Union Minister Manohar Lal have also been visiting the state regularly to coordinate the party's groundwork.

Despite the BJP's bid for an alignment with the SAD, Saini told the media a few days ago that the BJP will not enter into alliance for the Punjab elections.

Fraught scene

Senior leaders from Punjab argue that the prevailing situation in the state is "complex and fraught". Senior Congress leader and ex-Union minister Manish Tewari said: "The difficulty is that Punjab is unfortunately facing more existential challenges now than 1966 when it was reorganised. Its public debt is now over Rs 4.77 lakh crore, average land holding size has been reduced to 2.5 to 5 acres and water table has dipped drastically, especially in the rice grow-

ing areas of central Punjab. There is no industry, no employment while narco militancy is taking state back to the 1980s-1990s and unfortunately none of these issues have found any resonance in the public discourse."

With the AAP rolling out various sop to woo its vote bank despite the deepening debt crisis, the Congress reeling from internal feuds, the SAD not regaining traction, and the BJP still remaining a marginal force, Punjab seems to be under a cloud of uncertainty amid apprehensions that it may provide space to radical elements.

"Punjab requires a political consensus among parties to tackle its existential crisis. Or it requires a government for 60 months that is not interested in coming back to power and can take tough decisions to put the state back on the rails," Tewari said.

UTTAR PRADESH

A NEW DESTINATION FOR INVESTMENT AND INNOVATION

Under the visionary leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Uttar Pradesh is setting new benchmarks in development, investment, and innovation. Driven by progressive policies, modern infrastructure, rapid industrial expansion, and strong initiatives to promote entrepreneurship, the state has firmly established itself as one of India's most attractive investment destinations. From building world-class industrial and logistics ecosystems to generating new opportunities for employment and self-employment, Uttar Pradesh is unlocking fresh possibilities across every sector of the economy. With a commitment to sustainable and inclusive growth, the state growth is steadily progressing towards becoming a trillion-dollar economy and emerging as a leading engine of India's economic development.



Investor-Focused Framework: A Pro-Business Environment for Industries

- Five sectoral desks have been established to attract investment and ensure swift resolution of industry-related issues in the state.
- Dedicated focus on key sectors such as textiles and apparel, automobiles and e-mobility, chemicals, electronics, and Global Capability Centres (GCCs).
- Six country desks created to promote global investment: Germany-France, UAE-Singapore, Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, and the United Kingdom.
- Under the Uttar Pradesh Ease of Doing Business (Amendment of Provisions) Act, 2025, reforms have been introduced in 10 Acts.
- Decriminalisation of 39 provisions across 10 departments, making business operations simpler, faster, and more transparent.



World-Class Industrial Parks: Powering New Uttar Pradesh's Growth Story

- Rapid rollout of modern flatted factory complexes, including IIT GNL (Greater Noida), Mega Food Park (Bareilly), Trans Ganga City (Unnao), and dedicated Plastic & Garment Parks in Gorakhpur.
- Emerging innovation hubs like Film City, Toy Park, Apparel Park, Handicraft Park, and a Logistics Hub in the Yamuna Expressway region.
- Development of specialized parks including 1,472-acre Pharma Park (Lalitpur-Jhansi), Perfume Park (Kannauj), and Medical Device Park (YEIDA).
- PM MITRA Mega Textile & Apparel Park in Lucknow-Hardoi to create 3 lakh jobs.
- Expansion of leather, plastic, chemical & pharma clusters across key industrial cities.



DATA CENTRES & AI INFRASTRUCTURE: A NEW HUB OF THE DIGITAL FUTURE

- Target of 5 GW data centre capacity by 2030 and 40 GW by 2047 in UP.
- Plans to develop 8 data centre parks with an estimated investment of ₹30,000 crore.
- A total capacity allocation of 900 MW has been earmarked.
- Letters of Comfort issued for 8 projects, including 6 data centre parks and 2 standalone data centre units.
- Promotion of a cutting-edge digital ecosystem through cluster and township-based development models.

AI Ecosystem Development: From Innovation to Self-Reliance

- A strong foundation for an AI-driven future is being built through the 'Uttar Pradesh AI Mission'.
- Rapid progress towards establishing AI Labs in 49 ITIs, along with AI Centres of Excellence and India AI Data Labs. Decision to set up a Cyber Security Operations Centre to strengthen digital security.
- Under the AI-Pragya programme, global technology companies such as Microsoft, Google, Intel, and IBM are providing AI training to farmers, students, doctors, self-help groups, and government officials.

IT Ecosystem: A New Identity of Digital Growth

- Till 2017, there were 4 STPI centres in the state-Noida, Lucknow, Kanpur and Prayagraj.
- After 2017, 3 new STPI centres were established in Meerut, Agra & Gorakhpur.
- Proposal for setting up 2 additional STPI centres in Bareilly and Varanasi.
- Remarkable surge in electronics exports-from ₹3,862 crore (2017-18) to ₹44,744 crore (2024-25).
- A record growth of 1,058% in just 7 years, reflecting Uttar Pradesh's expanding strength in digital and electronics manufacturing.

Semiconductor Revolution

- North India's first semiconductor unit is being established in the Yamuna Expressway region.
- A joint venture of HCL and Foxconn Group with an investment of over ₹3,700 crore.
- India's first display driver IC-based OSAT facility, adding new capabilities in semiconductor assembly, packaging, and testing.
- Strengthening the electronics manufacturing supply chain and placing India firmly on the global semiconductor map.
- Uttar Pradesh becomes the fourth state in the country to implement the Semiconductor Policy 2024.

Technology-Driven Ease of Living: Digital UP, Empowered Citizens

- Over 24 citizen services, including income, caste, and domicile certificates, are available through the e-Saathi mobile app.
- Internet connectivity ensured by linking 2,066 Gram Panchayats with optical fibre networks.
- Under Project Ganga, a target has been set to deliver high-speed broadband to 20 lakh rural and semi-urban households, creating 1,00,000 employment opportunities.
- Rapid efforts are underway to develop Kanpur as a Drone Hub and Lucknow as an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Hub.

'Mouths sealed on Waqf': UP CM targets Congress, SP

Express News Service
Lucknow, July 7

UTTAR PRADESH Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath Tuesday hit out at the Congress and the Samajwadi Party (SP), claiming they "attack Sanatan" with their statements on the Ram temple 'donation theft' row but their "mouths get sealed with Fevicol" when it comes to Waqf issues.

The BJP governments at the Centre and in UP have been facing criticism over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple, an issue the Opposition has sought to frame as an assault on the faith of Hindus. Adityanath, whose government ordered an SIT probe, has repeatedly countered the Opposition by accusing them of Muslim appeasement.

On Tuesday, the CM alleged that the Congress and SP remained silent on issues such as waqf land "grabbing" while now seeking to corner the BJP over Ayodhya.

At an event in Pratapgarh, the CM said, "Remember how the Congress used to say that Ram never existed, Krishna never existed? In Ayodhya, the Congress and the SP, who were supporting the... Babri Masjid and shedding crocodile tears for it, today you must be seeing how that same Congress and SP have changed their colours like a chameleon. Now they are saying faith in Ayodhya is being hurt."

'Playing with faith of millions of Hindus': TMC MPs slam BJP

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

THE LEADERS of TMC, aligned with Mamata Banerjee, on Tuesday questioned why the registration of an FIR in relation to the alleged donation theft at Ayodhya's Ram Temple was delayed, while accusing Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath of playing "good cop, bad cop" in the issue.

TMC MPs Mahua Moitra and Kirti Azad also accused the Bharatiya Janata Party of "playing with the faith of millions of Hindus" while questioning the process of the ongoing investigation into the case.

Moitra alleged that the same Ram Mandir Trust which has been accused of allowing this alleged theft to take place under its watch is conducting the SIT inquiry, the report of which was to be submitted to Sanjay Prasad, the Principal Secretary of the Uttar Pradesh Government, who is himself a member of the same Trust.

Demanding why no FIR was registered when the alleged theft first came to light, Moitra said reports of eight arrests only surfaced later. "Who are they? They are merely low-level counting staff, some of whom are reportedly employed by a security agency in Varanasi," she alleged.

AYODHYA RAM TEMPLE 'DONATION THEFT' PROBE

'Negligence', 'lack of supervision': SIT flags 'lapses' by ex-trustee Anil Mishra

Prelim report does not name Champat Rai, the ex-general secy of temple trust

Bhupendra Pandey & Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 7

THE SPECIAL Investigation Team (SIT) probing the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya has flagged the role of former trustee Anil Mishra, holding him responsible for alleged negligence and lack of supervision in the counting process.

In its nine-page preliminary report, a copy of which was seen by The Indian Express, the SIT said Mishra was also involved in recommending the appointment of six of the eight accused named in the FIR and arrested.

Mishra did not respond to calls seeking comment.

The report does not name Champat Rai, who resigned as general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra following the controversy.

On Monday, the Trust announced a sweeping organisational overhaul, including leadership changes and the creation of a new chief executive officer (CEO) post: It accepted the resignations of Rai and Mishra, and appointed senior RSS functionary and retired Indian Forest

Service (IFoS) officer Krishna Mohan as interim General Secretary.

Sources said a majority of the trustees in the meeting had opposed Rai's resignation. Trust Treasurer, Govind Giri, also said Rai cannot be held responsible for the negligence and the lapse in supervision.

The report flagged Mishra's role with regard to the arrangement governing the counting process of donations.

It said an MoU was executed between the Trust and the State Bank of India, prescribing a procedure for opening donation boxes, separating cash and coins, classifying valuable items, counting the currency, and depositing it in the bank in the joint presence of authorised representatives of the Trust and the Bank.

It said that on September 20, 2024, and February 6, 2025, Minutes of Meeting/Standard Operating Procedure (MoM/SOP) were prepared between the Trust and the Bank, which were signed by then SBI Branch Manager, Ayodhya, Govind Mishra, and Anil Mishra.

These documents, the report noted, clearly show that potential weaknesses and risks had



A view of the Ram Temple premises in Ayodhya on Tuesday; (left) Anil Mishra. ANI



entry and exit

According to the SIT report, the February 2025 SOP stated that the responsibility for maintaining transparency and authenticity of the counting process would rest with the Trust.

The investigation, however, found that these security measures were not implemented. This was not merely a technical or procedural lapse, but a deliberate act of negligence that created circumstances for the alleged theft/misappropriation, the SIT report has stated.

It said Mishra, who represented the Trust in drawing up the September 2024 arrangement and the February 2025 guidelines with the bank, was expected to ensure that safeguards were enforced. The report noted that little evidence of

been identified in advance and security measures prescribed to prevent them.

- These included:
- Preparing a list of offering/donation boxes
 - Not shifting any offering/donation box without written permission
 - Shift-wise counting
 - Deployment of a fixed number of counting personnel
 - Biometric attendance
 - Hundi-wise counting, not mixing amounts of different hundis
 - Prescribed dress code
 - Frisking at the time of

Key findings: 70 'thefts', frisking protocol ignored, CCTV gaps and flawed counting

Bhupendra Pandey & Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 7

70 INCIDENTS of 'thefts' identified, frisking protocol ignored, counting lapses found: In its nine-page preliminary report, the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing alleged donation theft at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya has flagged a series of failures in supervision, CCTV monitoring, and cash-counting procedures.

Here are the key findings:

Supervisory lapses

The SIT found that several personnel involved in the counting process failed to comply with prescribed security protocols. It flagged serious supervisory failures that, it said, created conditions conducive to the alleged criminal acts.

The probe team raised serious concerns over individuals controlling the keys of donation boxes or managing access-related arrangements without any clear written authorisation, including accused Ramshankar Yadav alias Tinnu, who is known to be close to Champat Rai, who resigned as general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra.

The report also held accused Subhash Srivastava, the counting-in-charge and officer supervising the opening of the boxes arrested in the case, responsible for permitting this informal arrangement to continue.



Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust Treasurer Govind Dev Guru shows items donated to the Ram Temple, in Ayodhya on Monday. PTI

CCTV gaps

The report identified major weaknesses in CCTV surveillance and record retention. While cameras were installed in the counting room, Trust personnel allegedly failed to monitor live footage effectively.

Recordings were preserved for only 45 days — from April 27 to June 6 — despite earlier audit recommendations that footage be retained for 180 days. During this limited period, investigators identified 70 instances of alleged theft or embezzlement.

The SIT said the alleged pilferage may have begun even before April 27, but the absence of earlier footage made it impossible to establish the extent of any prior theft.

Available footage, it said, repeatedly showed some employees engaged in counting

concealing bundles of currency notes and loose cash inside their clothes, pockets, shoes, or other hidden locations.

Security failures

A series of security failures allowed the alleged thefts to go undetected, it said.

- Staff were not adequately frisked while entering or leaving the counting room
- The prescribed dress code was not strictly enforced
- Personal belongings were not effectively barred
- Donations were not counted separately for each hundi
- Denomination-wise records were not properly maintained.

SOP not followed during counting

The SIT also pointed to poor oversight, noting that these

lapses continued despite representatives of both the Trust and the bank being present during the counting exercise.

It also raised concerns over changes to frisking norms. Under an arrangement introduced in September 2024, all personnel entering or exiting the counting room were subject to security checks. However, a Standard Operating Procedure issued on February 6, 2025, diluted this requirement, allowing checks only at regular intervals or on a random basis.

The SIT said the circumstances in which the rule was changed warranted closer examination, especially since even these limited checks were allegedly not carried out.

Counting process flawed

The SIT also found widespread violations of prescribed procedures for handling cash and valuables across all three modes of offerings (hundis, counters, sanctum), including poor documentation, mixing of offerings, and weak chain-of-custody controls.

During the investigation, the report noted, it was found that serious deficiencies existed at the very initial stage of this process.

Although a system of box-wise recording and counting had been prescribed, in practice, the contents of different hundis were mixed together before counting.

sustained oversight, regular review, or effective supervision was found. The preliminary findings further pointed to the alleged involvement of six accused — Avinash Shukla, Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh Pandey and Ramashankar Mishra — in the suspected theft and diversion of cash during the counting of donations.

The report recommended that a criminal case be registered against the six under relevant provisions dealing with theft, misappropriation, breach of trust, common intention, conspiracy and other offences.

The SIT, the report noted, placed particular responsibility on accused Subhash Srivastava, a retired bank employee who was the Trust-appointed in-charge of the counting room. It noted that the alleged thefts occurred inside the counting room and that the failure to ensure regular frisking of staff was a critical lapse.

The report stated that the eighth accused, Ram Shankar Yadav alias Tinnu Yadav, Rai's former driver, retained custody of keys to hundis across the temple complex without formal authorisation and had recommended his relative, Manish Kumar Yadav, for counting duty, thereby granting him access to the process where the alleged misappropriation took place.

Charges are baseless, will respond after final SIT report: Champat Rai

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

A DAY after his resignation from the post of Ram Temple Trust general secretary was accepted, Champat Rai on Tuesday said that charges levelled against him in the alleged theft of donations were "baseless" and promised to give a "point-by-point response" after the SIT submits its final report.

In a letter to Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra, Rai wrote, "Since June 7, various kinds of rumours and discussions have been circulating regarding a theft committed during the counting of the donation boxes... Many people have levelled baseless personal allegations against me. I have chosen to maintain silence. In the July 6 meeting of the Temple Trust, the preliminary report of the SIT (Special Investigation Team) was presented. This report has now become public. Although it was 'highly confidential', I assure all of you that after the final report of the SIT is released, I will give my point-by-point response to all the rumors. The entire truth will come to light".

Earlier this month, the UP government had formed an SIT to probe into the alleged theft of cash and valuables offered by devotees at the Ram Temple.

• BRIEFLY



The elephant that fell into a well in Ernakulam in Kerala, Tuesday PTI

KERALA

Wild elephant falls into a well in Ernakulam, rescued hours later

A WILD elephant fell into a well in Malayattoor area of Ernakulam district early Tuesday and was brought out several hours later after rescue efforts were initially obstructed by residents, officials said. "Residents are obstructing the rescue efforts, raising concerns about repeated instances of human-animal conflict in the area..." an official said. Residents claimed the elephant had injuries to its trunk and, therefore, could not forage for food on its own, thus it kept entering residential areas. They claimed if the elephant was allowed to return to the forest, it might come back to the residential area in search for food, and demanded it be tranquilised and taken for treatment. Following assurances that steps would be taken to curb human-animal conflict, they allowed the elephant to be rescued, an official said. PTI

Woman staffer stabbed at Goa health centre

A WOMAN staffer, of the Government Hospital and research centre in North Goa's Tuem, was allegedly stabbed multiple times by a man on Tuesday, said police. The accused man has been arrested. Police said the man entered the government health centre, and allegedly approached the woman staffer, before attacking her with a knife. "Some locals overpowered him and handed him over to the police," the officer said. "We are lodging an FIR for attempt-to-murder. According to the victim's brother, the accused knew their family and held enmity against her," said police. ENS

MP woman gives birth to 4 in auto, all newborns die

A WOMAN gave birth to four babies in an auto-rickshaw while being taken to a hospital for delivery in Madhya Pradesh's Mandla district on Tuesday, but the newborns died soon after. The woman's husband said if an ambulance was made available on time, the babies could have survived, while health officials said the infants died due to premature delivery and incomplete development. When asked about the allegations of lack of ambulance, Mandla DM told PTI that he had not received any complaint so far and if received, they would investigate the matter and take necessary action. PTI

Handling of Badrinath donations under probe, office staffer suspended

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, July 7

A STAFFER in the office of the Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee chairman has been suspended following allegations of irregularities in the handling of donations and offerings at Badrinath Dham.

The Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee (BKTC) has taken disciplinary action by suspending Pramod Nautiyal, a personal assistant posted in the chairman's office.

According to the order issued by the committee, a show-cause notice was served to Nautiyal on July 3, after allegations of irregularities in the discharge of his official duties came to light. A four-member inquiry committee was constituted to investigate the matter. The preliminary report of the inquiry committee, along with the explanation by Nautiyal, purportedly found the alle-

gations prima facie substantiated. In its report, the committee recommended disciplinary action against the employee and said that allowing him to continue in his present post could potentially influence or hamper the investigation.

Nautiyal has been attached to the BKTC office in Joshimath in Chamoli. During this period, he will not be permitted to leave the headquarters without prior approval from the competent authority and will be required to extend full cooperation in the inquiry and disciplinary proceedings, a communication from the government said.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, BKTC chairman Hemant Dwivedi said, "The man suspended has been an employee during the term of three former chairpersons. Currently, this action was taken so that no tampering can be done during the investigation."

Lab-grown placenta to help study how drugs, nutrients pass down from mother to baby

Purnima Sah
Mumbai, July 7

FOR DECADES, doctors have had to prescribe medicines during pregnancy with little evidence on whether many of them reach the developing foetus via the placenta or not. Or if it is indeed an effective barrier against microbes and toxins. Now, researchers from Mumbai's ICMR-National Institute for Research on Women's Health (ICMR-NIR-WoH) and the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay (IIT Bombay) have developed a placenta-on-chip that closely mimics the human placenta.

This offers scientists a new way to study how drugs, nutrients, pollutants and infectious agents pass from mother to baby. Although it remains a laboratory research tool that requires further validation, researchers

E. EXPLAINED

Why is a placenta model significant?

The placenta is one of the most critical organs in pregnancy. Yet, it is one of the least understood. How well the placenta functions influences foetal growth, pregnancy outcomes and the safety of medicines prescribed during pregnancy.

believe it could accelerate the development of pregnancy-safe therapeutics and provide new insights into conditions such as gestational diabetes, foetal growth restriction and pre-eclampsia (high blood pressure

that damages organs).

The human-cell-based platform recreates several key structural and functional features of the placenta and could reduce dependence on animal models, which often fail to accurately replicate human pregnancy. The study was led by researchers Anshul Bhide and Sourav Mukherjee under the supervision of Professor Deepak Modi (ICMR-NIRWoH) and Professor Abhijit Majumder (IIT Bombay).

The placenta-on-chip is a transparent plastic device containing a porous membrane on which researchers grow human placental cells alongside human endothelial cells, which line blood vessels. Together, these recreate the interface through which nutrients, hormones and other molecules are exchanged between mother and foetus.

Unlike many existing pla-

centa-on-chip systems that require sophisticated microfluidic equipment, the Mumbai team's model is a static two-chamber platform that can be used in a standard laboratory, making it simpler, reproducible and more accessible.

Bhide said: "We tried to recreate the placenta to provide researchers a more humanised platform to better understand pregnancy and improve maternal and foetal health." The project that began during the Covid-19 pandemic took more than three-and-a-half years to complete, and has been built entirely using human cells. He said the team demonstrated how the device reproduces the placenta's cellular architecture, produces the pregnancy hormone beta-human chorionic gonadotropin (β-hCG), mimics glucose transport from mother to foetus.

{ GIRISH BHARADWAJ • 1950-2026 }

Man who built hundreds of low-cost hanging bridges, connecting remotest parts of India

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, July 7

PADMA SHRI awardee Girish Bharadwaj — popularly known as the 'Bridge Man of India' for constructing hundreds of low-cost hanging bridges, connecting the remotest parts of India — passed away on Tuesday in Karnataka. He was 76 years old.

Bharadwaj was admitted to a private hospital in Sullia in Karnataka's Dakshina Kannada district due to a cardiac condition, after which he died Tuesday.

A graduate in mechanical engineering, Bharadwaj chose to stay in rural parts of the country. His work brought hundreds of isolated villages to the mainstream — connecting the rest of the nation with places



Girish Bharadwaj was known as the 'Bridge Man of India'

where people otherwise had no way to cross rivers or canals except by swimming or boats. Bharadwaj devised his own solutions to suit the remote terrain — he built suspension footbridges which offered a simple and practical causeway for

many isolated communities.

After his low-cost small bridges became a hit in rural areas, the government was eager to utilise Bharadwaj's design to construct hanging bridges.

Upon completing his mechanical engineering degree in 1973, Bharadwaj set up a workshop in Sullia but started engaging beyond regular metal works. The Dakshina Kannada district usually receives heavy rainfall due to its geography. A young Girish then saw the plight of the villagers who would be deprived of all modes of road transportation during rain, instead relying on making life-threatening attempts to walk across swollen rivers. Facing issues with connectivity, some children also had to drop

out of schools.

Bharadwaj decided to find a cost-efficient solution for this.

In 1989, he built his first hanging footbridge over the Payaswini River at Aramburu in Sullia — a modest, budget-friendly structure that would go on to define his life's work. That single bridge marked only the start; over the following decades, Bharadwaj constructed more than 300 such bridges across Karnataka, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh and Odisha, gaining him the reputation of the 'Bridge Man of India'.

As Bharadwaj continued his work, the Government of India honoured him with the country's fourth-highest civilian award, the Padma Shri, in 2017.

‘We block drains, grab land’: High Court says Mumbai flooding ‘our own creation’

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, July 7

THE BOMBAY High Court said Tuesday that citizens should stop blaming the civic body alone for Mumbai’s chronic monsoon waterlogging, observing that encroachments, clogged drains, and misuse of public infrastructure have made the situation “our own creation”.

The bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra V Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad also issued notice to the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) on the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC’s) plea seeking land to widen a road in Mandala village on the Sion-Trombay stretch, after the civic body said it had removed encroachments from its portion and the remaining land belonged to the DAE.

“We are destined to see rain-water on Mumbai roads... We cannot help it,” Acting CJ Ghuge said.

“We are good at grabbing lands. We have an uncanny knack for grabbing lands. We put all the dirt and material inside that, we block the gutters. We have pavement blocks. They are inaugurated by people’s representatives and then they become parking lots. One small spell of rain blocks the roads in Mumbai. It’s our own creation,” Justice Ghuge said.

“When the corporation comes for demolition, you say ‘give me seven days’ notice’. Then, suddenly, the law books are opened, and you start reading the law. When you grab the land, nobody reads the law. So that is how things are in Mumbai. We are destined to see rain-water on the road with everything clogged. Cannot help it,” Justice Ghuge added.

PMO takes stock of El Nino impact, monitoring level & preparedness

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 7

TAKING STOCK of possible impact of El Nino on various sectors, the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) on Tuesday directed that the overall situation should be continuously monitored and the impact of the monsoon/delayed monsoon on vulnerable districts must be assessed in co-ordination with states so that remedial action can be taken up when necessary.

The directions came during a high-level meeting presided by P K Mishra, Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister. During the meeting, the progress of the kharif season and possible impact due to El Nino on other sectors of the economy was reviewed.

Secretaries and senior officials of more than 15 ministries, including Agriculture, Power, Co-operation, Health and Family Welfare and Economic Affairs, attended the meeting.

During the meeting, IMD officials presented the overall rainfall situation up to July 7.

“Director General of Meteorology updated on the status of monsoon coverage in the country and the possible impact of El Nino. There was delay in onset of monsoon by about 10 days in Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Maharashtra... The first week of July has shown above normal monsoon. Weak to moderate El Nino is expected in July and August,” the PMO said in a statement.

Landslide hits Wayanad tunnel project days after Collector’s warning on soil pile, 3 killed

Shaju Philip & Nikhila Henry
Meppadi (Wayanad), Hyderabad, July 7

DAYS AFTER the District Collector of Kerala’s Wayanad had called a halt to the construction of the Wayanad-Kozhikode twin tunnel project and directed that accumulated soil at the site be removed, a landslide struck the area on Tuesday, leaving three people dead and seven missing.

The incident took place in the Meenakshi area of the district, just 4 km away from Chooralmala, one of the two villages that were largely swept away by devastating landslides on July 30, 2024, which had killed around 300 people. The three victims are migrant workers identified as crane operator Chandra Bhan from Madhya Pradesh, civil foreman Bikash Kumar from Bihar and labourer Annol from Jharkhand.

The construction work at the Wayanad side of the tunnel had been halted since June 20 following a direction from District Collector Meghashree D R, who is also the chairperson of the District Disaster Management Authority. However, around two dozen people, including workers, security staff and supervisors, remained at the site for the day-to-day management of the work site.

Before this, preparatory work Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+4+2RvD_RG9mJlMzg1

was underway for the construction of the tunnel. The work included cutting the hill into benched slopes, which were reinforced with a soil nail wall. As a result of this work, a large heap of soil had accumulated at the side of the proposed tunnel’s opening. The collector had called for construction to be stopped until the soil was removed. However, ministers and officials accused the contractors of not removing the soil in time, leading to the disaster.

Bhopal-based Dileep Buildcon, which is constructing the twin tunnels, said in a statement that it had followed all regulations and attributed the incident to “exceptionally heavy rainfall”.

In the landslide, a massive chunk of loose soil came down from the hill. Workers, who were at the site and on the road between the villages of Meppadi and Chooralmala, were buried under debris, which flowed down Meenakshi river, wiping out a masjid and a house nearby.

Eye witness Musthafa, who runs a tea shop near the construction site, said, “The work had been stopped for around three weeks. However, heavy rain had caused the soil dumped from the construction work to come down on the road. Yesterday, the area witnessed heavy rain, and the road got covered with sludge. A few workers were



Debris flows down a river after the landslide in Wayanad on Tuesday. PTI

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

cleaning the bridge by pumping water from a tanker truck. At around 11.05 am, we heard a frightening roar and in a few seconds, everything was over. A bus loaded with passengers had passed the bridge a few minutes before the tragedy.” Musthafa sustained a minor injury while trying to escape from the spot.

Rescue workers, including personnel from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), state police, and the fire force, as well as volunteers, faced the uphill task of searching the

hillside covered in sludge and debris. Little progress has been made in removing the sludge from the Meenakshi bridge, leaving people living in Chooralmala and nearby areas cut off.

After reviewing the situation at the headquarters of the state disaster management authority, Chief Minister V D Sathesaran said contractors had been told to remove the soil, which had been left over after cutting down the hill and kept in a heap, from the site on June 20. “The Wayanad District Collector and the Dis-

aster Management Authority had given a direction in this regard. Later, the Public Works Minister had raised the same demand to the contractor, but they did not comply,” the CM said. He added the sludge from the site would be removed at the earliest.

Agriculture Minister and Kalpetta MLA T Siddique also blamed the contractor, claiming, “Unscientific dumping of loose soil at project site led to tragedy. This is not a natural landslide, but a man-made landslide.”

Kerala’s Minister for En-

Western Ghats hit by extreme rain, Lonavala gets highest 48-hr shower

Anjali Marar
Bengaluru, July 7

EXCEPTIONALLY HEAVY rain battered the Western Ghats of Maharashtra for the second consecutive day, with several ghat regions recording over 500 mm of rainfall in 24 hours leading up to Tuesday morning.

Since Sunday, districts across Maharashtra, including Mumbai, Pune, Raigad, Palghar, Thane, and Nashik, have witnessed intense rainfall, with several locations reporting record-breaking rainfall.

Lonavala, the popular hill station located around 80 km from Pune, recorded 620 mm of rainfall Tuesday, taking its 48-hour rainfall total to 1,290 mm — the highest on record.

The previous extreme rain event in the region took place on August 2 and 3, 1953, when Lonavala received 882 mm of rainfall over 48 hours, with the highest 24-hour rainfall recorded at 493 mm. Another significant 48-hour rainfall event occurred between August 13 and 15, 1983, when Lonavala received 507 mm, according to the 2015 report titled PMP Atlas for West Flowing Rivers of Western Ghats, prepared jointly by the India Meteorological Department (IMD) and the Central Water Commission.

In Raigad district, Bhira recorded 512 mm of rainfall Tuesday, taking its two-day total to 1,121 mm. Other locations in the region that witnessed extremely heavy rainfall included Davdi (688 mm), Tamhini (570 mm), Dongerwadi (423 mm), Shirgaon (420 mm), Walwhan (392 mm), Khand and Mulshi (312 mm each), and Nilshi (307 mm).

“The Southwest Monsoon has been vigorous over Konkan, Goa, and Central Maharashtra,” the IMD said.

The country had a 40% rainfall deficiency for the season at the end of June, but heavy rainfall in the last few days has brought this down to 17% now. At that time, about 80% of India’s geographical area had a rainfall deficiency.



Waterlogging in Virar has largely subsided, although a few pockets remain flooded on Tuesday, following heavy rainfall. AKASH PATIL

EXPLAINED

Wait continues for some regions

Although the normal date for the monsoon to cover the entire country is July 8, even with the latest advance on Tuesday, the monsoon onset stands delayed for Bikaner, Barmer, Jaipur and Kutch, where the normal onset to be realised was latest by July 5. The IMD has said that in its last phase of advance, the monsoon was likely to cover the entire country in the next 2 to 3 days. If realised, this year’s monsoon advance over the country could be the most delayed since 2021 (July 12).

As on Tuesday, only about 34% of land area has a deficit. Lakshadweep, Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Odisha and Tamil Nadu have excess rainfall for the season until now.

Maharashtra, after all the heavy rainfall in the past three days, has moved into the normal category.

The current spell of intense rainfall was triggered by the depression that had formed earlier over central India and traversed through Odisha and Chhattisgarh. On Tuesday, it weakened

into a well-marked low-pressure area and remained near east Madhya Pradesh. The IMD said the system is likely to move slowly west-northwestwards across Madhya Pradesh and adjoining Southwest Uttar Pradesh, weakening further by Thursday.

Under its influence, light to moderate rainfall is expected over parts of Madhya Pradesh, Konkan, Goa, central Maharashtra, Vidarbha, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, and Odisha until Wednesday.

The Met department has warned of extremely heavy rainfall (more than 200mm in 24 hours) over the sub-Himalayan West Bengal and Sikkim on Wednesday with an overall increase in the rainfall activity and heavy spells over north India during the next 3 days.

While parts of Central and Western India, including Mumbai and Pune, have been witnessing intense rainfall over the past 48 hours, the Southwest Monsoon is yet to reach several parts of extreme north-west India.

The monsoon advance remained stalled during July 2-6. On Tuesday, it covered Gujarat and advanced into some more parts of Rajasthan, Haryana and more areas of north Arabian Sea. The northern limit of the monsoon passed through Barmer, Jodhpur, Rajgarh and Bhatinda.

NEET-UG 2027 at 1,000 centres over 5-6 days; ‘top to bottom’ NTA revamp

Shyamal Yadav
New Delhi, July 7

THE NEET-UG for admission to undergraduate medical education will from next year be a computer-based test conducted across five-six days at around 1,000 centres in 500 cities, mainly government institutions such as Kendriya Vidyalayas, with around 5 lakh candidates to be accommodated each day, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Government is also set to overhaul the National Testing Agency (NTA), the nodal autonomous body that conducts NEET-UG apart from other entrance tests to higher educational institutions — a revamp that will cover the agency’s organisation, infrastructure, technology and processes, sources told this newspaper.

“We are going to change the entire organisation of the NTA, from top to bottom,” sources said, adding that the exercise is expected to be completed before October. There are around 150 posts sanctioned in the NTA.

These proposals by the Ministry of Education come in the



The exam will be conducted in 500 cities, with around 5 lakh candidates to be accommodated each day. FILE

wake of the paper leak that led to this year’s NEET-UG being held again, after the first exam on May 3, in which around 22 lakh candidates appeared, was cancelled, triggering outrage, protests and a CBI probe.

Sources said the move is based on recommendations of the high-powered seven-member committee headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan, constituted by the Centre in 2024 in the wake of a paper leak that year.

On May 15, while announcing the NEET-UG retest on June 21, Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan had said

that the exam, which has been a pen-and-paper exercise, would be computer-based from next year. Pradhan had said the switch was based on a recommendation of the Radhakrishnan committee — but the suggestion had not been implemented so far.

According to the plan for next year’s NEET-UG, sources said, most of the centres being identified are government institutions, including Kendriya Vidyalayas and Navodaya Vidyalayas, while “some reputed private institutions may also be made centres”.

Each of these centres will

‘NEET exam over’: HC allows unblocking of Cockroach Janta Party’s social media handle

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 7

THE DELHI High Court allowed the unblocking of Cockroach Janta Party’s X account after the Centre Tuesday conceded that it has no objection to the unblocking.

The government orally added that it wants people to be more “circumspect”. Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta, appearing for the government,

told Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, “I have no difficulty (with unblocking of the account). I just want everyone to be more circumspect.”

The concession from the government comes with the conclusion of National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test Undergraduate (NEET-UG) re-examination.

SG Mehta said, “It was blocked at a time when NEET examination was to take place.

Lakhs of students were to appear... several posts (on X) which would’ve created chaos among students and parents. Now the examination is over.”

The re-examination was necessitated after the original NEET-UG 2026 was cancelled following allegations of a paper leak — an issue that became a flashpoint for public anger and triggered a protest movement, including demonstrations by the newly formed CJP, which

strict compliance with all applicable engineering, safety and environmental approvals and protocols. Given its location in an ecologically sensitive region, the project is subject to multiple regulatory oversight and monitoring mechanisms, including supervision by the Supreme Court-appointed Central Empowered Committee, and all excavated material is handled in accordance with the approved methodology. With such additional and strict compliance procedures, the room for technical error remains very limited. We remain fully committed to cooperating with the probe and will continue to share verified information as it becomes available. Our focus remains on supporting rescue efforts and standing with affected families during this difficult time.”

Konkan Railway Corporation is the implementing agency for the project, which is expected to be completed in four years. Construction of the tube tunnels has been awarded to Bhopal-based Dilip Buildcon, while the approach roads and bridges in the project will be constructed by Kolkata-based Royal Construct.

Konkan Railway Corporation and Royal Construct did not respond to requests for comment. The proposed 8.11-km tunnel is estimated to cost around Rs 2,400 crore.

‘Appropriate, fair, just’: Families of those killed & injured in Ahmedabad blasts on HC verdict

Parimal A Dabhi & Leena Misra
Ahmedabad, July 7

YASH VYAS was just eight years old when he lost his father Dushyant and older brother Rohan in the bomb blasts that ripped through the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital’s trauma centre on July 26, 2008. He survived with injuries.

Welcoming the Gujarat High Court verdict, Vyas, 28, told *The Indian Express* on Tuesday, “The judgment is appropriate. My father, my brother and many others were killed in the blasts.” His father was an employee at the hospital and was at

work when he was killed.

Vyas earlier told this newspaper, “The two of us (he and his brother) were with our father to learn how to ride a bicycle in the open area there. We were about to return home when my father got a call seeking help for a patient in reaching the Trauma Centre. We reached the centre when the blast occurred.”

Nearly 22 bombs went off in a coordinated manner on that day, killing 56 people and injuring over 200. A special trial court had awarded death sentences to 38 of the 49 convicted persons in 2022, sentencing the rest to life imprisonment. The Gujarat High Court upheld the

lower court’s verdict on Tuesday while hearing an appeal challenging it.

Jashvant Patel (59) was among those who died at Ahmedabad Civil Hospital in the terror blast on July 26, 2008.

Patel was running a garage in the Asarva area and had gone to help the victims of the blasts that had taken place in various parts of the Ahmedabad city. When he was at the hospital a blast took place in front of the trauma centre.

His son, Amrish (49) runs the same garage and now lives in the Vastrapur area of the city.

Amrish said, “My father was part of a group of people in the



The Gujarat High Court on Tuesday. BHUPENDRA RANA

area who used to aid the patients at Civil Hospital. On learning of the blasts in the city, he went to the hospital, where

he was seriously injured. I got to know about his death nearly two hours after the blast.”

“My uncle was there at the

hospital when my father was injured. As there was chaos at Civil Hospital then, he was being taken to the nearby Rajasthan Hospital. However, he died on the way,” Amrish added.

He added, “It is good that the culprits have been punished by the High Court. So many people died.”

According to Amrish, at the relevant time, they were awarded compensation of around Rs 10 lakh by the Central and state governments then, apart from the Congress party.

“The Central government gave us compensation of Rs 4.5 lakhs. Then the Gujarat government has given Rs 5 lakh and

the Congress party gave us compensation of Rs 1 lakh,” he said.

“Even if it was delayed, the important thing is justice has been delivered,” says Vijay Modi, whose mother, then 55-years old, was a vendor in the Sarangpur marketplace and suffered a leg injury. Bombs had gone off in several public places, including Sarangpur, Khadia, Raipur and Isanpur, in addition to the Ahmedabad Civil Hospital and the municipal corporation-run LG Hospital. “My mother was treated at VS hospital,” says Vijay Modi, adding that she died in 2016.

As an 18-year-old boy at the

time, Darshan Modi remembers how panic had struck their neighbourhood in the Khadia area of the Walled City that Saturday. “My mother had gone to the market in Sarangpur to buy vegetables and we heard about the blasts. There was chaos. She was bleeding on one leg and the doctors told us she had been hit by shrapnel. ““We are lucky that she survived... It must be tough for those who lost their loved ones,” says Darshan Modi, now an IT professional. His mother, now 58 years old, lives abroad with his brother.

“I think the High Court verdict is very fair,” he says.

HC stays FRRO order to deport ‘Bangladeshi immigrant’

Mustafa Plumber
Bengaluru, July 7

THE KARNATAKA High Court on Monday stayed the deportation order of the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO), Bengaluru, involving a man detained as an alleged Bangladeshi national, after he claimed he is an Indian citizen by birth and a victim of mistaken identity.

Justice Suraj Govindaraj, hearing a petition filed by Abdul Rahim, also directed the FRRO to verify the detenu's identity, noting that he claimed to be the same person who was convicted by a sessions court in Uttar Pradesh in a case alleging illegal entry from Bangladesh—a conviction that is under appeal be-

fore the Allahabad High Court. “FRRO is directed to secure instruction about another proceeding stated to be pending in the Allahabad High Court, and whether the proceedings in that matter and the impugned order relating to the present matter are related to the very same person. Relist on July 14. Respondents are restrained from deporting the petitioner till the next date,” the court said in its interim order.

Rahim, in his petition, has stated that he was born on April 14, 1979, at New Seemapur in Delhi, and has lived, worked and carried on business in India throughout his life.

On March 5 this year, he was detained by Bengaluru police during a drive to identify alleged

illegal Bangladeshi immigrants and was handed over to the FRRO. The same day, the FRRO passed an order under Section 7(2)(f) of the Foreigners Act, 2025, read with Paragraph 8 of the Immigration and Foreigners Order, restricting his movement and directing him to reside at the Utile Foundation detention centre in Kothanur, Bengaluru.

The FRRO order proceeds on the assumption that Rahim is a foreign national and identifies him as one “Md. Rahim Howladar, s/o Md. Motalab Howladar”.

Appearing for Rahim, advocate Clifton D Rozario argued that his client is an Indian citizen by birth. “We have produced the birth certificate, passport, election identity card, Aadhaar card, PAN card, driving licence and several other public documents evi-

dencing his identity and citizenship, and documents relating to his family members establishing his lineage and longstanding roots within India,” he submitted.

The petition contends that the detention order was passed without notice, without an opportunity of hearing, and without any meaningful inquiry in violation of Articles 14, 15, 21 and 22 of the Constitution.

In a case registered in 2010, Rahim was convicted under Section 14A(b) of the Foreigners Act, 1946, for allegedly entering and staying in India without valid documents. On June 8, 2012, the Additional District and Sessions Judge, Ghazialbad, convicted him on the allegation that he was a Bangladeshi national named “Abdul Rahim, s/o Shah Jamal, resi-

dent of Bagerhat, Bangladesh”.

According to the petition, the conviction rested principally on the statutory burden under the Foreigners Act, which requires the accused to establish citizenship, and on the finding that the documents he produced were not satisfactory. Rahim challenged the conviction before the Allahabad High Court in 2012; the appeal was admitted, and he was granted bail. The appeal remains pending.

Rozario argued that the FRRO's detention order amounts to double jeopardy, violating Article 20 of the Constitution, which mandates that no person shall be prosecuted and punished for the same offence more than once—a protection available under Article 20(3) of the Constitution. The matter is slated for hearing on July 14.

Lucknow lawyer murder: 24 yrs on, family’s wait for justice ends in conviction

3 awarded life in prison, 3 other accused had died during the trial

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 7

NEARLY 24 years after former Lucknow Bar Association president Indradev Singh was shot dead near the Lucknow district court, three of the accused were sentenced to life on Tuesday.

Singh's wife, Nayantara, and his daughter, Laxmi Singh, who now serves as the police commissioner of Gautam Buddha Nagar, were present in the courtroom when the life sentences for Vikram Yadav alias Kalia, Panna Singh and Brijesh Yadav were pronounced.

After Special CBI Court Judge Vayu Nandan Mishra delivered the sentences, the mother-daughter left the courtroom in silence. Police personnel escorted them through the complex to their waiting vehicle. Holding Nayantara's hand, Laxmi walked beside her, supporting her mother who has difficulties walking now.

This brings to a close the high-profile murder case, stemming from a land dispute. A 2000-batch IPS officer, Laxmi Singh, was 28 at the time of the murder, which had rocked the city's legal community, leading to protests and roadblocks.

After her father's murder in Lucknow, Laxmi Singh moved to Uttar Pradesh after then Chief



Bar president Indradev Singh was shot dead near Lucknow district court in August 2002

Minister Mayawati agreed to her transfer on a three-year deputation. Originally a West Bengal cadre IPS officer, she had sought the transfer.

In the afternoon of August 8, 2002, senior advocate Indradev Singh, then 57, met Nayantara and Digvijay, his son—who is now a teacher—near the Lucknow district court, planning to ride to Aminabad to shop for upcoming festivals. Singh had set off on his bike, with his wife and son following him on another two-wheeler and had reached the Kaiserbagh Telephone Exchange, barely 500 metres from the court, when two assailants on another bike ambushed him.

As per the prosecution, before Singh could react, one of the two bike-borne men opened fire on him at close range. A bullet struck Singh in the neck, and he lost control of his bike and collapsed on the road. Nayantara and Digvijay, then 24, rushed to his side and, along with other passers-by, took him to a hospital. But it was too late. The doctors declared him dead.

On June 30 this year, the three accused were held guilty of

murder and criminal conspiracy. Vikram Yadav, already in jail in another case, and Panna Singh and Brijesh Yadav, who had been out on bail, were taken into custody after their convictions, with their sentencing scheduled for July 7. Three other accused—alleged key conspirator Manna Lal Gupta, Ved Prakash Lohia alias Neta and Chhote Lal alias Chhotu Yadav—had died during the trial.

CBI counsel K P Singh said the court sentenced the three convicts to life imprisonment and imposed a total fine of Rs 1.5 lakh on them. The court also directed that 80 per cent of the fine amount be paid to the complainant as compensation.

Defence Counsel Ashish Tripathi said they would file an appeal against the judgment.

‘Conspiracy to kill’

After Indradev's killing, Nayantara lodged a complaint at Kaiserbagh police station, alleging the murder stemmed from a long-running dispute between her husband and his former associate, Manna Lal.

The investigation was initially handled by a Special Investigation Team constituted by the Lucknow police. Amid mounting public pressure, the probe was transferred to the CBI later in 2002. According to the prosecution, the CBI found that the murder was the fallout of a dispute over a parcel of land on Sitapur Road.

Complainant's counsel Ram Kumar Yadav said Indradev had purchased the land and entrusted Manna Lal with developing it into plots for sale.

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

Gem Bid Notice 10/2026

Dated : 06.07.2026

Gem Bid Notice

Gem bid no. : GEM/2026/B/7685691 dt. 03.07.2026 Qty. : 5200 pairs

Description : Safety Footwear For Railway Tractmen.

EMD (Rs) : 101230/-

Gem bid Opening Date : 28.07.26

Note : (1) The complete information of above GEM Bid are available on GEM website i.e. <http://www.gem.gov.in> (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Bid. For this purpose, Vendors are required to get themselves registered with GEM website. (3) Rates entered into financial rate page and duly signed digitally shall only be considered. Rates and any other financial entry in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight away ignored and shall not be considered. (4) Documents being attached should be signed on their body. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the GEM website may be approached. 1548/26 (C)

 North central railways  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in  CPRNC

**JHARKHAND URJA**

SANCHARAN NIGAM LIMITED
(CIN No. - U40108JH2013SGC001704)

GOVERNMENT OF JHARKHAND UNDERTAKING
Office: General Manager (CRITL/O.E), JUSNL Building,
Kusai Colony, Baranda, Ranchi - 834 002 (Jharkhand)
(E-mail: cecritl.jusnl@rediffmail.com, gm.critl@jusnl.in, Website: www.jusnl.in)

Addendum ofe-NIT No. 293/PR/JUSNL/2026-27

In the Tender Notice having e-NIT No. 293/PR/JUSNL/2026-27, invited for 'Repairing of Three (03) Nos. 50 MVA, 132/33 kV Power Transformer of ECE make at 132/33 kV GSS Deoghar, 220/132/33 kV GSS Godda and 132/33 kV GSS Chitra' is hereby modified as Addendum. The pre-bid meeting will be held on 10.07.2026 (Friday).

स्वहित एवं राष्ट्रहित में ऊर्जा बचाव। कृपया अपनी शिकायतों को 18003456570(कोल सेंटर) पर दर्ज करवायें।

PR No. 383106

Sd/-

PR 384251 Jharkhand Urja General Manager (CRITL/O.E)
Sancharan Nigam Ltd(26-27)#D JUSNL, Ranchi

**श्री गोविन्दराम सेकसरिया**

प्रौद्योगिकी एवं विज्ञान संस्थान

23, पार्क रोड, इन्दौर-452 003 (म.प्र.), फोन : 0731-2582112
2582121, 122, Website : www.sgsits.ac.in

क्रमांक : SSS/Mess/2026/599 दिनांक : 07.07.2026

मेस के संचालन हेतु ई-टेंडर प्रस्ताव आमंत्रण

संशोधन- पत्र (Corrigendum)

पूर्व प्रकाशित ई-निविदा क्रमांक 2026 DTE_516235_1 दस्तावेज में वर्णित शर्त क्रमांक Clause-3 को संशोधित किया गया है। निविदा प्रक्रिया में भाग लेने वाले सभी निविदाकारों को सूचित किया जाता है कि उक्त संशोधन संस्थान की वेबसाइट ([Website:www.sgsits.ac.in](http://www.sgsits.ac.in) एवं www.mptenders.gov.in) पर उपलब्ध है। निविदा की अन्य सभी शर्तें नियम एवं प्रावधान पूर्ववत् यथावत रहेंगे। निविदा दस्तावेज दिनांक 08.07.2026 को प्रातः 11:00 से दिनांक 15.07.2026 को सायं 05:00 बजे तक डाउनलोड किये जा सकते हैं। ऑनलाइन बिड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 15.07.2026 को सायं 05:00 बजे तक है।

म.प्र. माध्यम/126756/2026 निदेशक

IN THE COURT OF PRINCIPAL SESSIONS JUDGE BARAMULLA

Present:- Jawad Ahmad

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED (Section 82)

UT of J&K through Police Station Pattran
FIR No: 258/2013
U/S 420,467,468,471,120B RPC

VERSUS
Showkat Ah Malik and ors

Whereas, Chargesheet has been made before me that Showkat Ah Malik and Ors have committed the offence punishable under section 420,467,468,471,120B, RPC, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that Manzoor Ah Khan (Accused No. 4) S/O Gh Rasool Khan R/O Braripora Bandipora cannot be found, and Whereas, it has been shown to my satisfaction that said Manzoor Ah Khan (Accused No. 4) has absconded or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the warrant Therefore, Proclamation is hereby made that the said Manzoor Ah Khan S/O Gh Rasool Khan R/o Braripora Bandipora (Accused No. 4) is required to appear before this court on the next date of hearing i.e., 06-07-2026.

Date of Issue: 10-06-2026

Sd/-

Principal Sessions Judge
Baramulla

DIPK-2950/26 DATE 07.07.2026

**NORTHERN RAILWAY**

e-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

Name of work with its location	Part-B(U): Provision and application of composite high voltage insulated coating under girder bridges in DUK section inconnection with Strengthening of existing TRD assets in DUK section,
Approx. Cost of work	Rs.50,48,687.47/-
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs.1,01,000/-

E-Tender Bid Online Submission period	16.07.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 30.07.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time	30.07.2026 (15.00 hrs)
Fund Allocation	RRSK (PH-36)
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

E-Tender No.: 20-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated: 07.07.2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

2332/2026

**WESTERN RAILWAY**

Material Management Department

VARIOUS MATERIALS SUPPLY

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE No. S/35/2026 Date 03.07.2026

S. N.	Tender No.	Short Description of Items	Quantity	T. O. D.
288	22262053A	Modified Transition Screw Coupling	425 Nos.	05-Aug-26
289	23262350A	Upgraded High Capacity Draft Gear	2945 Nos.	04-Aug-26
290	30265001	IGBT Phase module S3P-3000FL + duct as per Siemens India Part No. 10636455	2 Nos.	03-Aug-26
291	22262342	Microprocessor Based Energy Cum Speed Monitoring System (ESMON)	30 Set	03-Aug-26
292	29255030	High End/Advanced ICU Critical Care Ventilator	4 Nos.	31-Jul-26
293	23261944	Secondary spring inner for LHB NAC	300 Nos.	30-Jul-26

Regarding detailed notice EMD, Purchase restrictions and detailed tender conditions, please visit website www.ireps.gov.in

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0337

GOVERNMENT OF MEGHALAYA

OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR OF HEALTH SERVICES

MEDICAL EDUCATION & RESEARCH (DME),

MEGHALAYA

PASTEUR HILLS, SHILLONG

Email ID: pasteurinstituteshil@gmail.com
Tel No. 0364-2591510/94851 06663

DHSME&R/SMC/Tender/V/24/2026/3874 Dtd: Shillong, the 7th July, 2026

NOTICE

The Government of Meghalaya invites sealed Bids from eligible bidders for the “Supply and Installation of Equipment/Items for the Departments of Microbiology, Pathology, Pharmacology and PSM (Community Medicine) as per NMC norms at Shillong Medical College, Shillong” under the Directorate of Health Services, Medical Education and Research (DME) Pasteur Hills Shillong, Meghalaya. Detailed Bid Documents, including eligibility criteria and submission guidelines, are available on the websites: www.meghealth.gov.in and www.nhmmeghalaya.nic.in.

Sd/-

Director of Health Services
Medical Education & Research (DME)
Meghalaya, Pasteur Hills, Shillong

M.I.P.R. No.- 1048
Dt. 7.7.26

**JAMSHEDPUR NOTIFIED AREA COMMITTEE**

New Kalimati Road, Sakchi-831001

E-mail ID-jnacjsr@gmail.com

Short E-Procurement Notice

Tender Notice

NIT No- JNAC/30/2026-27 Date-06.07.2026

1.	Name of the work	Waste Water Management System Drains- Nimbbhatta, Baridhi Basti and Bihari Basti Under Jamshedpur Notified Area Committee Jamshedpur. (7th Call)
2.	Estimated Cost (rs.)	Construction cost :- ₹ 6,81,74,316.00 Operation & Maintenance cost :- ₹ 50,35,648.00 Total cost :- ₹ 7,32,09,964.00
3.	Cost of Bid Document (INR)	INR 25,000/- (Twenty thousand Only) Non-Refundable
4.	Bid Security (INR)	Bid Security: Rs 7,32,100.00
5	(a). Time of Completion	1 year including one month of trial run.
(b)	Defect Liability Period	Defect liability period 1 years after satisfactory completion of project.
(c)	O&M Period	1 year after satisfactory completion of project.
6.	Date/Time of publication of tender on website	08.07.2026 at 12:00 PM
7.	Document downloading Start date	08.07.2026 at 12:00 PM
8.	Pre bid meeting date, Time & venue	09.07.2026 at 03:00 PM, JNAC Conference Hall
9.	Bid Submission Start date	10.07.2026 at 05:00 PM
10.	Bid Submission end date	24.07.2026 at 05:00 PM
11.	Bid Opening date	25.07.2026 at 05:00PM
12.	Mode of Submission of bids	E-tendering (http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in)
13.	Name and address of office inviting tender	Municipal Commissioner, Jamshedpur Notified Area Committee, Jamshedpur.
14.	Email ID of E-procurement cell	jnacjsr@gmail.com .

Note- 1. Only E-tender will be accepted, further details can be seen on website (<http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>)

PR 384323 Urban Development(26-27)#D

Municipal Commissioner,
Jamshedpur Notified Area Committee,
Jamshedpur.

**UNITED INDIA INSURANCE COMPANY LIMITED**
(A Govt. of India Undertaking) 100% share by govt of India
Head Office :- No. 24, Whites Road, Chennai - 600 014.

E-TENDER NOTICE
RFP No.: 00010010/00 ITR/PP/216/2026-2027
United India Insurance Company Limited, a Public Sector Company invites Bids for “**APPOINTMENT OF CONSULTANT FOR IMPLEMENTATION OF DPDP ACT, 2023 AND DPDP RULES, 2025**”. Please visit our website <https://www.uilic.co.in/> and <https://gem.gov.in/> for details of Bids & RFP.

IRDAI Regn. No. 545 | CIN: U93090TN1938G00000108

www.uilic.co.in

**NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY**

E-tender Notice No:- 33255963D

OPEN TENDER NOTICE (Through e-Tender)

On the behalf of President of India e-Tenders are invited by the Sr. DMM/DSD/NWVR, Jodhpur. Name of item : 9 TRACTION MOTOR COMPLETE (WITHOUT MSU / CANON TUBE & BULL GEAR) FOR 1600HP IGBTEMU AS PER SCOPE OF SUPPLY ENCLOSED AS ANNEXURE - 1 (LIST OF 70 ITEMS) CONFORMING TO ALL RELEVANT CLAUSES OF RDSO SPECIFICATION No. MP.0.24.00.45 (REV.02) ALONG WITH ICF NNXUEAPPLICABLE FOR THIS ITEM. MAKE TYPE No.TME-48-45-6, PART No. SPDMMU of M/s-MEDHA TRACTION EQUIPMENTS PVT LTD

Approximate Cost of items : RS. 6679980.00 (Rs. Sixty Six Lakh Seventy Nine Thousand Nine Hundred Eighty Rupees Only) Earnest Money to be deposited :- Rs. 133800.00 (Rs. One Lakh Thirty Three Thousand Six Hundred Rupees Only) Last date and time for Submission of E-Tender Opening of E-Tender : 30/07/2026, 14:25 Web site on E-Tender forms can be obtained : www.ireps.gov.in Address of NIT issuing Office : Officer of the Sr. DMM/DSD, NWVR, Jodhpur-342001(Rajasthan) Notice: 1. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender, and any such manual offer received shall be summarily rejected. 2. Cost of tender document & EMD online through e- transfers i.e. through payment gateway facility 3. on the IREPS website. 968-D/26

Follow us on:      NWRailways

**EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY**

E-TENDER NOTICE

Open Tender Notice No. : EPC/PSU/GHD-KMND/ECRA/ Date :06.07.2026.

1. Name of the work with its location : Design, Supply, Erection, Testing & Commissioning of Traction Sub Stations (Scott/V connected) with associated Switching Posts (SP/SSP) for 2 x 25 KV AT feeding system along with provision of associated SCADA system in upgradation of Electric Traction System from 1x25KV to 2x25KV Traction System for Kumandih-Garhwa Section of ECR to meet 3000 MT loading target. 2. Approximate cost of the work : ₹144,70,98,590.08/- 3. Cost of Tender form : ₹0.00/- 4. Earnest money to be deposited : ₹2,89,42,000.00/- 5. Date & time for submission of tender and opening of tender : Bidding start date 17.10.2026 and opening of tender on 31.10.2026 at 11.00 hrs. 6. Website particulars, notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc. : For eligibility criteria and other conditions and details, please go through the tender document available in web-site at <http://www.ireps.com>. 7. Address of the office from where the tender details can be obtained, website particulars and notice board location : Office of the Chief Electrical Engineer, Railway Project, Danapur, Near Jagjeevan stadium, Khagaul, Danapur-801105 E-tendering website- www.ireps.gov.in Notice board-Office of the Chief Electrical Engineer Railway Project, Danapur, Near Jagjeevan stadium, Khagaul, Danapur.

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/
Railway Project/ECR/Danapur
PR/0515/DNR/Elect./T/26-27/52

(प्रधान कुमार् जीधरी)
अधीक्षक अभियन्ता अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लो०नि०वि०, अलीगढ़

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लो०नि०वि०, अलीगढ़

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना (अल्पकालीन) (प्रेस विज्ञापित)

पत्रांक- 3960 / कैशियर (निष्का०-1 अ०) - अणु०/2026-27

दिनांक 01.07.2026

1. महानगर रायचूल उप प्रदेश की ओर से अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लो.नि.वि., अलीगढ़, द्वारा निम्न तालिका में अंकित विवरण के अनुसार लोक निर्माण विभाग में मार्ग कार्य हेतु सुसज्जित श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदार से प्रतिस्तर पर के अन्तर्गत पर और लाइन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदादाता किसी एक अथवा समस्त कार्य हेतु निविदा में भाग ले सकता है। निविदादाताओं को सलाह दी जाती है कि निविदा डालने से पूर्व निविदा के लिए न्यूनतम अर्हता हेतु निविदा निर्देशिका के खंडज 4 का ध्यानपूर्वक अध्ययन कर लें।

क्र० सं०	जगह का नाम	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की अनुमानित लागत (A)	अधीक्षण मद की अनुमानित लागत (B)	अनुमानित कुल लागत (लाख रू० में)	धराशिर धरोहर (लाख रू० में)	निविदा प्रारंभ का मूल्य (रू० में)	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	कार्य सम्पादित करने वाले अधिशासी अभियन्ता का पता	अधीक्षण अभियन्ता के कार्यालय का पता	मुख्य अभियन्ता का कार्यालय का पता	ठेकेदारों की श्रेणी/अनिवार्य पंजीकरण
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
1	अलीगढ़	गुर्ज नगरिया से सड़ा (दमोदर नगर) मिसिंग लिंक नवनिर्माण का कार्य।	127.40	7.90	135.30	8.77	2000 + 300 +54 Rs. 2354.00	12 माह	निर्माण खण्ड-1, लो.नि.वि., अलीगढ़	अलीगढ़ वृत्त, लो.नि.वि., अलीगढ़	अलीगढ़ क्षेत्र, लो.नि.वि., अलीगढ़	ए० एवं बी० (मार्ग कार्य में पंजीकृत)

2. मार्ग कार्य करने की अवधि में वर्षा ऋतु भी सम्मिलित है।
3. बिड अगलोल करने की तिथि से 90 दिन तक बिड स्वीकृति हेतु वैध रहेगी।
4. वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण एवं विस्तृत शर्तें तथा बिडिंग डॉक्यूमेंट्स आन लाइन देखे जा सकते हैं तथा दिनांक 13.07.2026 से 28.07.2026 तक देखे जा सकेंगे। ऑनलाइन बिड दिनांक 28.07.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे या इससे पूर्व ई-निविदा <http://etender.up.nic.in> पर अनिवार्य रूप से ऑनलाइन अर्जा कर दी जाये एवं ऑनलाइन प्राप्त समस्त दस्तावेज बिड दिनांक 28.07.2026 को अपरान्ह 12:30 बजे खोली जावेगी।

UPID-253365 Date 06/07/2026

www.upidadv.gov.in

(प्रधान कुमार् जीधरी)
अधीक्षक अभियन्ता निर्माण खण्ड-1, लो०नि०वि०, अलीगढ़

Press Trust of India
Bhadohi, July 7

A DALIT labourer was allegedly assaulted and subjected to casteist abuses by two persons for drinking water from a vessel kept outside a clinic in Uttar Pradesh's Bhadohi district, police said on Tuesday.

ASP Shubham Agrawal said the incident took place on June 23 in Kevatahi village and two persons have been arrested. The complaint was filed on Sunday after the victim was discharged from the hospital after undergoing treatment for 12 days.

According to the FIR, Bhola

Gautam was returning home with fellow labourer Om Prakash Vishwakarma after finishing painting work when he stopped at the clinic allegedly run by a quack, Shiv Ram Bind, to seek medicine for headache.

When Gautam asked for water to take the medicine, Bind asked him to fetch water from outside, the officer said.

As Gautam took water from a vessel kept on top a bucket outside the clinic, a nearby shopkeeper, identified as Subhash Bind, allegedly hurled casteist slurs and questioned how a person belonging to a “lower caste” could drink water from the

bucket, the FIR lodged under BNS section 351 (3) (criminal intimidation), 352 (2) (Intentional insult with intent to provoke a breach of peace), and SC/ST Prevention of Atrocities Act said.

Agrawal said Subhash Bind allegedly hit Gautam with a stick, leaving him injured.

The complaint further alleged that Shiv Ram Bind also came outside, saying the bucket had been “polluted” because a Dalit had drunk water from it. He then allegedly assaulted Gautam and threatened to kill him.

Gautam was rescued by his co-worker Om Prakash Vishwakarma and others present.

**NAGAR NIGAM, GORAKHPUR**

EOI Notice

No. 117/AMC-III/NNG/2026-27

Date :- 07/07/2026

Nagar Nigam, Gorakhpur invites first time the specified work through e-Procurement.

Name of Work	Tender fee with GST @ 18%
EOI For Setting Up, Operation, Maintenance of Cow Dung disposal Plant - Nagar Nigam Gorakhpur, U.P.	Rs. 1180/- (including GST)

Time Schedule for Bidding :

S.No.	Description	Date
1	Start Date for EOI document download	10-07-26
2	Last date of Online submission of EOI	30-07-26 - 05:00 PM
3	Pre-Bid meeting	20-07-26 - 12:00 PM onwards
4	Opening of Technical proposal	31-07-26 - 12:00 PM
5	Opening of financial proposal	Will be communicated.

NOTE:

1. Other details can be seen on website <http://etender.up.nic.in> (for view, download and bidding).

2. For any other queries, please contact Additional Municipal Commissioner, Nagar Nigam Gorakhpur at 8810709304. Also, for any further queries, and pre-bid queries the bidders are advised to send an email to: nnggkpsbm@gmail.com and Cc to nagarnigmkgkp@gmail.com

Additional Municipal Commissioner-III
Nagar Nigam, Gorakhpur

The Big Picture

WEDNESDAY, JULY 8, 2026

11

3. We are separately requesting the concerned Indian authorities to take necessary steps to terminate all cases and proceedings against you arising out of the UK request for your provisional arrest and extradition.

From the letter sent by the Ministry of External Affairs to Sougat Chandra Mukherjee, dated May 1, 2019

A MURDER IN GLASGOW, AN ARREST IN MUMBAI

THE SCOTLAND REDEMPTION

In January 2015, police landed at Sougat Mukherjee's door in Mumbai. He was a suspect in the murder of a sex worker in Glasgow nearly two decades earlier. SOPHIYA MATHEW on the unravelling that followed — his arrest, a spiral into depression, and a clean chit that came too late



Sougat and Sapna met at a college festival in Mumbai; (below, left) with his parents, elder brother Sourav and his wife. SOURCE: FAMILY ALBUM

SHORT BUILD", "dark hair", "protruding teeth" — that is not how Sougat Mukherjee's family knew him. But that is what he was stripped down to in a Scottish case diary after he was named a suspect in a 1997 murder case.

It's a case that hunted him down nearly decades after he left Glasgow, Scotland, where he was a student in the nineties, led to his arrest in India, and wrecked the life and family he had built back home. And then, years later, with the casualness with which law enforcement often operates, another man was picked up for the murder in Glasgow, and the case against Sougat was dropped. It was, however, too late — Sougat died in 2023 at age 44, his name cleared, but his frame broken by alcoholism and the spiral of depression he had plunged into.

Now, more than two years later, his wife Sapna, a sales manager at a technology firm in Mumbai's Malad, is preparing to take legal action against the authorities in Scotland and India for Sougat's "wrongful identification, unlawful arrest, and systematic destruction". "I really didn't want to," she says. "But the repercussions of the case, the financial and mental toll on my family and children, have been so huge."

A murder in Glasgow

On November 24, 1997, Tracey Wylde, 21, was found dead in her flat in Barmulloch, north-east Glasgow. A post-mortem examination later confirmed the police's findings of "manual strangulation". Wylde was the sixth sex worker to be murdered in Glasgow between 1991 and 1999. The crimes had proved notoriously difficult to prosecute, and the Scottish police admitted they could find no evidence linking them, leaving investigators to pursue separate suspects in each of the cases.

Sougat was then in Glasgow on a student visa. The second of two children of Syamal Chandra Mukherjee, a former director of logistics at ONGC, and Soma Mukherjee, Sougat was pursuing a two-year nautical course at the Glasgow College of Nautical Studies that would have led him to his dream job in the Merchant Navy. He stayed in the college's residential accommodation south of River Clyde, and worked part-time in grocery stores and restaurants.

But things soon turned sour. His family says he was mugged near his college and had approached police, but they instead detained him for a day. The incident left him "unsettled" and, in February 1998, he returned to India. "He got scared. He was only 19," says Sapna.

Years later, Sougat's decision to leave — at a time when the Scottish police were looking for suspects in the Wylde case — would be treated with suspicion.

Back in India, Sougat met Sapna at a festival in Mumbai's Lala Lajpat Rai College. He was stepping in for his elder brother Sourav, who then worked for a security firm, by handling a sniffer dog at the college festival.

Sapna, a Class 12 student at the pre-degree college, says she didn't approach Sougat first, but the dog. "Was the dog friendly?" she asked him. It was their first conversation.

They exchanged pager numbers and later, long phone calls. He told her about the course he had dropped out of and the humiliation of it. Sapna says she listened without judgment and soon, Sougat had left behind the memories of his brief stint in Glasgow.

They married the next year, in 1999. The couple later moved to Singapore, where Sapna completed a nurse practitioner course while Sougat secured a degree in mechanical engineering. The couple returned to India in 2005. Sapna changed careers to join a multinational firm and eventually moved to sales. By 2004, their three children were born.

Back in Scotland, something had stirred in the Tracey Wylde case. In 2013, Police Scotland's Cold Case Review Team (CCRT), which works on unsolved homicides, began a fresh review of Wylde's murder.

The prosecution's case rested on a single DNA profile recovered from five locations on Tracey Wylde's body.

Grainy CCTV frames had captured the young woman in the company of a man in his "mid-thirties or early forties", approaching her apartment entrance at 2 am.

And then in a "baffling" turn of events, the suspicion fell on Sougat. "The Glasgow police had drawn the sketch of the suspect. He had protruding teeth. It was only on the basis of this that Sougat was taken," said Hitesh Jain, Senior Advocate, who handled Sougat's case in 2019.

Things moved rapidly. In August 2014, Police Scotland sought an Interpol Red Notice, branding Sougat a fugitive. In December 2014, the Crown Office, Scotland's public prosecution service, claimed it had "sufficiency of corroborated, reliable and credible evidence", following which Glasgow's Extradition Section moved to arrest Sougat.

On January 9, 2015, the case reached the couple's home in Malad, Mumbai. It was a knock in the morning, before the children could leave for school. Sougat, then a business development professional, was recovering from a leg injury at home. A team of Mumbai Police personnel, led by a woman officer, says Sapna, had come with



a copy of the Interpol notice.

Their questions were blunt and, to the family, bewildering. "Aapne Glasgow mein kya kiya (What did you do in Glasgow)?" Sapna says Sougat kept repeating. "I have done nothing." The only brush with the authorities he could remember from Glasgow was a warning over urinating in public, he told them.

At first, the family did not understand the scale of the allegation, says Sapna. Only after frantic calls did they learn that Sougat had been linked to a murder in Glasgow.

On January 9, 2015, he was arrested by the Detection Crime Branch (DCB), CID Extradition Cell, Mumbai, following instructions routed through the British High Commission, the extradition section at Patiala House in Delhi and the Ministry of External Affairs. He spent more than three weeks in prison at Mumbai's Arthur Road Jail. "For days, we were totally unaware. Then, it was all over the papers, everybody started talking," says Sapna.

The warrant for Sougat's provisional arrest, secured by the Crown Office in December 2014, accused him of four counts of public indecency of sexual nature, besides the murder charge. Hitesh Jain, his lawyer then, says these were later proven to be false during the bail appeal proceedings in 2015.

"In spite of the fact that no extradition request had been received, the police placed him under arrest merely on the basis of a Red Corner Notice issued on suspicion. We argued before the Mumbai Metropolitan Court that there was no need for arrest and the court saw merit in our

• GLASGOW MURDER & A SUSPECT: AS IT HAPPENED

AUGUST 1997: Sougat Mukherjee leaves India to study at Glasgow College of Nautical Studies

24 NOVEMBER 1997: Tracey Wylde, 21, found dead at her flat in Glasgow

FEBRUARY 1998: Sougat drops out of college, returns to India

6 AUGUST 2014: An Interpol Red notice is issued against him after Police Scotland takes up the 1997 cold case

DECEMBER 2014: Extradition Section in Glasgow formally transmits a provisional arrest request to Indian authorities, charging Sougat with murder

9 JANUARY 2015: Sougat is arrested and sent to Arthur Road Jail in Mumbai

30 JANUARY 2015: Chief Metropolitan Court in Mumbai grants bail to Sougat

24 APRIL 2019: In Glasgow, Zhi Min Chen, a Chinese immigrant, pleads guilty to the murder

1 MAY 2019: Ministry of External Affairs formally informs Sougat that the UK has withdrawn all charges and extradition requests

JANUARY 2023: Sougat dies at 44 from acute liver cirrhosis

MAY 2026: His wife, Sapna Mukherjee, petitions Prime Minister Narendra Modi to support a formal complaint against Police Scotland and British prosecutors

JULY 2026: Sapna with legal support initiates formal compensation proceedings against Police Scotland, the Scottish government, and Indian authorities concerned for the wrongful identification and unlawful arrest of Sougat



On 24 April 2019, China-born Zhi Min Chen (right) pleaded guilty to killing Tracey Wylde (left), a sex worker, in Glasgow in 1997. In May 2019, the High Court in Glasgow sentenced Zhi Min Chen to life imprisonment, with a minimum term of 20 years, after he pleaded guilty to Wylde's murder

point and he was granted bail without having to approach the higher courts," Jain told *The Indian Express*.

A senior officer said the Mumbai Police follows "diplomatic processes between countries and due processes in all cases".

Sougat would later, in conversations with his family and interviews to the media, describe the jail stay as degrading and terrifying. "Police suspected me because I left in the middle of my studies. There was no other reason."

In a 2019 interview to *The Scottish Sun*, a Glasgow publication, Sougat said, "I might have failed my course, but it doesn't make me a killer. I was declared a rapist and a killer. I was treated like a monster. I was in prison for 24 days alongside dangerous criminals. The pavement

in Glasgow was 100 times cleaner than the floor I was sleeping on. I was in jail for nothing. I've never even killed a cockroach."

His bail plea was declined thrice. "Every morning at 5 am, we would leave for Arthur prison. They (jail staffers) allowed visitors between 11 am and 5 pm, and there would be a long queue... So, my mother-in-law and I would be there early in the morning and sit on the road outside the jail."

Sougat was eventually granted bail on January 30, 2015, but he was required to report every Monday to the office of the inspector, Extradition Cell, DCB-CID, Mumbai — a routine he stuck to until July 13, 2015, after which he had to visit once in two weeks.

Despite Sougat's bail in 2015, suspicion followed him wherever he went. Sapna says their extended relatives grew quiet and invitations to family functions came with a whispered condition: "Please Sapna, don't bring your husband. You and your children can come."

She says that with the family spending Rs 14.5 lakh to fight the case, they had to sell their homes in Mumbai's Kandivali and Nerul. Later, the landlord at their rented home asked them to vacate at a week's notice, forcing Sougat, Sapna and the children to move to his family home in Kolkata.

It was also a period when Sourav, driven by guilt and shame at the suffering he had caused his family, distanced himself from Sapna and the children — sleeping in the living room, losing his temper and plunging

into depression. He also suffered epileptic attacks, bruising his tongue badly each time. Sapna says that from someone who liked an occasional drink, Sougat took to drinking heavily and ended up with acute liver cirrhosis. Repeated hospital visits followed as Sapna watched him sinking.

Though Sougat had lost the will to return to himself, he kept trying to find work. Employers rejected him because of the gap in his resume. "Nobody came back to say, 'Let us give you a job, no matter how small,'" Sapna says. "It would have saved him his life... The children would have had their father."

Sougat also meticulously kept track of the case in Glasgow through news alerts and notifications.

It was one such Google News notification that alerted him to new developments in his case in Glasgow — on July 11, 2018, China-born immigrant Zhi Min Chen was taken into custody for killing Tracey Wylde in Glasgow in 1997. He later pleaded guilty to the murder, after which the High Court in Glasgow sentenced Zhi Min Chen to life imprisonment, with a minimum term of 20 years, in May 2019.

On February 8, 2019, Sougat wrote to then External Affairs Minister Sushma Swaraj to have the proceedings against him closed and to get his seized passport back. Until then, Sapna notes, they hadn't heard from the British High Commission or the Mumbai Police about the turn in the case in Glasgow.

Sougat wrote, "I have been giving attendance for more than four years... although since early 2018, I was not been keeping well... I am not able to join any company due to the verifications carried out by all companies, this has affected my health and mental well-being. My family is going through a major financial crisis... now we are not able to lead a normal family life."

On May 1, 2019, the MEA wrote to Sougat that British authorities had informed India that he was "no longer required by them" and that Indian authorities were being separately asked to terminate all proceedings. In a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 2025, Sapna wrote that Sougat was officially exonerated by the MEA on May 1, 2019, but the damage to the family was irreversible.

'The life of the family'

A photograph on her phone that Sapna keeps returning to has Sougat in a light pink shirt, his hands on his waist, his hair neatly combed. He looks into the lens, his smile wide.

The date on the photograph is April 9, 2020, almost a year after Zhi Min Chen had pleaded guilty to killing Tracey Wylde. The photograph, and the smile, are what she holds on to as the Sougat she knew, the one she remembers as a "one-person entertainment".

"He was the life of the family," she says. "The entire place would transform and light up in his presence. The brothers were opposites. Sourav was quieter, more reserved. Sougat was the one with so many tricks up his sleeve. He would crack jokes with uncles and aunts, he was the one people gathered around."

Sapna's life is now organised around her work and her children, and the wreckage the case has left behind. After Sougat died in 2023, Sapna and the children moved back from Kolkata to Malad.

Her eldest daughter studies BSc Microbiology in Mumbai, her son has finished school and is hoping to secure admission in an engineering college and her

youngest daughter is still in school. "My son's admission is completely dependent on the finances. It has left me anxious," says Sapna.

Sapna says her father-in-law's health has suffered and they

may now have to sell the Kolkata house he built to support themselves. "I have seen the house being built from one floor to what it is now," she says. "It is heartbreaking."

For Sougat's brother Sourav, the loss has taken a different form. In 2025, after Sougat's death, he wrote a book titled, *I Want to Break Free: A Fictionalized Memoir of a Life Gone Too Soon*, to keep memories of his brother alive.

As Sourav returns repeatedly to the "boy who lit up family gatherings", there's a recurring childhood memory. Two brothers on a terrace in Gujarat, with a kite straining against the wind, the elder trying to control the spool, the younger cutting the string and watching it disappear with a "signature smile". "It looked better when it was free, *dada*," Sourav recalls Sougat as saying.

The brother often returns to Sougat's smile — "a grin", he says that made him look both innocent and guilty at the same time. With time, Sougat learnt to hide it. Eventually, it disappeared altogether.

There is another memory, one that sears through the family every time they recall it — of Sougat asking his father: "Baba, if they hadn't found him (Zhi Min Chen), would I have died a murderer?"

WITH INPUTS FROM MOHAMED THAYER, MUMBAI

The Indian EXPRESS

~ FOUNDED BY ~

RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

On ethanol, make haste slowly

THE CENTRE is apparently going slow on implementing ethanol blending in petrol beyond the current 20 per cent. The rethink, as reported by this newspaper, comes even as the Finance Ministry, only last month, exempted petrol containing 22, 25, 27 and 30 per cent ethanol from excise duty after the Bureau of Indian Standards had issued specifications for these higher blends. The move to not hurry the transition to 20 per cent-plus blends makes sense. The all-India average ethanol-petrol blending ratio rose from 5 to 10 per cent between 2019-20 and 2021-22. It has since further doubled to 20 per cent, with this blend (E20) being made mandatory for all petrol sold from April 2026. Given how fast it has happened — well before the originally planned 2030 deadline — a pause isn't a bad thing from a policy or practical standpoint.

The pause period should be used by the government to address genuine concerns of motorists. The first has to do with lower mileage because of ethanol's calorific value being 30-35 per cent less compared to that of pure petrol. The second is on account of ethanol's hygroscopic (moisture-absorbing) property, which can lead to corrosion of steel fuel tanks and internal metal components. As it is, only vehicles sold in India after April 2023 have full material compatibility with E20. Handling fuel with ethanol blends may require major overhaul of internal combustion engines and auto parts to resist any potential ethanol-related degradation. Not surprisingly, it's the older car and two-wheeler owners who are feeling short-changed: reduced mileage and wearing of engine parts from ethanol is something they were not told about at the time of purchase before April 2023. All the more reason for transparent communication before embarking on E25 or E30. The government can even consider fiscal measures that would make the higher ethanol-blended fuels cheaper than E20, which will make consumers more receptive to them.

That said, the focus on biofuels and electrification of transport must continue. The risks of 90 per cent crude petroleum import dependency are too high — and the Iran war will not be the last of the global oil supply shocks. India needs a clear, calibrated and forward-looking roadmap for higher ethanol blends that avoid the abruptness of the earlier rollouts. Equally important is the feedstock for producing ethanol. It's certainly not desirable to make ethanol from water-guzzling rice. More effort is required to promote sweet sorghum, bajra and other millets as sustainable feedstocks, with breeding of varieties/hybrids with higher starch content and fermentation efficiencies comparable to maize or sugarcane.

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The safety net and the trade-off

IN RECENT years, several states have introduced cash transfer schemes aimed at women. From the Ladli Behna Yojana in Madhya Pradesh to the Maiya Samman Yojana in Jharkhand and the Magalir Urimai Thogai scheme in Tamil Nadu, these typically involve transfers in the range of Rs1,000 to Rs2,500 per month. The quantum of funds channelled through these schemes has increased significantly. In 2025-26, 12 states were estimated to spend Rs1.68 lakh crore on unconditional cash transfers, as per a report by PRS Legislative Research. To put this in perspective — the Union government allocated Rs86,000 crore for the MGNREGA in 2025-26.

Unconditional cash transfers have emerged as an instrument of social welfare and empowerment for women, and as an electoral strategy for political parties. A new study — 'Unconditional Women Cash Transfer Programmes in India', EAC-PM Working Paper Series — provides evidence to support these. Examining such schemes in Maharashtra and Odisha, it finds that they have led to improvements in consumption and savings of beneficiaries, raising household welfare, with more being allocated for medical, educational and lifestyle purposes. These are welcome trends, and underline the reasons for the spread of such schemes.

Over the last few years, however, concerns have been expressed that as states allocate more resources for such schemes and populist measures such as free electricity, their ability to spend on other areas gets affected. The central bank has echoed these concerns, saying that they "run the risk of crowding out" investments. This shift to cash transfers has also come at a time of mounting disquiet over state finances. As per a report from Axis Bank, the resources for these schemes are garnered through expenditure switching and higher deficits. While the consolidated debt of states has fallen from 31 per cent in March 2021 to 29.2 per cent in 2026 (budget estimates), there is a marked variation across states. For instance, Punjab has a debt burden of 46.4 per cent of the GSDP, West Bengal 38.9 per cent and Bihar 36.8 per cent. "High debt levels, growing contingent liabilities from guarantees and cash transfer schemes pose risks to state finances," the RBI noted. This requires closer attention.

The end of football superpowerdom

WORLD FOOTBALL'S beloved giant Brazil is sinking. When the new Vikings from Norway casually flicked them aside as their star forward Erling Haaland literally scored in walk-in-the-park fashion, Brazil seemed to fade into a sad sunset. The Brazilian samba tunes had been drowned by Norway's celebratory rowing echoes. In a World Cup where tiny nations like Cape Verde and Curaçao showed that even they can compete, and where Germany and Holland went home early while Italy were a no-show, Brazil's exit was the cue for the end of the notion of a football superpower.

The signs date back to 2002 when the original Ronaldo — Nozario — had his last dance at a World Cup. While Neymar was force-fitted into a must-fill niche of Brazilian raw talent, he never really could nail down a World Cup. The main reason was the quality of men around him and the lack of seamless service and creative delivery. The void left behind by Ronaldinho, Rivaldo, Roberto Carlos, Leonardo was glaring. Norway had more players at the Champions League than the South Americans. Their coach, Carlo Ancelotti from Italy, wasn't wrong in saying the "chasing pack" of countries had caught up.

The players in the present team have the win-gene in bits and pieces, but neither the swagger nor the suaveness of Haaland or Mbappé to turn matches on their own. Or maybe, like Morocco fans claimed earlier, Brazil's streets just don't have the hunger and humour or desperation to produce champions of yore. Ancelotti has great faith in turning things around. But Neymar was touted as the injection of new blood 15 years back. Maybe Brazil needs half a dozen of those, just like 2002 or before.



RAJA MANDALA

BY C RAJA MOHAN

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's eastward journey this week — from Indonesia to Australia and New Zealand — marks the consolidation of a new Indo-Pacific approach that might be called "G Minus Two". The idea of a US-China condominium in Asia has always made Indian strategists uneasy. President Donald Trump's occasional references to a G2, along with his administration's decision to discard the Indo-Pacific terminology, have reinforced those anxieties.

Delhi is responding to the new dynamic between Washington and Beijing by expanding its cooperation with the rest of Asia. This is similar to the ways in which several Asian powers are dealing with the changes in US-China relations. The unfolding Asian pattern of "G Minus Two" should help shift India's Indo-Pacific debate away from sterile slogans about American intentions or Chinese ambitions. The more practical question is what India can build with the rest of Asia.

The visits to Delhi by Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi this month and South Korean President Lee Jae-myung in April underlined the urgency in Tokyo and Seoul, two key Asian allies of Washington, to widen their Asian ties. Modi's visits to Jakarta, Melbourne and Auckland point to the same logic — the im-

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RSS deliberately chooses opacity, that becomes its shield



D RAJA

RSS-BJP leader Ram Madhav's recent defence of the RSS ('Needless controversy over the RSS', *IE*, June 20) seeks to portray the organisation as a transparent association that has operated openly within the framework of Indian law. However, he relies on a selective reading of history. The central claim of Madhav's article is that the RSS voluntarily adopted a written constitution in 1949. The historical record tells a very different story. The framing of the RSS constitution was not a voluntary act; it was the outcome of a prolonged confrontation between the RSS leadership and the Government of India following the assassination of Mahatma Gandhi and the ban imposed on the organisation in 1948. The RSS constitution emerged as part of a bargain that M S Golwalkar arrived at with the Nehru-Patel leadership. Far from being a document organically evolved within the RSS, it was virtually drafted by Congress leader D P Mishra and practically shoved down Golwalkar's throat.

Since its formation in 1925, the RSS's structure, decision-making mechanisms and internal functioning remained opaque. From its inception, the RSS cultivated ambiguity regarding its organisational structure and its relationship with political activity. The frustration of the then-government over this opacity is evident in the official correspondence of that period. After repeated flip-flops by Golwalkar, the Union Home Ministry under Sardar Patel wrote to him, "The government of India has expected that you would appreciate the constructive approach which they made to the draft constitution of the RSS but find that you have either misunderstood that approach or are deliberately adhering to the objectionable features of your constitution in the hope that they will enable you to carry on the activities of the RSS on the same undesirable lines as in the past." (see *Golwalkar, The Myth Behind the Man, The Man Behind the Machine* by Dhirendra K Jha, p. 258). This context is crucial because Madhav presents the eventual adoption of the constitution as an amicable and mutually agreeable process.

The RSS constitution emerged as part of a bargain that M S Golwalkar arrived at with the Nehru-Patel leadership. It was virtually drafted by Congress leader D P Mishra and practically shoved down Golwalkar's throat

portance of expanding the geopolitical room for manoeuvre by strengthening cooperation among themselves.

"G Minus Two" is not about Asia turning its back on America. Quite the contrary. Most Asian countries recognise that there can be no stable balance of power in Asia without a sustained US strategic presence. China's rising military weight cannot be balanced by the rest of Asia, even if they act in concert. That is why Japan, South Korea, Australia and New Zealand continue to build on their security partnerships with Washington. If anything, uncertainty under Trump has increased the incentive to bind the US more closely to Asian security.

India and Indonesia, despite their non-aligned tradition, have reached similar conclusions. As China flexes its military muscle, both have intensified defence cooperation with the US. Their "strategic autonomy" under China's shadow rests not on keeping America at arm's length, but on working with it and navigating Trump's mercurial diplomacy. Both Delhi and Jakarta are now "major defence partners" of Washington.

If "G Minus Two" is not about distancing from the US, neither is it about containing China. Every major Asian nation, including India and the three countries Modi is visiting this week, knows that Chinese power in Asia and the Indo-Pacific is a reality that must be managed. They also have to deal with the extraordinary economic interdependence with China.

The Asian objective is to "de-risk" Beijing's weaponisation of interdependence. India's annual trade with China is now at \$150 billion. Comparable figures for America's Asian partners underline the same reality: South Korea

Every major Asian nation, including India and the three countries Modi is visiting this week, knows that Chinese power in Asia and the Indo-Pacific is a reality that must be managed

trades roughly \$300 billion with China, Japan more than \$300 billion, Australia over \$200 billion, while ASEAN's trade with China has crossed the trillion-dollar mark. Commercial decoupling is not a realistic option. The Asian imperative for deeper economic cooperation among the regional powers has been reinforced by Trump's tariff wars. This logic was evident during President Lee's visit, which emphasised strategic economic cooperation, and during PM Takaichi's visit, which expanded the agenda on economic security. Similar themes of economic resilience and defence cooperation will dominate Modi's discussions in Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand.

The objective is neither an anti-China coalition nor an alternative to the American alliance system. Nor is it an attempt to create an independent bloc of middle powers. It is a practical effort to strengthen India's partnerships with the major industrial, technological and maritime powers of Asia.

Japan brings advanced manufacturing, defence technology and infrastructure finance. South Korea offers world-class capabilities in shipbuilding, semiconductors and defence production. Australia has become indispensable in critical minerals, maritime security and the stabilisation of the eastern Indian Ocean. New Zealand offers important opportunities in trade, higher education, agriculture and advanced technologies.

Whether Washington uses the term Indo-Pacific or not, Indonesia remains the geographical and geopolitical heart of that concept. Sitting astride the confluence of the Indian and Pacific Oceans, it occupies one of the most consequential strategic locations in the world.

Our right to walk is broken — just like our footpaths



ANURADHA MASCARENHAS

THE LITTLE girl in a T-shirt and cotton trousers gently opened her umbrella to avoid one loose spoke tearing into the polyester. She pranced about on the footpath, twirling the umbrella to send the rain-

drops at the end of the spokes scattering around.

It brought out the girl in me, reviving memories of the time when I received my first umbrella, a pink one, from my dad. Would I shed inhibitions and join the little girl with my umbrella? I would have loved to, but I have snapped ligaments in one ankle. It forces me to tread with care on broken footpaths.

I'm particularly wary of the dislodged interlocking tiles on our footpaths, gingerly sidestepping them lest the ankle buckle again. Walking on our footpaths is certainly no pleasure. Worse, the absence of the footpath itself can have serious consequences. In a recent ruling, the Supreme Court recognised the need for safe, demarcated footpaths as a fundamental constitutional right while hearing a man's plea for compensation after his five-year-old son was killed by a tanker while walking on the road.

According to recent news reports, as many as 36,000 pedestrians were killed in accidents on Indian roads in 2024. And as per the Road Safety Network's white paper for 2025, India continues to lose 1.7 lakh lives annually to road accidents, with pedestrians, cyclists and two-wheeler riders at greatest risk.

Remember when the ignored footpath of today was a muse for filmmakers and lyricists? Raj Kapoor as Raju in the 1950s romanticised the footpath in *Awaara*. Later, in *Chhoti Si Baat*, South Mumbai's footpaths witnessed the heartwarming courtship of Arun (Amol Palekar) following Prabha (Vidya Sinha) around, hesitant to profess his love but not knowing that she knew about his interest. In *Rajnigandha*, Deepa (again Vidya Sinha) contemplates her two suitors on the footpath.

Over time, the footpath has been lost to traffic congestion, encroachment and unplanned infrastructure. In many cities, it becomes a getaway for two-wheelers in heavy traffic, works as a parking bay or hosts makeshift chai *tapris*. While municipal squads have been acting against illegal shop extensions and mobile hawkers to ensure footpaths remain encroachment-free, city administrators have taken the SC's ruling seriously by initiating measures to ensure the pedestrian's right of way.

The UK's National Health Service (NHS) recently initiated its Movement 26.2 challenge in which adults walking 30 minutes a day for a month are eligible for rewards and discounts. The NHS is concerned that one in six deaths in the UK is due to lack of physical activity. Here, we aren't even asking for such incentives — all we want is good footpaths to walk on.

With better implementation of existing policies, we could perhaps ensure that the monsoon gambol of the little girl with the umbrella on the footpath is no longer an exception.

The writer is senior editor, The Indian Express. anuradha.mascarenhas@expressindia.com

40 YEARS AGO

July 8, 1986



Jagjivan Ram cremated

WATCHED BY thousands of misty-eyed people, the mortal remains of Jagjivan Ram were consigned to flames here in his native village as per his wish after a state funeral attended by President Zail Singh and Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. Among other mourners at the funeral were Bihar Governor P Venkatasubbiah and CM Bindeshwari Dubey. Sixteen-year-old Anshul Avijit, son of Meira Kumar, MP, daughter of Jagjivan Ram, lit the funeral pyre at 5 pm amidst rendering of "Ram dhun" and chanting of Vedic hymns.

Punjab boycotts Desai panel

THE PUNJAB Chief Minister, S S Barnala,

had a 90-minute meeting with Justice D A Desai and informed him formally that his cabinet had decided to boycott the Desai Commission. Therefore, he said, he was unable to present Punjab's case before him.

TULF leaders meet GP

THE SECRETARY-general of the Tamil United Liberation Front, A Amirthalingam, met the policy advisory committee chairman, G Parthasarathy, and the Minister of State for Administrative Reforms, P Chidambaram, to discuss the discrepancies in the latest Sri Lankan proposals sent to the TULF through the Government of India and Sri Lankan President J R Jayawardene's statement at the June 25 conference of

political parties in Colombo. Amirthalingam said after his meetings with Parthasarathy and Chidambaram, "We made our points clear to the Government of India."

Bus falls into ravine, 14 killed

FOURTEEN PEOPLE were killed and 23 injured when a tourist bus from Andhra Pradesh fell into a 60-metre-deep khud in Bherughat, near Manpur on the Bombay-Agra national highway. According to police, the injured were admitted to Maharaja Yeshwantrao Hospital in Indore. Hospital sources said the condition of three of the injured was serious. The bus belonged to Vijaykrishna Travel, Masulipatnam district in Andhra Pradesh.



Now, more than ever, the strategic legacy of Imam Khamenei can be a guide



MOHAMMAD FATHALI

IN THE history of nations, certain concepts transcend the lifespan of governments and rulers, becoming inseparable from the very spirit and identity of a people. For the Iranian nation, independence is one such concept — an ideal rooted in centuries of resistance against foreign domination. Yet, it was Imam Khamenei who transformed this longstanding historical aspiration into a living and guiding principle governing every sphere of national life. Throughout four decades of leadership, he treated independence not as a slogan but as the backbone of policymaking in security, diplomacy, economics, and science — a pillar that never bent, even amid the fiercest storms of international pressure.

Strategic independence, in its precise sense, is a nation's ability to determine its own destiny according to its own interests and values. What made this concept an enduring doctrine in Imam Khamenei's thought was its remarkable consistency and steadfastness over time. He stood as immovable as a mountain against every temptation toward dependency, regardless of the direction from which it came.

Within the discourse founded and uniquely articulated by Imam Khamenei, independence was never confined to resistance against the West. With the same determination, he rejected strategic dependence on the East. He warned that strategic dependency — even when presented in the language of cooperation or technical partnership — would ultimately become a chain. For the martyred Imam, self-reliance in the defence industry, the flourishing of indigenous technologies, and economic resilience were all manifestations of a single truth: National dignity. Looking far beyond the horizon of day-to-day politics, he saw independence as the continuation of Iran's ancient narrative of survival and permanence — a narrative in whose service he considered himself a loyal soldier and faithful guardian.

This historical vision, in Imam Khamenei's thought, was profoundly intertwined with the spiritual grandeur of Ashura. He viewed the tragedy of Karbala not as a distant historical memory, but as an ever-burning beacon illuminating the path of resistance against oppression and the willingness to pay any price in the cause of truth. The words of the martyred Imam were imbued with this Ashura-inspired spirit — a spirit that translated resistance, independence, and sacrifice into the contemporary language of the Iranian nation. From the union of the historical glory of ancient Iran and the spiritual magnificence of Islam, Imam Khamenei formulated the concept of the Iranian-Islamic Civilisation — which, in his view, presented Iran not merely as a political entity but as the rightful heir to two of humanity's greatest civilisational legacies. His life was devoted to the strengthening of this dual identity.

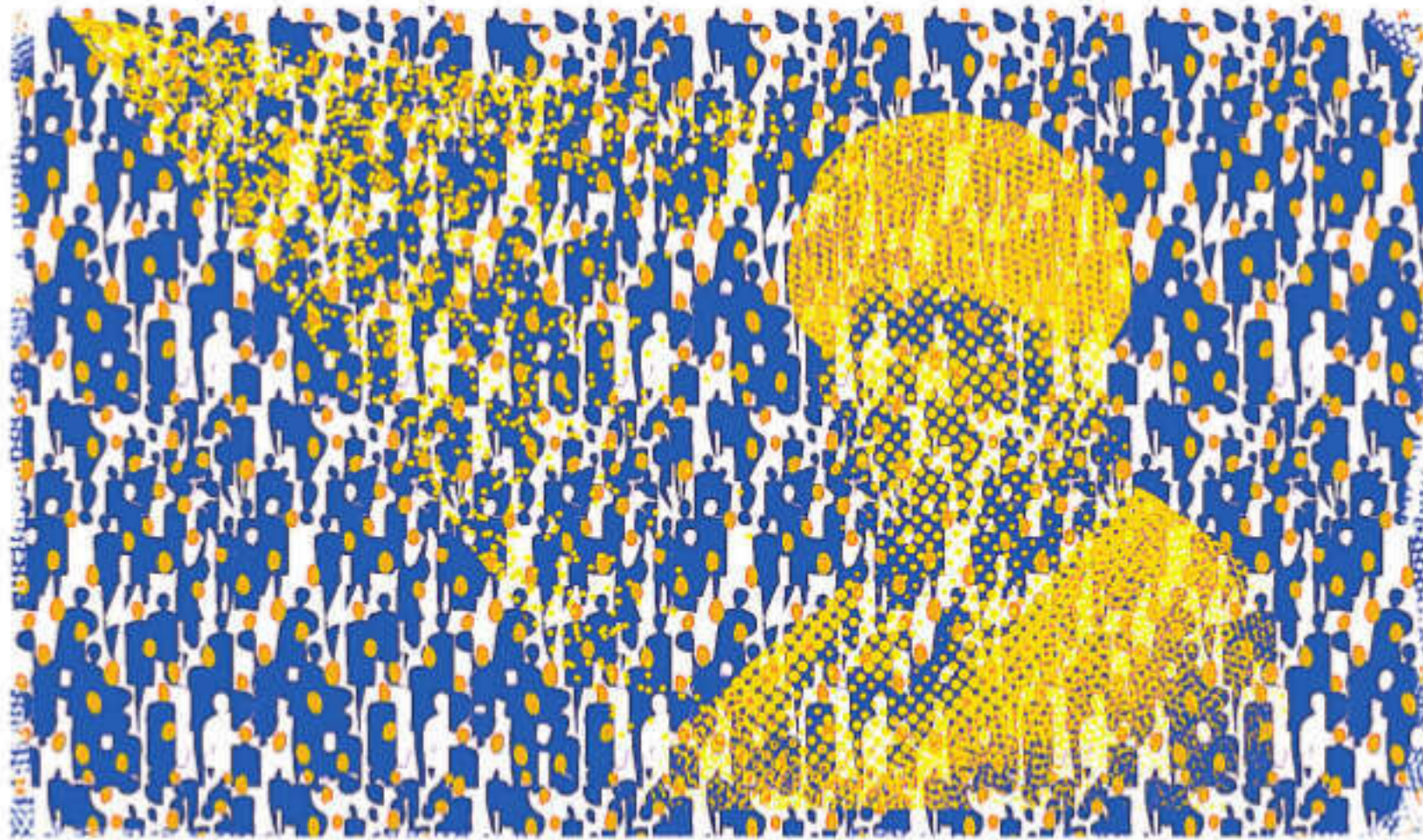


ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

Within this elevated vision, strategic independence was never merely a political instrument. Security, scientific advancement, and international dignity all derived their meaning from it. This intellectual legacy stands as the most enduring and distinguished hallmark of his four decades of leadership.

The martyred Leader regarded independence as a precious trust, nurtured by the blood of the martyrs of the Islamic Revolution and the Sacred Defence. For this reason, he considered it a sacred responsibility that must never be surrendered under any circumstances or at any cost. It was this unwavering conviction that enabled Iran to withstand some of the most severe international pressures of modern history, emerging as a resilient and dignified nation that chose steadfastness over submission.

Within this elevated vision, strategic independence was never merely a political instrument. Security, scientific advancement, and international dignity all derived their meaning from it

Yet what transformed Imam Khamenei's legacy from a political philosophy into an enduring epic was not merely his words or his statesmanship, but the grandeur of his final chapter. At the moment when an overt foreign act of aggression targeted the land of Iran, the very man who had devoted his life to speaking of independence and resistance proved the sincerity of his convictions through his own conduct. He remained in his homeland, beneath the sky whose independence he had spent a lifetime defending, standing firm in the place where he believed duty required him to stand.

In the final hours of his blessed life, he was fasting and engaged in service to the people for whose security and dignity he had devoted his entire life. Such martyrdom can never represent a mere ending in

the enduring memory of a nation. It is the culmination of a lifelong journey — the moment when a leader's words and deeds become forever inseparable. By remaining among his people at a time when fleeing has so often become the familiar course for many leaders around the world, Imam Khamenei left behind an image of leadership that will live forever in the memory of a nation that carries within itself one of the world's oldest civilisations. The blood of the martyred Imam was poured upon the roots of the very tree he had spent a lifetime nurturing — the mighty tree of Iran's independence and national dignity.

Nations ultimately judge their leaders not by the measure of fleeting achievements, but by the breadth of their vision and their steadfastness before the judgement of history. The manner in which Imam Khamenei forged an enduring connection between security, independence, progress, and national dignity — and ultimately sacrificed his own life in their defence — has created an image that will remain alive and honoured in Iran's historical memory.

Today, as the world confronts great-power competition, rapid technological transformation, and increasingly complex forms of economic dependency, Imam Khamenei's doctrine of strategic independence has acquired greater global relevance than ever before. It is no longer confined to the borders of a single country; rather, it has become a model for any nation seeking to preserve its dignity and sovereign will amid the pressures of international politics. From this perspective, Iran's experience during Imam Khamenei's leadership offers a lasting lesson to all those who regard national freedom of decision as more precious than any short-term advantage.

Ultimately, it must be said that, in Imam Khamenei's thought, independence was never merely a policy or an administrative programme. It was the very essence through which the history, culture, faith, and collective will of a nation were brought together. The legacy of the martyred Leader is today, more than ever, a guiding light for Iran's future — a light that, through his blood, will burn brighter and endure more steadfastly than ever before.

The writer is the Ambassador of the Islamic Republic of Iran in India

In growing India-Japan ties, an opportunity for Bihar



SANJAY KUMAR JHA

THE VISIT of Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi to India comes as the two countries are preparing to celebrate 75 years of diplomatic relations in 2027. Over the past decade, this partnership has expanded to include defence, technology, infrastructure, semiconductors, resilient supply chains and the Indo-Pacific. This is also the right occasion to make a strong case for Bihar.

Last year, I had the privilege of leading an all-party parliamentary delegation to Japan. During our interactions with political leaders, scholars and members of the Indian diaspora, I was struck by the warmth and affection with which Bihar was spoken of. The reverence for Bodhi Gaya, Nalanda and Rajgir remains deeply embedded in Japanese consciousness. This civilisational goodwill deserves to be translated into stronger economic and developmental partnerships. If New Delhi is the strategic anchor of India-Japan relations, Bihar is their civilisational foundation. No other Indian state shares such a deep historical, spiritual and cultural bond with Japan. Yet, Bihar has remained on the margins of the modern India-Japan economic story. That deserves to change.

For millions of Japanese people, Bihar is the land where Lord Buddha attained enlightenment. Bodhi Gaya has a sacred place in the hearts of Japanese Buddhists. Rajgir, where the Buddha spent several years and delivered many sermons, and Nalanda, one of the greatest ancient centres of learning, are equally revered. Every year, thousands of Japanese pilgrims travel to these sites in search of spiritual fulfilment and cultural understanding.

The Vishwa Shanti Stupa at Rajgir, built by the Japanese Buddhist order Nipponzan Myohoji, is one of the most enduring symbols of friendship between India and Japan. Japanese monks have maintained close ties with Bihar for decades, while scholars continue to engage with Nalanda and Buddhist studies. It is a matter of pride for Bihar that the Mithila Museum in Tokamachi, Niigata Prefecture, has showcased the rich tradition of Mithila paintings, creating yet another enduring cultural bridge.

Japan has also been among Bihar's oldest development partners. It has supported infrastructure and tourism projects

connected with the Buddhist Circuit. These investments have strengthened pilgrimage tourism and demonstrated Japan's longstanding commitment to preserving a shared heritage. Yet, when viewed against the scale of India's economic engagement with Japan today, Bihar has received only a modest share of Japanese investment.



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has elevated India-Japan relations to unprecedented heights. The goal announced during PM Takaichi's visit of increasing Japanese investment in India and expanding the presence of Japanese firms reflects the confidence both countries have in each other's future. Bihar is well placed to build on this momentum. Greater Japanese participation in tourism, urban infrastructure, heritage conservation, skill development and sustainable mobility would not only benefit the state but also complement the broader national vision of stronger India-Japan ties.

In Bihar, better roads, improved connectivity, expanding airports, growing urban centres and improvements in governance have created conditions far more conducive to investment than before. Bihar's young population, strategic location in eastern India and growing consumer market make it an attractive destination for long-term partnerships.

The Buddhist Circuit can be developed into a premier spiritual tourism destination. Japanese participation in heritage conservation would be a natural extension of the existing relationship. As Bihar urbanises, Japanese expertise in public transport, water supply, waste management and urban planning can contribute significantly. Agriculture, food processing, healthcare equipment, renewable energy and skill development are promising sectors where partnerships can deliver lasting benefits.

Former chief minister Nitish Kumar understood the importance of Japan for Bihar. His government consistently promoted the Buddhist Circuit, improved connectivity to pilgrimage sites and encouraged closer engagement with Japanese institutions. His vision recognised that Bihar's civilisational heritage is an economic and diplomatic asset capable of generating tourism, employment and international partnerships.

Every enduring partnership also draws strength from its civilisational roots. For India and Japan, those roots lie in Bihar. India and Japan first met through the Buddha. Seventy-five years after establishing diplomatic ties, it is time they discovered Bihar once again as the meeting point of their shared past and future.

The author is Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha) and national working president of JD(U)

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

WhatsApp row

WHILE THE authors have rightly argued that the government should regulate digital harms, not individual software features, their comparison of email and WhatsApp is somewhat flawed ('Don't scrap WhatsApp username, address the harms', *IE*, July 7). It should be noted that the use of email is largely limited to formal communication. WhatsApp has much deeper penetration. It is used by people regardless of education or economic status. While efforts to maintain privacy are commendable, they must be undertaken with caution because of WhatsApp's widespread presence among the masses.

Monika Rathore, Faridabad

Trump's overreach

IS IT not ironic that Donald Trump's bullish and whimsical attitude has now transgressed into the sports arena too ('FIFA lets Donald Trump, the bully, win', *IE*, July 7)? What else could explain his making multiple calls to FIFA over the referee's decision to show a red card to US striker Folarin Balogun in the match against Bosnia and Herzegovina? It is hardly surprising if those calls eventually culminated in FIFA lifting the suspension. Notably, the FIFA President conferred a "Peace Prize" on Trump in December last year, though it had nothing to do with the world of sports.

SK Gupta, via email

Folk icon

LEGENDARY PANDAVANI exponent Teejan Bai transformed Chhattisgarh's oral retelling of the Mahabharata into a globally recognised performing art, bringing its characters to life with little more than a tambura and her powerful voice ('Teejan Bai claimed her right to sing', *IE*, July 7). With her passing, India has lost one of the finest custodians of its oral traditions. Teejan Bai showed that a civilisation endures through the storytellers who keep its heritage alive.

SS Paul, Nadia



SUSAN THOMAS AND CHIRASHREE GHOSH

ON JULY 1, Capgemini shut down its on-campus daycare in Bengaluru after viral videos allegedly showing toddlers being abused surfaced. The shocking allegations are a warning about a larger childcare system that remains underregulated, undervalued, and often invisible. The Capgemini episode is a symptom of a much deeper crisis: The urgent need to build a safe, accountable, and dignified childcare ecosystem.

A robust childcare system will ensure children grow in a secure, nurturing, and developmentally rich environment. It enables women to enter and stay in the workforce. It converts care work from an invisible burden into a formal profession with standards, training, and fair wages. Despite rapid progress, 86 million children under six still lack access to quality early care at the very age when 85 per cent of brain development is most rapid. At the same time, female labour force participation remains distressingly low, especially in urban India where mothers are often forced to choose between earning and caregiving. This is not only a social problem; it is a drag on productivity, economic growth, and inclusion.

Other countries have shown that childcare is not a peripheral welfare scheme but core infrastructure. Singapore, for instance, expanded preschool capacity, subsidised centres, and tightened safety and wage standards as part of a strategy to support working families and national productivity.

This calls for the expansion of childcare services, crèches, maternity and parental benefits, skilling of childcare workers, and family-friendly workplace policies to reduce women's unpaid care burden



MIHIR VASAVDA

BRAZIL'S DEFEAT to Norway was more than another World Cup upset. It was a reminder that several of football's traditional powers are wrestling with the same question. Brazil no longer quite looks Brazilian. Germany no longer feels unmistakably German. The Netherlands, once the great innovators, are no longer setting the tactical agenda.

Their decline has often been explained by the rest of the world catching up. That is undoubtedly part of the story. Coaching, sports science and tactical ideas have spread across continents, shrinking the gap between football's elite and everyone else. But another possibility is worth considering. In

To ensure a quality creche is the employer's job

disised centres, and tightened safety and wage standards as part of a strategy to support working families and national productivity.

India has a legal framework that recognises the importance of workplace crèches. The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017 and the related crèche guidelines set out standards for staffing, monitoring, safety, and training. However, it is important to implement the guidelines to avoid such tragedies. What requires proactive action is responding to the needs of women workers in the formal and informal sector.

A crèche is not a convenience room where children are merely supervised until parents finish work. It is a space where nutrition, health, safety, early learning, and emotional well-being must come together. Children need more than watchfulness; they need responsive care from trained adults.

Childcare is still treated as a low-status extension of unpaid domestic labour. Workers are paid meagre wages, and their skill is not a priority. This calls for the expansion of childcare services, crèches, maternity and parental benefits, skilling of childcare workers, and family-friendly workplace policies to reduce women's unpaid care burden. Such measures enable women to participate equally in economic, social, and political life while ensuring the well-being and development of

Free Whatsapp Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

children. This will facilitate the delivery of a triple dividend through childcare.

As we rapidly move towards Viksit Bharat, childcare must be treated as essential public infrastructure. That means moving from voluntary compliance to strict enforcement. Crèche Monitoring Committees must function properly, with parent participation, regular checks, and unannounced audits. Safety standards must be monitored, not merely announced. Employers must be held accountable for the quality of care provided.

Just as important, the childcare workforce must be professionalised. Caring for young children requires training in child development, nutrition, hygiene, behaviour, and first response in emergencies. Certification, decent pay, and career pathways are the foundation of quality care.

The Bengaluru case should not fade into the usual cycle of outrage and forgetfulness. It should force a national reckoning to move towards a collective solution. It cannot be an afterthought that every child deserves safety, stimulation, and dignity. Every parent deserves confidence that their child is in capable hands. And every economy that hopes to prosper must recognise that care is not a private burden to be absorbed silently by women. It is public infrastructure, and it belongs at the centre of national development.

Thomas is committee member, and Ghosh is national coordinator, FORCES

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A football lesson from Brazil's defeat

trying to keep pace with modern football, some of the game's biggest nations may have drifted away from the qualities that made them successful in the first place.

The best international teams have always evolved with the game. But the most successful ones have usually adapted without becoming copies of somebody else. Brazil perhaps illustrates that best. Over the past decade, Brazil have become more structured, more tactically disciplined and, in many ways, more European in their approach. Yet, somewhere along the way, Brazil seem to have misplaced some of the instincts that once made them unique. The irony is that Brazil's greatest teams were never tactically naive. The 1970 side had structure. The 2002 World Cup winners were exceptionally well organised. But those systems existed to maximise Brazi-

lian creativity, not restrain it.

Germany's story leads to a similar conclusion. German football was defined by clarity, efficiency and competitiveness. Even when Germany modernised under Joachim Lowe, culminating in the 2014 World Cup triumph, those qualities remained intact. In the years that followed, however, their football became more elaborate, but the ruthless directness gradually faded. Dutch football earned its reputation because it consistently changed how foot-

Football has always evolved by borrowing ideas, but the strongest teams have rarely succeeded by becoming imitations of someone else

ball itself was played. Today, the Netherlands still produces excellent footballers and coaches, but it no longer feels like football's principal laboratory.

This is not a problem unique to football. For years after artificial turf transformed the sport, Indian hockey tried to emulate the European and Australian model. But India could never become a better version of Europe than Europe itself. The revival came only when Indian hockey found a balance.

For decades, England remained attached to an outdated version of English football built around physicality and direct play, even as the Premier League became increasingly shaped by continental ideas. Their improvement has come by embracing tactical flexibility without abandoning traditional strengths. England have also become one of the most consistent teams in recent years,

reaching two European Championship finals, a World Cup semifinal and two World Cup quarterfinals in the last eight years.

Perhaps that is becoming the defining challenge for international sport. Globalisation has made teams tactically smarter. Young players across continents learn similar positional principles. Inevitably, national styles have become less distinct. That makes identity even more valuable. Football has always evolved by borrowing ideas, but the strongest teams have rarely succeeded by becoming imitations of someone else. They have taken new ideas and moulded them around their own culture, history and strengths. That may be the lesson for many of football's traditional powers.

The writer is deputy associate editor, The Indian Express. mihir.vasavda@expressindia.com

2 bombs go off near Macron’s hotel in Damascus, 18 hurt



French President Emmanuel Macron with Syrian President Ahmed Al-Sharaa at People's Palace in Damascus, Syria, on Tuesday. REUTERS

Reuters
Damascus, July 7

TWO BOMBS exploded on Tuesday near a hotel in Damascus where French President Emmanuel Macron spent the night, wounding 18 people and overshadowing the first visit to Syria by a European Union head of state since Bashar al-Assad was toppled.

Macron, whose motorcade left the hotel shortly before the blasts, pressed ahead with his visit, meeting President Ahmed al-Sharaa at the presidential palace. His office said he had not heard the blasts.

The attack underlined lingering security challenges facing Sharaa, a former al Qaeda commander who has built close ties with Western states as he has sought to stabilise a country shattered by 13 years of civil war.

The explosions struck a busy area of Damascus between the Syrian Tourism Ministry and the national museum across the street from the Four Seasons

hotel, where a source in Macron's delegation and Syrian security sources said he had spent the night and had met civil society groups Tuesday morning. In a post on X after the blasts, Macron said his visit continued. "Nothing can undermine the desire of Syrians to live in a fully sovereign and secure Syria," he posted.

"This morning I met Syria in all its diversity, and I saw dignity, courage and determination," he added.

Macron, who led calls for the lifting of Western sanctions on Syria last year, was accompanied by business leaders, including the CEOs of TotalEnergies and shipping group CMA CGM.

The Elysee said CMA CGM signed a partnership deal with Syria, including air cargo freight handling, at Damascus airport, and that France and Syria would start a process to restore €51 million (\$58.3 million) of assets to Syria that were confiscated from the late Rifaat al-Assad, Bashar's uncle.

NATO flaunts arms deals as Trump targets Europe allies

U.S. PRESIDENT RENEWS PUSH TO CONTROL GREENLAND

Key 'defence forum' yields \$50 billion in deals: NATO official

Reuters
Ankara, July 7

NATO LEADERS unveiled arms deals worth tens of billions of dollars in Turkey on Tuesday, driving home the message that they are heeding US calls to spend more to defend Europe even as President Donald Trump said he felt let down and renewed his push to control Greenland.

Leaders were convening for a summit in the capital Ankara, hoping to project unity after another bruising year, in which the Iran war once again exposed cracks in the alliance.

In a meeting with President Tayyip Erdogan, Trump said he might have boycotted the NATO summit altogether had it not been for his warm relations with Turkish leader, and did not rule out further troop withdrawals from Europe. "Well, we're going to see. I was very disappointed with NATO," he said, singling out Britain, France, Germany and Italy for not doing enough to support US war on Iran.

Trump added "we weren't treated well" by the allies, even as he reiterated that he did not want or need their help. "Before I asked, they said they wouldn't be there, and we've invested trillions of dollars in NATO," Trump said.

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US President Donald Trump with Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan in Ankara on Tuesday. AP

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

NATO members have repeatedly tried to show Trump that they are stepping up. NATO Secretary General Mark Rutte said on Monday Europeans had made "staggering" increases in defence spending.

Before Trump's arrival, Rutte trumpeted a series of initiatives and deals at a defence industry forum, and called for a defence industry "revolution" across the alliance, warning over Russia's massive military spending as well as China, North Korea and Iran.

"We don't have the luxury of time. We need capabilities now to ensure we remain ready. The security situation demands it," Rutte said. "The hum of machinery must become a roar."

The deals, estimated to be worth at least \$50 billion ac-

Trump: US to lift Turkey sanctions, sell F-35 fighters

Reuters
Ankara, July 7

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Tuesday announced that the US would lift sanctions on Turkey that were imposed in 2020 over Ankara's purchase of Russian missiles, and signaled a willingness to sell the NATO ally F-35 fighter jets, moves that would both be massive gestures to Turkey but may face legal hurdles.

In the first visit to Turkey by a US President in 11 years, Trump was welcomed by President Tayyip Erdogan at the airport with a lavish state ceremony.

Speaking to reporters at the Turkish presidential palace, Trump repeatedly praised Erdogan, saying he had "chemistry" with him and that the relationship with Ankara has never been better.

Trump's 2019 acquisition of a Russian S-400 system and Washington's 2020 imposition of sanctions on a major Turkish defence company and removal of Turkey from the F-35 stealth fighter jet program have long been a sore point. "We're going to be taking the sanctions off," Trump said. "It's time. We don't want to sanction friends."

When asked if he had any concerns about Ankara still being in possession of the Russian S-400s, he said he did not.



People attend the funeral procession for Iran's late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in Qom, Iran, on Tuesday. REUTERS

LNG tanker at risk of exploding after two ships hit; Iran blamed

Reuters
Doha, July 7

A QATARI LNG tanker was at risk of exploding and a Saudi-flagged crude oil tanker was damaged near the Strait of Hormuz, sources said Tuesday, after reports Iran fired missiles at ships in the waterway overnight.

The *Al Rekayyat*, loaded with liquefied natural gas, sent out distress signals seeking assistance after it was hit on its port side, one of the sources said. Another source briefed on the matter said the vessel was at risk of exploding due to a fire in its engine room. The crew were safe and were being evacuated.

It is the first time an LNG ship from Qatar, a mediator in talks between Washington and Tehran, has been struck since the start of the Iran war.

A Saudi-flagged tanker, believed to be the supertanker Wedyan, was also damaged off Oman's coast, maritime security sources said. The cause

was not immediately known.

Al Rekayyat is owned and managed by Nakilat, also known as Qatar Gas Transport Company Ltd, which operates one of the world's largest LNG shipping fleets. LSEG shipping data showed the vessel last transmitted its location on June 18, indicating its AIS tracking transponder was switched off.

Wedyan is owned and managed by Saudi shipping firm Bahri. Bahri, Nakilat, QatarEnergy, Qatar's international media office, the Saudi government's media office and US Central Command did not respond to requests for comment.

There was no claim of responsibility for the attacks. A US official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said initial indications were that Iran had fired at two commercial vessels.

Qatar's foreign ministry said Tehran bore full legal responsibility for the attack on the LNG tanker. Tehran did not immediately comment.

Monaco bombing suspect found dead in Ukraine, two are arrested

Reuters
Kyiv, July 7

THE BODY of a woman suspected of carrying out a bomb attack in Monaco last week that targeted a sanctioned Ukrainian-born businessman has been found in Ukraine, and two men have been arrested in connection with her murder, authorities said on Tuesday.

Ukraine's Prosecutor General's Office said a serving employee of Ukraine's military intelligence service (HUR) and a former police officer had been detained on suspicion of the killing of Anastasiia Berezovska.

The body of Berezovska, a Ukrainian citizen who was wanted by Interpol for the June 29 bombing, was found with gunshot wounds to the head and pistol cartridges nearby, the prosecutor general said in a statement on Telegram.

The two men had communicated with Berezovska after she returned to Ukraine on July 1 and had made repeated transfers to her crypto and bank accounts, the statement said.

The HUR employee confessed to killing Berezovska with the other defendant and said he had acted without the knowledge of his superiors, the prosecutor general's office said.

The two men were arrested on suspicion of committing murder and are also believed to be involved in the bombing.

French court lets Le Pen seek presidency—with ankle tag

Reuters
Paris, July 7

A FRENCH appeal court on Tuesday upheld Marine Le Pen's conviction for misusing EU funds but shortened her ban on running for public office, in the ory preserving a path for the far-right leader to run in the 2027 presidential election.

However, the court also sentenced Le Pen to a three-year jail term: two suspended and one with an electronic ankle tag. This could make a presidential campaign politically and logis-

tically difficult. It is now up to Le Pen to say if she will run to become modern France's first far-right president. She is due to give a prime-time TV interview on *TF1* at 8 pm, in which she may make an announcement on her political future.

Le Pen previously said she would be reluctant to wage a presidential campaign while serving a sentence under electronic monitoring, arguing that it would interfere with campaigning and undermine her credibility. But she is yet to confirm what she will do.



Far-right leader Marine Le Pen

As she left the courtroom, Le Pen was smiling but did not say a word. She then went to the headquarters of her party, the

anti-immigrant National Rally (RN), to discuss what to do next.

Le Pen had been convicted in March 2025 of embezzlement and banned for five years with immediate effect from holding public office, and thus from making her long-planned fourth bid for the Elysee Palace.

Tuesday's appeal judgment, under which Le Pen is ineligible to hold public office for 45 months, 30 of which are suspended, means she will be eligible to stand when voters go to the polls in April 2027, because she has already served the 15-

month ban, which has been running since last year's ruling.

The decision is likely to trigger intense debate within the RN, which has spent months preparing for two possible futures: one led by Le Pen and another by party president Jordan Bardella. The electronic tag was stipulated as part of a softened jail sentence, and means she would not have to go to jail.

A sentencing judge will decide on the terms of Le Pen's tag, setting out the hours when she can be away from her home and what time she must return.

Drug-smuggling behind deadly prison clash that killed 26: Lanka minister

Reuters
Colombo, July 7

A RIOT in a Sri Lankan prison that killed 26 people and injured dozens was due to a clash between two groups over drug smuggling within the jail, a top official said on Tuesday.

Two days of fighting between two groups of inmates at the prison in the coastal town of Negombo, about 35 km north of the capital, Colombo, left 26 people dead, including seven prison officials, authorities said.

Initial investigations show the fight had started when a few prisoners had leaked information of efforts to smuggle drugs into the prison to prison officials,

Minister of Justice and National Integration Harshana Nanayakkara told parliament.

"This had angered a second group of inmates who were supporting the smuggling. This was what started the clash," he told lawmakers. "When prison officials attempted to intervene it had escalated. Prisoners attacked prison officials with bricks and poles. Prison officials fired in self-defence. At the moment we are unaware of how prisoners got possession of weapons. Investigations into these details are ongoing."

A small group of prisoners had also managed to disable the CCTV cameras in the prison, Nanayakkara added.

UK's Farage quits as MP over gift allegations, seeks re-election

London: Reform UK leader Nigel Farage announced Tuesday that he will quit his Parliament seat and seek re-election in an effort to clear his name over financial allegations linked to millions of dollars' worth of donations.

"Have done nothing wrong. I have not broken the law in any way at all. I have not misused public money," said Farage.

Farage faces questions about undeclared gifts, and a probe by Parliament's standards watchdog, over a 5 million pound (\$6.7 million) gift he received from a Thailand-based crypto currency billionaire. AP

Israeli fire kills 7 people, including a child, in Gaza

Reuters
Cairo, July 7

ISRAELI STRIKES and gunfire killed at least seven Palestinians, including a child, in the Gaza Strip on Tuesday, the territory's health officials said.

Medics said an Israeli airstrike killed a man and wounded two children in the Mawasi area of Khan Younis in southern Gaza. The Israeli military told *Reuters* they had targeted a Hamas militant.

Another Israeli airstrike hit near a tent encampment housing displaced families in western Gaza City, killing one person and wounding five others, medics said, while a third airstrike in Khan Younis killed one person and wounded three others.

The Israeli military said both of those strikes had also targeted militants.

The Popular Resistance Committees, a militant group that has long carried out armed attacks against Israel, said one of two Israeli strikes in Khan Younis had killed a senior leader of the group, Waheed Abu Salem.

Later on Tuesday, one Palestinian was killed and nine others were wounded by Israeli gunfire in an area of Rafah in the south of Gaza, medics and witnesses said.

Meanwhile, in Gaza City's Tel Al-Hawa neighbourhood, an Israeli airstrike hit a vehicle, killing three people, including a child, medics said, taking Tuesday's death toll across the Gaza Strip to at least seven.

• BRIEFLY

UNITED KINGDOM

Judge dismisses Harry's privacy invasion case against *Daily Mail*



Prince Harry. FILE

Prince Harry's final lawsuit aimed at taming the British tabloids ended in defeat on Tuesday as a judge found he failed to prove his privacy invasion claims against the publisher of the *Daily Mail*. Justice Matthew Nicklin rejected the broad inferences the Duke of Sussex had relied on to try to show that Associated Newspapers Ltd. had engaged in unlawful activities. The judge said there was a realistic possibility

the news came from legitimate sources. The ruling scuttles the lawsuits filed by Harry and six others, including singer Elton John. Reacting to ruling, Prince Harry called it a "complete and obvious whitewash." REUTERS

PAKISTAN

Court acquits man accused of blasphemy

IN A rare judgment, a Pakistani court has acquitted a Christian man accused of blasphemy due to lack of evidence, a court official said Tuesday. A sessions court on Monday cleared Danis Albert after the prosecution failed to establish any direct link between him and the alleged tearing of pages from a religious book, the official said. Albert was arrested in April 2024 after a complainant claimed he witnessed act in Lahore's Shadman Chowk. PTI

CHINA

5 dead, 12 missing after landslides in Gansu province

AT LEAST five people died after a landslide struck a mountainous area in China's western province of Gansu on Tuesday, with 12 others still buried amid ongoing rescue efforts, state media reported. The landslide hit a valley in Tanchang county early on Tuesday morning, leaving 33 people trapped, state-run Xinhua news agency said. By afternoon rescuers had found 21 people, five of whom died despite emergency treatment. REUTERS

• A 162-PAGE REPORT RELEASED BY THE WHITE HOUSE DOMESTIC POLICY COUNCIL ACCUSES THE NATIONAL MUSEUM OF AMERICAN HISTORY OF ANTI-WHITE BIAS & OF DISTORTING THE NATION'S FOUNDING

How White House and Smithsonian Museum are battling over American history

Graham Bowley, Robin Pogrebin & Jennifer Schuessler
July 7

IN A broadside posted to its website just as fireworks celebrating America's 250th birthday were lighting up the skies on Saturday, the White House condemned the Smithsonian's National Museum of American History for what it said was a failure to celebrate the nation's heritage, arguing it had become a political tool intent on denigrating the American story.

The 162-page report, by the White House's Domestic Policy Council, represents a sweeping attack on the museum's presen-

tation of US history. It is the latest step in the Trump administration's campaign to pressure the Smithsonian into conforming to what President Donald Trump has described as "patriotic" history.

While the report concludes that the broader Smithsonian Institution — which oversees 21 museums and the National Zoo — "has not met its obligations to the American people," it places particular blame on the National Museum of American History.

Titled "Saving America's Story: How Ideological Capture at the Smithsonian Institution's National Museum of American History Erases Our Heritage," the report accuses the museum

of anti-white bias and of minimizing and distorting the nation's founding. Those actions, the report asserts, have shifted the museum's mission "from straightforward historical education and scholarship toward an extreme political activism that seeks to transform our country."

The museum, it says "no longer treats the American story as a shared national inheritance to be taught or celebrated but as a political instrument to divide, dispirit and discourage our citizens."

The report takes issue with specific exhibits, such as an 1840 statue of George Washington that includes a depiction of Her-



The exterior of the Smithsonian's National Museum of American History, in Washington. FILE

cules. The work's accompanying text describes "the perceived courage of the American

people." That language, the report says, "refuses to affirm the exceptional courage of the

American people."

But the report's "main concerns" involve what is not there. Visitors today, it says, "will find no major exhibit dedicated to America's founding era, George Washington, Thomas Jefferson, other founding fathers, the Continental Congress, the pilgrims, the Puritans or major moments of the American Revolution." Instead, it claims, many founders are presented chiefly in terms of their connection to slavery.

In a statement, a spokesperson for the Smithsonian, Julissa Marengo, said, "For more than 180 years, the Smithsonian has served the American public with nonpartisan and indepen-

dent scholarship, and we remain committed to doing so."

The Organization of American Historians blasted the report in a statement Monday, accusing the administration of presenting a partisan ideological attack in the guise of historical critique. "The National Museum of American History interprets America's history through its vast collection," it said.

"This report's objective is to punish it for doing that in a way that makes US history accessible to and reflective of all Americans. The report is only the latest chapter in a broader, systematic campaign that now targets an institution that was never meant to answer to any

single administration."

The group accused the administration of ignoring decades of scholarship and trying to "erase the conflict, struggle and diversity — the complexity — that have always defined the American experience. The White House did not respond to a request for comment.

The Smithsonian has long been regarded as independent of the executive branch. But in an effort to have much greater influence on cultural matters in Washington, Trump has focused on the Smithsonian since March 2025, when he issued an executive order titled "Restoring Truth and Sanity to American History." NYT

NBFCs' GOLD LOAN OUTSTANDING HAS RISEN 136% IN THE LAST TWO YEARS

Jewellery-backed loans soar 70%, lead NBFC retail credit growth

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 7

GOLD LOANS are glittering as never before, driving a surge in credit growth for non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) and emerging as the fastest-growing segment of retail credit amid high gold prices.

Outstanding NBFC loans against gold jewellery surged by 69.9% year-on-year to Rs 3.29 lakh crore by the end of May 2026 from Rs 1.94 lakh in May 2025, far outpacing the 19.5% growth in overall retail loans, according to the latest Reserve Bank of India data.

Gold loan outstanding of NBFC players has jumped by 136% from Rs 1.4 lakh crore in the last two years.

As a result, gold loans by NBFCs accounted for a much larger share of retail credit, reflecting increased borrower preference for secured lending backed by rising gold prices.

"In a country where household gold holdings are significant, the rapid growth of gold loans is enabling households to convert a traditionally held asset into a source of accessible finance. This is supporting greater financial inclusion while enabling consumers to meet a wide range of personal and livelihood needs," said

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Vn2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

Manish Jain, Country Managing Director of Experian India. The growth story is also becoming increasingly broad-based across the country.

While Southern India continues to remain an important market for gold loans, strong sourcing growth in FY26 was seen in states such as Uttar Pradesh (138%), West Bengal (112%), Rajasthan (105%) and Maharashtra (102%), highlighting growing acceptance of gold-backed lending beyond its traditional regional concentration and indicating a broader pan-India expansion trend, Experian said.

There is evidence that gold loans are becoming an increasingly important gateway to formal credit for a wider spectrum of consumers. By unlocking the value of household gold, priority sector gold loans are helping convert dormant assets into productive capital, especially supporting women-led households, micro-enterprises, livelihood generation and greater participation in the formal financial ecosystem.

While companies have not yet reported any signs of stress in the segment, the practice of rolling over gold loans by making partial payments to extend the tenure and reset the loan period has become widespread.

• NBFC LOAN GROWTH DRIVERS

THE GROWTH story is increasingly becoming broad-based. Loans against gold jewellery surged by 138% in Uttar Pradesh, in West Bengal it rose by 112%, in Rajasthan by 105% and in Maharashtra by 102%.

IT HIGHLIGHTS growing acceptance of gold-backed lending beyond its traditional regional concentration.

COMMERCIAL REAL estate also emerged as the one of fastest-



growing mainstream categories in credit growth with outstanding credit to the segment surging 40.2% to Rs 1.196 lakh crore in May 2026 from Rs 85,317 cr a year ago.

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1
However, latest RBI guidelines have placed strict limits on such rollovers.

Borrowers are now required to fully repay bullet loans within 12 months, and lenders are barred from "evergreening" loans by repeatedly extending the tenure without conducting fresh appraisals, said an industry player. Muthoot Finance, the largest player in the segment, reported Rs 1.65 lakh crore worth of gold loans and 196 tonnes of gold as security from customers in FY26.

The industry portfolio, including banks, also expanded substantially from Rs 6.3 lakh

crore in March 2023 to Rs.19.4 lakh crore by March 2026, reflecting sustained momentum across the category.

Retail loans accounted for the biggest share in non-banks' loans at 43%, with gold loans — which are part of retail loans — making up 5.6% of all loans as at the end of May. Loans to industry had a share of 37.4%, with that of services at 13%.

Real estate loans spurt by 40.2%

Commercial real estate has emerged as the one of fastest-growing mainstream categories in credit growth in the

Rajesh Exports: NFRA begins its investigation

Mumbai: The National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA) is looking into the revenue misstatements case at Rajesh Exports, but it will not be possible to share a timeline on the probe, a top official at the auditors' watchdog said Tuesday.

"Yes, we have started our processes," NFRA chairperson Nitin Gupta said on the sidelines of an event organised by Ficci here.

Last month, capital markets regulator SEBI issued an order in which Rajesh Exports was found to have indulged in misstating revenues over a long period, pegging the overall discrepancies at Rs 15.5 lakh crore.

As per subsequent reports, Sebi had written to NFRA seeking examination of the errant entity's auditors. Gupta also called for genuine board independence in promoter-driven companies, pointing out that as AI influences corporate decision-making, a critical look at an issue may be essential. PTI

• BRIEFLY



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday addressed an event organised by the Toy Association of India in New Delhi. She asked manufacturers to aspire to capture at least a one-fourth of the global toy market share. PHOTO: X/@NSITHARAMANOFFC

Release services production index within 60 days: Panel

New Delhi: An expert panel recommended compiling sectoral indices monthly and releasing the Index of Services Production (ISP) within 60 days after the reference month. Earlier, the Statistics Ministry constituted a Technical Advisory

Committee on ISP (TAC-ISP) in May 2025 under the Chairpersonship of Debjani Ghosh, Distinguished Fellow, NITI Aayog. As part of the consultative process, an approach paper on the compilation of the ISP was released on April 27. PTI

BHEL partners with German firm for green hydrogen project

New Delhi: Bharat Heavy Electricals on Tuesday said it has tied up with thyssenkrupp nucera India for indigenisation and local manufacturing of alkaline electrolyser systems for green hydrogen projects in India. PTI

SBI Life ties up with IIT Mumbai

Mumbai: SBI Life Insurance has signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the IIT, Mumbai, to establish 'Bharat's AI & Cyber Innovation Hub for Insurance', a joint research and innovation centre dedicated to building deep-technology defences for the insurance sector. ENS

India flags flaws in US' Section 301 tariff probe

Mukesh Jagota
New Delhi, July 7

INDIA HAS flagged several flaws in the way the US has initiated and conducted its investigation into alleged forced-labour content in Indian imports. It also suggested bilateral dialogue to address any specific concern of the US in this regard.

In its formal response to the Report in Section 301 investigations on imports of goods with forced labour that has proposed 12.5% additional tariffs on India, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry has said the office of US Trade Representative (USTR) has issued a sweeping, generalised determination across 60 economies without performing an economy-specific, or product-specific analysis of India's actual laws and practices.

The USTR probe covers 60 economies, including the European Union (EU). India has also sought reconsideration of the proposed tariffs.

Separately, the USTR is investigating India, the EU, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, South Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico and Japan over policies that allegedly enable excess manufacturing capacity



The USTR probe covers 60 economies, including EU. REUTERS

and undermine the US industrial base. The findings could pave the way for another round of additional tariffs.

The investigations are seen as part of Washington's efforts to rebuild its tariff architecture following the US Supreme Court's verdict on reciprocal tariffs. The Section 301 investigations are also part of the ongoing India-US trade agreement negotiations.

Public hearings on the forced-labour investigation began on Tuesday, with the Indian government and industry scheduled to present their arguments on Wednesday.

India argued that the USTR has failed to meet the legal threshold under Section 301(d) of the Trade Act by concluding that India's acts, policies or practices relating to imports are unreasonable. FE

Domestic air traffic soars to 1.54 cr in May: DGCA

New Delhi: After losing momentum in April, when domestic passenger traffic declined both sequentially and year-on-year amid softer travel demand and rising operating costs, the domestic aviation sector regained altitude in May, driven by strong summer travel demand and airlines focusing capacity on high-demand routes.

According to data released by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), domestic airlines carried 1.54 crore passengers in May 2026, up 9.2% from 1.41 crore in the corresponding month last year. Passenger traffic also rebounded from 1.38 crore in April 2026, reversing the previous month's slowdown.

For the first five months of 2026, domestic carriers flew 7.29 crore passengers, compared

with 7.16 crore during the same period last year, registering annual growth of 1.91%. On a month-on-month basis, passenger traffic rose 9.49% in May, highlighting the sharp recovery in travel demand during the peak summer holiday season.

The rebound suggests domestic travel demand remained resilient despite operational headwinds that had weighed on airlines in recent months, including elevated operating costs, aircraft shortages and airspace disruptions. Airlines also continued to optimise network deployment by prioritising higher-yielding routes as demand picked up.

Market leader IndiGo retained its dominant position, although its market share slipped marginally to 64.9% in May from 65% in April. FE

• MARKETS

			
Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▼	US Dollar ▼
78,180.72	24,398.70	₹1,44,083	₹94.97
-104.35	-31.65		
-0.13%	-0.13%	Silver ▼	Oil ▲
		₹2,27,200	\$68.69

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 6, 2026

How a price surge fuelled gold loans, sparked talk of behavioural change

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 7

THE UNPRECEDENTED rise in gold prices over the last one year — albeit one that has cooled in recent months — has led to such an increase in loans against the yellow metal that experts think Indians are now willing to pawn what they hold of it more easily than before even as prices have moderated.

Over the last few years, the people taking gold loans have been increasingly more credit-worthy, with Simranjeet Singh, Chief Executive Officer of the SME and retail verticals at Anand Rath Global Finance, saying that prime and above-prime borrowers' participation has risen from 43% to 52%. This, according to Singh, suggests "a structural shift in that borrowers now consider gold loans as a major financial tool rather than an emergency last resort option."

What are gold loans being used for? Experts note financing business growth, travel, and even higher education, while the Reserve Bank of India noted last week in its Financial Stability Report that existing borrowers have used higher gold prices to secure larger loans and roll over their debt.

The growth in gold loans has indeed been extraordinary. According to new data from the RBI on Tuesday, loans given by non-banks against gold jewellery were up a massive 70% year-on-year as at the end of May — the segment with by far the highest growth. From 3% in May 2024, loans against gold jewellery now make up almost 6% of non-banks' loans and amount to Rs 3.3 lakh crore.

For banks, gold loan growth is an even more extraordinary 105%, with total gold loans standing at Rs 5.1 lakh crore as at



NBFCs' gold loan growth was 70% in May, while for banks it stood at 105%. REUTERS

the end of May. And while non-banks saw the share of gold loans almost double in two years, for banks the increase has been almost 4x: from 0.64% in May 2024 to 2.4% in May this year.

Gold-backed credit

To put these gold loan growth numbers in context, non-banks' total loans were up 14% year-on-year as at the end of May, while credit growth for banks was 18%.

In its Financial Stability Report, the RBI also noted that the rapid growth in gold loans has coincided with a decline in the increase in outstanding personal loans for borrowers who have both personal loans and gold loans. "This trend is particularly pronounced among sub-prime borrowers, whose outstanding personal loan balances and loan accounts have declined," the central bank said.

According to TransUnion CIBIL, the share of gold loans in banks and non-banks' total loans had increased to 11.1% in December 2025, second only to housing loans, from 5.9% in March 2022. And this was before the January 2026 price surge that saw global gold prices hit all-time highs of

around \$5,500 per ounce.

But what happens now that gold prices are closer to \$4,000/oz? For the RBI, elevated price volatility "merits continued vigilance". "A prolonged correction in gold prices could weaken collateral protection, increase borrower stress, and result in higher delinquencies," the central bank said.

An analyst tracking gold at a domestic brokerage said the precious metal "is not just for hoarding for a rainy day" anymore but is also "a good option for leveraging in a society where wage growth has been sluggish". With gold loans becoming more and more popular, it could lead to a behavioural change.

The public's increased willingness to borrow against their gold also hits a sweet spot for lenders, with Singh of Anand Rath pointing out that the preference for secured lending by financial institutions indicates that "the rise in the gold loan segment is here to stay and is not just a cyclical spike". The rate of expansion may moderate, but in the long-term, Singh said, the segment is set to grow even more.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

ECLGS 5.0 sanctions cross Rs 1.55 lakh cr within 2 months of launch

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 7

THE CENTRAL government has issued guarantees worth Rs 1.55 lakh crore under the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS) 5.0 within two months of its launch, reflecting the scheme's rapid absorption across the lending ecosystem.

Approved by the Union Cabinet on May 5, 2026, the scheme has issued 4,11,497 guarantees so far.

MSMEs (micro, small, and medium enterprises) account for 98% of all guarantees issued (by number), and 82% of the total guaranteed amount is also towards MSMEs, the government data showed.

The scheme aims to facilitate additional credit of Rs 2.55

lakh crore to existing borrowers by March 2027.

By extending 100% guarantee coverage to additional loans of MSMEs and 90% to other business segments, the scheme has allowed financial institutions to lend more confidently, ensuring liquidity reaches the needy sectors.

The scheme provides 100% guarantee coverage for MSMEs and 90% for non-MSMEs, to facilitate additional credit of Rs 2.55 lakh crore to existing borrowers.

Wide participation by banks and non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), customer outreach initiatives, and government-led awareness programmes have contributed to its swift uptake across sectors. The results from ECLGS 5.0 reflect the government's

continued commitment to building a resilient, responsive credit ecosystem. As the scheme evolves and outreach expands, it is expected to further strengthen liquidity support for businesses including MSMEs and enable entrepreneurs to meet their liquidity needs in the times of external challenges.

To maximise awareness and adoption, the Department of Financial Services (DFS) has led a structured outreach campaign across the country.

These outreach programmes are intended to ensure that eligible borrowers are aware of the Scheme and are able to access its benefits, while Member Lending Institutions (MLIs) are equipped to facilitate its effective implementation. FE

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of India Undertaking)

NOTICE INVITING OPEN-E-TENDER DATED 07.07.2026

On behalf of Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd, Senior Divisional Engineer, Ratnagiri is inviting Open E Tender For the following work: **Ten No: KR-RN-W-2026-17, Name of work : Deep screening, shallow screening, sleeper replacement, destressing of track etc under SSE/VI/wade section. Estimated cost: Rs. 179.14, 184/- EMD: Rs. 3,58,300/- Last date and Time of depositing of tender on line: 30.07.2026 upto 15.00 hrs.** For further details, contact office of Regional Railway Manager, Office, MIDC area, Mirjole, Ratnagiri. (Web site: <https://www.ireps.gov.in>)

OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR GENERAL, MEDICAL HEALTH & F.W.
Danda Lakhound, Sahstradhara Road, P.O. Gujraa, Dehradun, Uttarakhand

Letter No.: 27P/PPP/05/2024/TC/26245 Dated : 07.07.2026

Government of Uttarakhand Short E-tender Notice

1. Name of Work-OPERATION & MAINTENANCE CONTRACT OF EMERGENCY RESPONSE SERVICES IN UTTARAKHAND 108 Ambulance Service.

2. Date and time of publishing of tender: 09/07/2026 till 14:00 PM

3. Pre-Bid Meeting : 23/07/2026 till 14:00 PM

4. Closing date of online submission of Tender : 30/07/2026, till 14:00 (IST)

5. Opening date of technical bid Tender : 30/07/2026, till 15:00 (IST)

6. Details of subsequent addendum/corrigendum/cancellation etc, may be obtained from the website <https://uktenders.gov.in>

7. Portal Registration : The bidder intending to participate in the bid is Required to register in the portal using his/her active personal/official email id as his/her Login id and attach his/her valid digital signature certificate (DSC) to his/her unique login.

8. Pre Bid meeting will be held in the office of the Director General, Medical Health & F.W. Danda Lakhound, P.O. Gujraa, Sahstradhara road, Dehradun, Uttarakhand.

For further queries, the bidders may contact through email-mhvutarakhand@yahoo.com and at Room No. 52, Office of the Director General, Medical Health & Family Welfare, Danda Lakhound, P.O. Gujraa, Sahstradhara road, Dehradun, Uttarakhand

Director (PPP)
Medical Health & F.W. Dehradun, Uttarakhand

SOUTHERN POWER DISTRIBUTION COMPANY OF TELANGANA LIMITED
e-Procurement Tender Notice (Paper Notification)

TGSPDCL intends to float tender for procurement of (a) Bulk SMS gateway services and Whatsapp business messaging & rule based chat bot services (b) 11 KV 200A (TT) GOAB Switches with Polymer Insulators (c) 34 Sq.mm AAA Conductor (d) LaserJet Printers (e) 33KV 3x400 Sqmm Heat Shrinkable Indoor End Termination Kits (f) 11 KV 3x185 Sqmm Heat Shrinkable Straight Through Joining Kits (g) MS Channel 75x40 mm (h) Test benches-4 position on e-procurement platform.

For further details of each item above, please visit www.southernpower.org, www.tender.telangana.gov.in and www.auction.telangana.gov.in.

Phone:040-23431360, 1033, 1035, 1026 Sd/-CHIEF ENGINEER (P&MM)
TGSPDCL, Hyderabad.

DIPR R.O.No. 281-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:07-07-2026

gmda

Guwahati Metropolitan Development Authority

STATFED Building, Bhangagarh, Guwahati - 781005
Website: www.gmda.co.in Tel: 0361-2529650/9824
E-mail: ceo_gmda@yahoo.com Fax: 0361-2529991

No. GMDA/DEV/40/2026/05 Date: 06-07-2026

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL (RFP)

Guwahati Metropolitan Development Authority (GMDA), Guwahati, Assam invites Request for Proposal (RFP) in prescribed standard format from empaneled consultants/ firms under GMDA to participate in the RFP process for selection of most suitable among all the participated agencies to provide "Consultancy Services for the Development of a Children's Park at the Bank of Brahmaputra River at Garal, Guwahati". Interested participants can apply online through the Govt. of Assam, e-tender portal i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in from 08-07-2026 to 29-07-2026.

Sd/- (Anbamuthan M.P., IAS)
Chief Executive Officer
Guwahati Metropolitan Dev. Authority
Bhangagarh, Guwahati - 5

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If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

• HISTORY

Arches that lead to Charminar: Plans to restore the Char Kaman

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 7

HYDERABAD IS known for its iconic Charminar, the Old City structure that bears the signature of the Qutb Shahi dynasty's architectural majesty. But what's lesser known are the four ornamental gateways that lead to it, called the Char Kaman. The Telangana government has announced that the gateways will soon get a facelift.

History and significance

The Charminar was built between 1589 and 1591 by Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah, the fifth ruler of the Qutb Shahi dynasty. According to Mohammed Safiullah, a Hyderabad historian and honorary managing trustee of Deccan Heritage Trust, the Kamans could have been built around 1594. The 20th century historian Syed Ali Asghar Bilgrami writes that after the completion of the Charminar, Shah commissioned the construction of four ornamental arches or gateways around the Charminar.

According to Bilgrami's book *Landmarks of Deccan* (1927), the four arches had names differing from their present nomenclature. The west arch was first named Daulat Khana-e Ali, or the gate of the royal residence; whereas the one on the east was named Naqqar Khana, or gate of the palace where drums are beaten. "Generally the central area of the four arches was termed Jilau Khana or the royal vestibule," Bilgrami writes.

One of the Char Kaman in Hyderabad. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

The Kaman to the north under which "a huge elephant with a canopied litter can easily pass" were later called Machli Kaman, or the fish arch. This is because, Bilgrami writes, "a big fish made of bamboo and paper resembling a miniature aeroplane is suspended in the centre of the arch on every lunar new year".

The rest of the arches were called Charminar Arch (south); Kali Kaman or Kaman of Shambhoo Pershad (east), which stands for the black arch; Kaman Sher Dil or Sihr Batil (west), meaning gateway for the lion hearted or the magic breaker. These names are still in use in Hyderabad.

Bilgrami writes: "Formerly the Qutub Shahi palaces were situated towards the western arch, but the relentless hand of time has totally obliterated them." The arches marked the entrances to the city of Hyderabad. According to Bilgrami, the arches saw immense traffic during the Qutb Shahi period as "the adjoining outhouses were used as a sitting place for the nobles and officials. These noblemen used to come every morning with their retinue and attendants and after reaching the royal vestibule which was in the centre of the four arches, the suite and retinue were left behind and they used to proceed unattended for the audience of the king."

Restoration plans

The restoration work is expected to focus on structural repairs and conservation of heritage features. The work would aim to improve the overall condition of the monuments while retaining their historical character. Heritage conservationists have long called for the preservation of the Char Kaman, pointing to the damage caused over the years by growing urbanisation and resultant pollution.

Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi announced last week that the restoration project has received a major boost, with the government granting administrative sanction to invite tenders and appoint a consultant for the work. Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

• SCIENCE

Birds' words: Why a scientist won Rs 95-lakh prize for work on zebra finches



EXPERT EXPLAINS

ANTONIO JOSE OSUNA-MASCARÓ
ANIMAL COGNITION RESEARCHER, UNIVERSITY OF VETERINARY MEDICINE, VIENNA

AN AMERICAN scientist has won a \$100,000-prize for her work on how zebra finches communicate with each other. Dr Julie Elie at the University of California, Berkeley, won the Collier Dolittle Challenge for Two-Way Interspecies Communication for discovering that "zebra finches classify their calls according to meaning more so than acoustics," the UK-based Collier Foundation said in a statement. Elie identified 11 different calls that the birds make, and their meanings.

Dr. Antonio Jose Osuna-Mascaró explains how scientists study birds' 'language', and why Elie's work is significant. He spoke to **Yashee**.

Scientists have long known that animals use distinct calls in different situations. What is new in Elie's work?
Traditionally, humans observe animals, record their calls, examine their acoustic structure and the circumstances in which

they are produced, and then divide them into categories. But that leaves an important question unanswered: do those categories also exist for the animals themselves?

These researchers trained zebra finches to distinguish the different call types in their repertoire, using many examples. The birds were remarkably good at doing so.

The strongest result, in my opinion, comes from their mistakes. The researchers compared the birds' pattern of errors with what would be expected purely from acoustic similarity. The birds were more likely to confuse different calls associated with similar meanings (behavioural functions) rather than sound similarity. This suggests that their perceptual organisation reflects not only what calls sound like, but also something about what those calls are used for.

What are the main methods to investigate whether a call carries specific information or meaning?

There are several complementary approaches. The starting point is usually naturalistic observation: researchers ask when a call is produced, who produces it, who is present and what happens afterwards. Acoustic analysis can then determine whether sounds produced in different situations are structurally distinct.

Playback experiments have been especially important. Researchers play a recorded call in the absence of the original event and ask whether receivers respond appropriately. Classic studies of alarm calls, for



Elie identified 11 different calls that zebra finches make. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

example, showed that animals can produce different responses to calls associated with different predators. Studying alarm calls is the most common and easiest approach to study vocal communication in the animal world, since we can perceive the trigger, the vocalisation, and the response.

What is unusual about this study is its systematic scale and the use of the birds' own classification errors as data. They compared two things: which calls an acoustic classifier tends to confuse, and which calls the birds themselves tend to confuse. The fact that these two error patterns are not identical is central to the argument. The birds' additional errors appear to group calls according to behavioural function, to their "meaning".

So, the study asks: how is the entire repertoire organised in the bird's perceptual space?

What can machine-learning tools detect that earlier generations of researchers could not, and their risks?

I would actually use this study as a good example of why we should not confuse machine learning with understanding.

Machine-learning tools are enormously useful because they can process quantities of data that would be impossible for a human. They can identify subtle combinations of acoustic features, detect structure in large repertoires, distinguish individuals, discover graded variation and find statistical regularities across millions of vocalisations.

But a machine finding categories does not mean that those categories matter to the animal.

This study illustrates that distinction very nicely. The researchers use computational tools to characterise the acoustic relationships among calls, but the crucial evidence comes from comparing those computational classifications with the behaviour of the birds. The birds' perceptual organisation contains structure that cannot be completely predicted from acoustics alone.

That is, in my view, the correct relationship between AI and experimental biology. Machine learning can reveal patterns and generate hypotheses, but we still need experiments to establish whether animals perceive those patterns, use them and respond to them flexibly.

• RAM TEMPLE CONTROVERSY

With CEO post, how Ram Temple Trust is changing



DEEPTIMAN TIWARY

THE RAM TEMPLE Trust has accepted the resignations of its two most influential office-bearers, General Secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra, and announced that it will appoint a Chief Executive Officer (CEO) for the first time. The move marks the biggest administrative overhaul of the body that runs the Ayodhya temple since it was constituted in 2020.

How did the Trust come into being?

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra owes its existence to the Supreme Court's November 2019 Ayodhya judgment. The Court directed that the government formulate a scheme within three months for setting up the trust and transferring the disputed land to it. Acting under the Acquisition of Certain Area at Ayodhya Act, 1993, the Centre constituted the Trust on February 5, 2020, and transferred the acquired land to it through a Gazette notification.

Unlike Tirupati, Jagannath, Vaishno Devi or Kashi Vishwanath, the Ram Temple is not governed by a dedicated statute enacted by a state legislature. Its legal foundation is a combination of the Supreme Court's 2019 judgment, the 1993 Ayodhya Acquisition Act, the Central government's scheme and notification, and the trust deed of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra. The trust is therefore neither a conventional private religious trust nor a statutory temple board established by legislation. It occupies a unique institutional position: a public religious trust brought into existence by executive action in implementation of a judicial mandate.

Who runs the Trust?

The 15-member Trust is the temple's highest decision-making body. It is chaired by Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, although because of age and ill health, day-to-day leadership gradually came to rest with Rai, who emerged as the institution's public face.

The trust deed provides for permanent members, nominated members and ex-officio representatives, ensuring representation from the religious community as well as the Centre and the Uttar Pradesh government. Construction has been supervised by a committee headed by former Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, Nripendra Mishra, as ex-officio member.

The Trust also includes senior advocate K Parasaran, IAS officer Prashant Lokhande as Central government representative, and IAS officers Sanjay Prasad and Shashank Tripathi as UP government representatives. Rest of the members are revered seers from the Hindu community associated with the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.

Unlike statutory temple boards headed by executive officers or chief administrators, the Ram Temple's administration has so far largely been driven by trustees and office-bearers themselves.

Who manages the temple every day?

Unlike Tirupati or Vaishno Devi, the Ram Temple has not had a professional chief executive. Instead, administrative responsibilities have been divided among individual office-bearers.

• KEY FACES OF THE TRUST



GOVIND DEV GIRI, TRUST TREASURER

A religious speaker from Maharashtra. Involved in maintaining audited records of Trust income and expenditure.



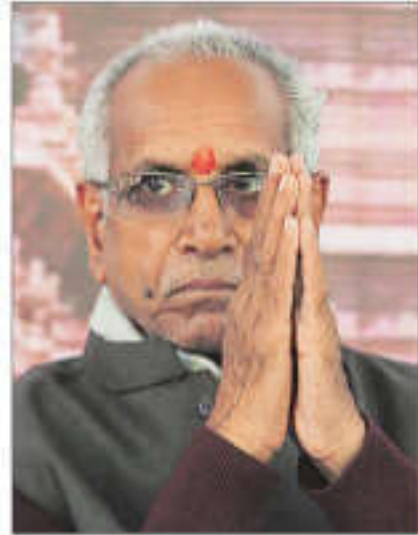
MAHANT NRITYA GOPAL DAS, TRUST PRESIDENT

Also the head of Maniram Das Chavani in Ayodhya. Long been associated with the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.



KRISHNA MOHAN, INTERIM GENERAL SECRETARY

RSS office-bearer, ex-Indian Forest Service officer. Became trustee in 2025 after the death of a founding member.



CHAMPAT RAI, EX-GENERAL SECRETARY

RSS and VHP member who was the person in charge. Has resigned following the recent theft row.



ANIL MISHRA, EX-MEMBER

RSS member who supervised all sales and purchases. Has resigned following the theft row. SIT probe has raised questions about his role.

• STRUCTURAL CONTRAST: RAM TEMPLE TRUST VS OTHER MAJOR SHRINES

Temple	Ram Temple	Tirupati	Mata Vaishno Devi	Jagannath Temple	Siddhivinayak Temple	Kashi Vishwanath Temple
Governing legislation	Supreme Court judgment + 1993 Act + Trust Deed	AP Charitable & Hindu Religious Institutions Act, 1987	J&K Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Act, 1988	Shri Jagannath Temple Act, 1955	Shree Siddhivinayak Ganapati Temple Trust Act, 1980	UP Sri Kashi Vishwanath Temple Act, 1983
Legal nature of management	Independent public charitable trust	State government endowments board	Autonomous statutory board	Autonomous statutory managing committee	Government-controlled public trust	Statutory board of trustees
Executive head / Chief administrator	Proposed CEO / General Secretary	Executive Officer (EO): A senior, active IAS Officer posted by the state government to run operations.	Chief Executive Officer (CEO): An active IAS or KAS (Civil Services) Officer deployed by the state administration.	Chief Administrator: A senior bureaucrat (usually IAS or senior OAS) appointed directly by the Odisha Law Dept.	Executive Officer: A state-appointed government officer who acts as the ex-officio Secretary to the Trust.	Chief Executive Officer (CEO): A senior state-vetted bureaucrat/PCS officer appointed under Section 16 of the Act.
Financial audit grid	Private auditing	State audit department	Statutory audit	State Law Dept oversight	State vetted	State monitored
RTI status	Exempt	Fully bound	Fully bound	Fully bound	Fully bound	Not known

Rai oversaw overall administration, Mishra supervised donations and recruitment linked to the counting system, retired banker Subhash Srivastava managed the counting process, while former RSS *prant pracharak* Gopal Rao looked after day-to-day temple operations.

The donation controversy exposed the limitations of this model. What had worked during the construction of the temple came under strain once it became one of the country's busiest pilgrimage centres, receiving around one lakh devotees every day.

With a significant number of trustees and office bearers being connected with the RSS — Rai, Mishra, Rao and Srivastava are all from the RSS — a "Sanghecosystem" virtually runs the temple, sources said.

The Temple's recruitment rules are not public, but police investigations into the case have found that quite a few people in the temple were engaged for daily work in an ad hoc manner and appointment letters for many have not been found yet. The six outsourced counting agents, who were supposedly hired by the State Bank of India for counting donations, were actually recommended to the bank by Trust office bearers. One of them is the relative of Rai's driver Tinnu Yadav.

Yadav, who is under arrest, was entrusted with the keys to the donation boxes. The Trust has not yet made it clear under what rules he had been given that responsibility.

Investigations have also revealed that while a standard operating procedure (SOP) was drafted under Mishra's leadership for temple operations, its implementation left a lot to be desired.

Limited information

Unlike other major temple bodies, much of the Ram Temple Trust's internal rulebook remains outside public domain.

By contrast, the governing Acts, rules and administrative structures of other institutions are publicly available.

The *Indian Express* had earlier reported that a private internal audit commissioned in 2020 had described the management at the execution level as "highly unprofessional" and flagged the absence of SOPs, systematic financial records, defined reporting hierarchies, HR processes and maker-checker controls.

Why appoint a CEO now?

The Trust's decision marks its biggest administrative restructuring since 2020.

Unlike the existing arrangement, where trustees directly supervised several operational functions, the CEO is expected to oversee day-to-day administration, leaving the Trust to focus on policy decisions.

The move brings the Ram Temple closer to the governance model followed by several older temple institutions (*see table*).

The appointment comes in the backdrop of the donation controversy and the RSS's call for "transparent financial management and efficient administrative systems" to restore public confidence.

What does the rulebook say?

Unlike most other major temple bodies, much of the Ram Temple Trust's internal rulebook remains outside public domain.

While the Centre notified the Trust's creation in February 2020, the detailed government scheme under which it was constituted and the Trust Deed have not been publicly released. An RTI applicant seeking these records was denied access after the Ministry of Home Affairs told the Central Information Commission (CIC) that the documents formed part of a "confidential file" be-

cause of the matter's sensitivity. The CIC also held that the Trust is not a "public authority" under the RTI Act and is therefore not obliged to disclose its internal documents.

Consequently, many aspects of the Trust's functioning have entered the public domain only during controversies.

The donation row led the Trust to publicly explain its counting process, inventory registers and handling of donated valuables. Following the resignations of Champat Rai and Anil Mishra, another internal rule became public when senior trustee K Parasaran clarified that under the Trust's constitution, a resignation takes effect immediately upon being submitted and does not require formal acceptance.

Earlier litigation over land purchases similarly brought into court parts of the Trust's internal framework to explain the powers of office-bearers and committees.

By contrast, the governing Acts, rules and administrative structures of other institutions are publicly available. The Ram Temple's institutional architecture has instead become visible largely through litigation, official statements and crises rather than through an accessible rulebook.

That distinction has acquired greater significance in the wake of the donation controversy. In its first public statement on the issue, the RSS itself called for an end to the "confusion and uncertainty" surrounding the temple's administration. The proposed appointment of a CEO appears to be part of that broader effort to institutionalise the administration of a temple that has rapidly grown into one of the country's biggest religious institutions.

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

The major risk is anthropomorphism by algorithm. If an AI system discovers 47 statistically separable vocal clusters, it is tempting to call them 47 "words". But clusters may reflect individual identity, sex, emotional arousal, or microphone characteristics.

Some researchers now speak of two-way interspecies communication rather than simply decoding animal signals.

There is a large conceptual distance between decoding a signal and having a conversation.

At the simplest level, two-way communication requires that information genuinely passes in both directions. A human or machine-generated signal should change the animal's behaviour in a predictable way, and the animal should also be able to produce signals whose interpretation changes our subsequent behaviour.

But a convincing case for something resembling conversation would require considerably more. The exchange should be contingent: the meaning of one contribution should depend on what happened immediately before.

It should also be flexible, rather than a fixed chain of trained responses. Ideally, the system should allow some form of generalisation to new situations or new combinations, because otherwise it is difficult to distinguish communication from an elaborate sequence of conditioned behaviours.

Personally, the most convincing evidence would be an exchange in which an

animal spontaneously provides information that the human does not already possess, the human responds on the basis of that information, and the animal then adjusts its subsequent communication according to that response.

If scientists eventually manage to communicate meaningfully with certain animals, what are the biggest implications — for animal welfare, conservation, farming, or laboratory research?

That would be fantastic, of course, like science fiction to me. We have been close to that in the past, with Alex the parrot and with Kanzi the bonobo, but those were interactions far from what a naïve perspective would expect from a conversation between species.

I think we should be careful not to imagine a future in which animals simply tell us in human-like sentences that they are frightened or in pain. Communication systems are adapted to the ecological and social problems faced by each species. What matters to a zebra finch, an elephant or a cuttlefish may be structured in ways that do not map neatly onto human categories.

It's important to free ourselves from trying to "force" other species into our own way to understand the world. It's extremely interesting to learn about the vocal communication of other species, of course, and there might be many surprises waiting to be discovered. We have had to reshape our understanding of animal communication multiple times, and we should be open to do it again in the future.

epaper.indianexpress.com

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Shally Sareen W/o Amit Tuli, R/o 158 Jeevan Nagar, New Delhi-110014, have changed my name to Sakshi Tuli.

0071046177-1

I, BHAGAT RAM S/o Maman Singh R/o-A-9 Punjabi Basti Nangloi West Delhi-110041 have changed my name to BHAGAT RAM

0040864618-5

I, Rashmi Arora W/o Rajiv Pal R/o-C21, C-Block, Brij Vihar, Chander Nagar, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Rashmi.

0071046213-1

I, MUBASHSHIR, S/O JAVED AHMAD, R/O, H.NO-K-26, Jamia Nagar Batla-House, New Friends-Colony, Delhi-110025, have changed my name to MUBASHSHIR KHAN for all purposes.

0040864645-5

I, AZMAT PRAVEEN W/o Chand Babu, 12-A-64, Gali No.-2, Vijay Mohalla, Majupur, Delhi -53, have changed my name to AZMAT PARVEEN.

0071046254-1

I Babita Dhama W/o, Trivender Kumar R/o B-29, Gali No. -2, First Pusta New Usmanpur, Bhajan Pura North East Delhi Delhi-110053 have changed my name to Babita Rani.

0040864578-1

I, Amalendu Biswas, S/o Bhim Biswas, R/o H.No.A-18, Shiv Mandir, Khadar, Sarita Vihar, New Delhi-110076, my name is wrongly mentioned in my Pan card, Aadhar card & Bank account as Amalendu Biswas, have changed my name to Amal Biswas for all future purposes.

0040864596-2

I, Jyoti Rana, D/o Kirpal Singh, permanent resident of Sonipat, Haryana, India-131001, presently residing at Arcadia, CA-91007, hereby give notice that I am changing the name of my minor daughter, holder on Indian passport U7395003, from Eva to Eva Rana. Henceforth, she shall be known as Eva Rana for all official purposes.

0040864513-1

I, PUJA SALUJA, W/O-VIKAS RASWANT, R/O BH 08 AMARPALI VILLAGE NYAY KHAND-2 INDIRAPURAM GHAZIABAD U.P.201014, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO PUJA RASWANT.

0040864595-5

I,Indu Devi W/o-Anil Kumar Yadav, Vill-Indara, P.O.-Indara Dist-Mau (U.P.), have changed my name from Indu Devi to Indu kumari, for all future purposes.

0040864601-7

I, Tannu Puri w/o-Himanshu Puri, R/O-A-68/1, Sudershan Park, New Delhi-15, have changed my name to Veerawali Puri, for all purposes.

0040864512-2

I, KRRISH SHASHIDHAR, S/O-SHASHI DHAR, R/O C-5025 GAUR, GREEN CITY VAIBHAV-KHAND INDIRAPURAM, GHAZIABAD U.P.201014, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO KRRISH S. AGRAWAL.

0040864595-7

I, hitherto known as M C Verma, S/o-D C Verma, R/o A-1/21, Sector-7, Rohini, North-West-Delhi, Delhi-110085, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Mool Chand Verma.

0040864618-7

I, Abdul Rahma S/o Hurmat R/o Nagla Sharif Khan, Dayantpur, GB Nagar have changed my name to Abdul Rahman.

0071046221-1

I, Sudha W/o-Rajiv Bhati, R/o-A-702, Brestech Park View Spa, Sector-47, Gurugram, Haryana-122018, have changed my name to Sudha Bhati, for all future purposes.

0040864645-7

I, Mohammad Shahid S/o Abdul Hameed R/o-359, Asalatpur, Farakhnagar, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Mohd Shahid.

0071046262-1

I, Garima Sekhri D/o Munish Kumar, R/o 665/4, Gali, No.2, Military Road, Anand Parbat, Central Delhi, Delhi-110005, have changed my name to Garima for all purposes.

0040864596-4

I, Tammo Devi Rawat W/o Puran Singh Rawat R/o 161-A sainik farm carriapa marg gate no-2 khudki extension, sainik farm South Delhi-110062 have change my name to Tammo Devi for all future purpose

0071046189-1

I, Amanpreet Kaur Kharb, W/O-VIKAS KHRAB, R/O FLAT, NO.259, SECOND FLOOR, POKKET-4, SECTOR-12, DWARKA, SOUTH WEST DELHI, DELHI-110078, have changed my name, from Amanpreet Kaur Kharb to Amanpreet Kaur for all, future purposes.

0040864601-9

I, Sweety wife of Shri Girish Panwar Residence of RZ-8, First Floor, Indra Park Extn., Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059 have changed my name Sweety to Sweety Panwar for all intents and future purposes. Inform that Sweety & Sweety Panwar both are one & same Person

0040864518-1

I, Ankit Jig Singh, S/o LD Garg R/o Flat No. A903, 53, Haryana, Sector-3, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad, UP-201012 have changed my name to Ankit Garg for all future Purposes.

0040864546-1

I, Suman Jain/ Suman Rani W/O Arhant Jain R/o Floor No.1861-0 Third Floor, Block-D, Omach city, Sonipat, Sector-18, Haryana-131001, Have changed my name to Suman

0040864618-3

I, ARNAV PRATAP, S/o AJAY PRATAP SONKAR, R/o H.No. 9C, LIDDLE ROAD, GEPRGE TOWN, PRAYAGRAJ-211002. UTTAR PRADESH have changed my name to ARNAV PRATAP SONKAR .

0071046270-1

I, DEEPIKA D/O MUKESH MEHTA, R/O-A-24 GALI NO.1 HARDEV NAGAR HARODA MAZRA DELHI-110084, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO DEEPIKA MEHTA.

0040864595-9

I, SOHAN SINGH, S/O-RAMPAL SAINI, R/O RZ-72 GALI NO.3, RAJ NAGAR PART-II PALAM COLONY BAGDOLA, DELHI-110077, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SOHAN SINGH SAINI.

0040864601-2

I, Aayushi Yadav D/o Sandeep Yadav R/o-1240, Old Vijay Nagar, Sector-9, Ghaziabad UP have changed my name to Ayushi Yadav.

0071046228-1

I, Arvind Pandey S/O Vijay Kumar Pandey R/O Y-1/23 Budh vihar phase-1, Delhi-110086 Have changed my name to Arvind Kumar Pandey

0040864618-2

I, Sheela Devi Chauhan W/o Sh. Brij Mohan Singh, R/o H.No.-F-164, Gali No.11, Phase-6, Gya Nagar, New Delhi-110047 declare that Sheela Devi Chauhan and Sheela both names are mine and I will be known as Sheela Devi Chauhan for all respects.

0040864645-9

I, SHWETA D/O JAN RAO D/O 34/312 2nd FLOOR TRILOK PURI EAST DELHI-110091, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SHWETA RAO.

0040864595-2

I, Naitai Charan Manna Alias Nital Manna S/o Nandalal Manna R/o AD 245, Rabindra Pally, Krishnapur, Prafulla Kanan, PO: Prafulla Kanan, Dist- North 24 Parganas, West Bengal- 700101, have changed my name to Netai Manna

0071046203-1

I, HARGHUN SINGH S/O JITENDER SINGH R/O B-144 SECTOR-92, NOIDA, G.B.NAGAR U.P-201301 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO HARGHUN SINGH HANDA FOR ALL THE FUTURE PURPOSE.

0071046245-1

I, PRERIT BENGANI S/O Prakash Bengani 452/4, Street No.2, Bhola Nath Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 have changed my name from PUNIT BENGANI to PRERIT BENGANI for all future purposes

0071046275-1

I, ANURADHA KAKATI, W/O VASANT VOHRA, R/O A-37, GUJRANWALA TOWN PART-1, DELHI-110009, CHANGED MY NAME TO ANURADHA KAKATI VOHRA FOR ALL PURPOSES.

0040864596-3

I, DALIP KUMAR, S/O RAM LAL THAKUR, R/O-A-68, EAST OF KAILASH, DELHI-110065, HAVE TO CHANGED MY NAME FROM DALIP KUMAR TO DALIP THAKUR, FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

0040864503-1

I, Pooja Dahiya, formerly known as Pooja, wife of, Dhruv Dahiya, residing at, 10-C, PDA-Danta Flats, Kalu Sarai, Hauz-Khas, New Delhi-110016, have changed my name, from Pooja to Pooja Dahiya. Henceforth, I shall be known as Pooja Dahiya, for all purposes.

0040864601-8

I, DALIP KUMAR, S/O RAM LAL THAKUR, R/O-A-68, EAST OF KAILASH, DELHI-110065, HAVE TO CHANGED MY NAME FROM DALIP KUMAR TO DALIP THAKUR, FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

0040864503-1

I, Riddhi Vora W/o-Upamanyu Malik, R/o-15, Road No-41, Near T.T. Park, Punjabi Bagh West, New Delhi-26, have changed my name to Riddhi Malik.

0040864512-3

I, ADITYA SINGH, S/o Sh. Joginder Singh, R/o L-1 71/15, Sangam Vihar, Deoli, South Delhi-110062, hereby declare that my correct name is ADITYA SINGH, my father's correct name is JOGINDER SINGH, and my correct Date-of-Birth is 03/06/2008, as recorded in my Aadhaar Card and Birth Certificate. However, due to an inadvertent error in my School/Board records, my father's name has been mentioned as JOGENDER, my surname "SINGH" has not been mentioned, and my Date-of-Birth has been incorrectly recorded as 03/07/2008. Henceforth, I shall be known as ADITYA SINGH, S/o JOGINDER SINGH, with Date-of-Birth 03/06/2008, for all purposes.

0071046267-1

I, NITIN, S/O-POORAN SINGH, R/O-HOUSE NO.1 GALLI, NO.2 WAZIRPUR-ROAD KHERI-KALAN-113, FARIDABAD-121002, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO NITIN KUMAR, FOR ALL, FUTURE PURPOSE

0040864595-8

I, Rakesh Sadana, S/O Sh. Khem Chand Arora, R/O H.No.-L-38, Double-Storey, Pratap-Nagar, Subzi-Mandi, Delhi-110007, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Rajesh Kumar Arora.

0040864645-4

I, RHYTHM GROVER W/O SAHIL SACHDEVA R/O D-229, DEFENCE COLONY, DELHI-110024, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RHYTHM SACHDEVA.

0040864618-4

It is for general information that I, Samrat Chakraborty S/o Pradip Kumar Chakraborty R/o Near Saheb Bagam Math, Kazidanga, Debanandapur, Hooghly, West Bengal- 712123, declare that name of my father has been wrongly written as P K Chakraborty in my 10th and 12th Class School Certificate cum Marksheet and Birth Certificate No. - 314217. The actual name of my father is Pradip Kumar Chakraborty, which may be amended accordingly.

0071046210-1

I, Rakesh Sadana, S/O Sh. Khem Chand Arora, R/O H.No.-L-38, Double-Storey, Pratap-Nagar, Subzi-Mandi, Delhi-110007, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Rajesh Kumar Arora.

0040864512-4

I, RAMANJIT KAUR W/o Mandeep Singh Chawla, 10/2, Wing No-2, Prem Nagar, Dehradun, Uttarakhand-248007 have changed my name to RAMANJEET KAUR CHAWLA.

0071046251-1

I, Sava Chand S/o-Har Lal Singh, R/O-339-A, 3rd Floor, Hari Nagar, Ashram, Delhi-14 have changed my name to Suresh Singh Bhati for all purposes, My correct date of Birth is 12/03/1963 and Mobile No.9968314007.

0040864512-4

I, MOHD SHAHBUDDIN, S/O-MOHD ALLUDDIN, R/O A-7, KHASRA NO.766, GALI NO.2 RAJEEV-NAGAR BHALSAVA DAIRY DELHI-110042, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHAMMAD SHAHAABUDDIN.

0040864595-10

I, PATTATHIPARAMBIL JOY JOHN, S/O PATTATHIPARAMBIL THOMAS JOHN, R/O H-161, SECTOR 12, NOIDA-201301, DISTT. GAUTAM BUDH NAGAR (UP) HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO JOY JOHN.

0040864511-1

I, Farheen D/o Shri Mohd. Hussain and W/o Shri Ubaid Khan resident of 19-E, Pocket-1, Mayur Vihar Phase-1, Delhi-110091 have changed my name to Farheen Khan for all purposes.

0040864596-6

I, Rajender Prashad, S/O Mool Chand R/O 151, Deepak Vihar, Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043, Have Changed my Name to Rajinder Prasad for all future purposes.

0040864645-2

I, Chanchal Arora D/o Jagdish Lal nagpal R/o B-33, F/F Plot No. B-28, Gali No.5, Mohan Park, naveen shahdara, delhi-32 have change my name to kirti kwatra for all future purpose

0040864596-1

I, Sukhbir Kaur W/o Surinder Singh, R/o WZ-283/269A, Street No-9, Vishnu Garden, Tilak Nagar Delhi-110018, have changed my name to Sukkbeer Kaur.

0040864601-6

I, BOBI W/o-Ganesh Rai, R/o-E-12, Indra Kalyan Vihar, Okhla Phase-1, Okhla Industrial Estate, New Delhi-20, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as BABITA DEVI.

0040864512-1

I, VIKAS RASVANT, S/O-AMRIT SAGAR RASWANT, R/O BH-08 AMARPALI VILLAGE NYAY-KHAND-2 INDIRAPURAM, GHAZIABAD, U.P.201014 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO VIKAS RASWANT

0040864595-6

I, SOWRI DAVID S/o DAVID CHINNAPAN R/o H NO-16, BLOCK-34, TRILOKPURI, DELHI-110091. Have changed my name to D SOWRI RAJ.

0040864618-6

I, Rajiv Pal Arora S/o Puroshotam Pal R/o-C21, C-Block, Brijvihar, Chander Nagar, Ghaziabad have changed my name to Rajiv Pal.

0071046217-1

I, Rajiv Bhati, S/o-Satanpal Bhati, R/o-A-702, Brestech Park View Spa, Sector-47, Gurugram, Haryana-122018, have changed, my minor, daughter's name, from Raavi, to Raavi Bhati, for all future purposes.

0040864645-6

I, Raj Kumar Sachdeva R/o-C8/290A, 2nd Floor, Keshavpuram, Delhi have changed my son name from Vamaan to Vaaman Sachdeva for all purposes.

0071046256-1

I, Ram Shanker S/O Ram Ratan R/O H.No. B-32, Street No.7, West Karawal Nagar, Delhi-110094, have changed, my name to Prem Shankar Parashar.

0040864596-3

I, DALIP KUMAR, S/O RAM LAL THAKUR, R/O-A-68, EAST OF KAILASH, DELHI-110065, HAVE TO CHANGED MY NAME FROM DALIP KUMAR TO DALIP THAKUR, FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES.

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0040864511-1

I, Farheen D/o Shri Mohd. Hussain and W/o Shri Ubaid Khan resident of 19-E, Pocket-1, Mayur Vihar Phase-1, Delhi-110091 have changed my name to Farheen Khan for all purposes.

0040864596-6

I have Changed my Name From Amaan To Mohd Amaan For all future purpose. Mohd Amaan S/o Rahat Hussain R/o-742 Kaila Road Lalitain Factory Compound Ghaziabad

0071046272-1

I MANVIR SINGH MUDHAR S/O. GOVINDER SINGH R/O WZ-183, SHIV NAGAR, GALI NO 11, JAIL ROAD, NEW DELHI-110058 had changed my name to MANVIR SINGH for all future purpose.

0040864502-1

I, ASHMEET SINGH, S/O Harcharan Singh Sethi R/O C-10, FIRST-FLOOR LAJPAT NAGAR-1, S.O, SOUTH DELHI-110024, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO ASHMEET SINGH SETHI

0040864601-3

I, K, Neelam Kumari W/o Sandeep Yadav R/O-1240, Old Vijay Nagar, Ghaziabad UP have changed my name to Neelam Yadav.

0071046238-1

I, SANJEEV SINGH, S/O NARAIN SINGH, R/O H.NO 501 SECOND FLOOR SECTOR-15 VASUNDHARA GHAZIABAD, U.P.201012, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SANJEEV KUMAR SINGH.

0040864595-3

I, Bharati Baidya Alias Bharati Mondal Baidya D/o Gurucharan Baidya and W/o Gurupada Mondal R/o Sundhine, Paschimpara, Buddha Mandir, Nebadhai, Nebadhai Duttapukur, PO: Duttapukur, District: North 24 Parganas, West Bengal- 743248, have changed my name to Bharati Mondal

0071046204-1

I, Rajni W/o Brij Bhushan R/o B2/24 Bharat Vihar, Sector-14, Dwarka, New Delhi-110078, have changed my name to Rajni Verma.

0040864645-3

I, Gursimran Kaur Bhatia W/o Gursimran Singh, 1639B, Sector-46, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001, have changed my name to Gurpreen Kaur.

0071046248-1

I, Ronak Pandey S/O Arvind Kumar Pandey R/O-Y-1/23 Budh vihar phase-1, DELHI-110086 Have changed my name to Ronak Kumar Pandey

0040864618-1

I, JISH JOHN, W/O-SNABLE KANNAMPUZHA SHAJI, R/O-L-168, GALLI, NO.-5A L-BLOCK, MAHIPALPUR-EXTENSION, Malik Pur Kohi Alias Rang Puri, South-West Delhi-110037, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO JISH JOHN SNABLE.

0040864595-12

I, ASIF ANSARI S/O MASIULAH H.NO-103, STREET, NO-4, Near-Panduk ShilaMANDIR GAUTAMPURI NEW-Seelampur. P.O-BHAJAN PURA, NORTH EAST DELHI-110053, have changed my name to MOHD ASIF ANSARI.

0040864601-5

**GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA**

S. N.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HARYANA MEDICAL SERVICES CORPORATION LIMITED PANCHKULA	NOTICE INVITING TENDER FOR THE SUPPLY, INSTALLATION AND COMMISSIONING OF MOVEMENT THERAPY MACHINE ON 2 YEARS RATE CONTRACT AS MENTIONED AGAINST ITEM IN SCHEDULE OF REQUIREMENT	07.07.2026 20.07.2026	1,50,00,000/-	www.hemad.org.in	962299829 eprocment@haryana@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in No. 46936/HRY

**BIHAR STATE HOUSING BOARD**
6, Sardar Patel Marg, Patna-15

Short Notice Inviting Proposal (RFP)
Through E-Procurement Mode-www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
No.-BSHB/2026-27- 02

S.No	Information to Bidders
1	Name of the Client: Bihar State Housing Board (BSHB), A Govt. of Bihar Undertaking Name of the Assignment: "Selection of Consultancy Firm for outsourcing of accounting and financial management services in Bihar State Housing Board. Details on the services to be provided: As Mentioned in Terms of Reference (TOR) under chapter 2 of the RFP
2	Financial Proposal to be submitted together with Technical Proposal: Yes
3	There shall be a pre-proposal meeting as under:- Date and Time: 16 th July, 2026 at 3:00 P.M Venue: Bihar State Housing Board The Address for clarification is : Secretary, Bihar State Housing Board (BSHB) 6, Sardar Patel Marg, Patna – 800 015 Phone: 0612-2217992, Fax: 0612-2217605 Email: mddbshb@gmail.com, Website: bshb.bihar.gov.in
4	Last date for proposal submission is 23 rd July, 2026 at 3:00 P.M
5	Tender opening date is 24 th July, 2026 at 3:00 P.M
6	Proposals must remain valid for 90 days from the submission date.
7	The Non-refundable Bid Cost and refundable bid Security Rs 5,000 (Rupees Five thousand only) and Rs. 1,00,000/- (Rupees One Lakh only) to be submitted as mentioned in the data sheet.
8	The Bid processing fee to be paid through Internet Banking, Debit Card, Credit Card or Payment Gateway Via the portal https://www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
9	All the information/corrigendum/addendum related to the tender shall be published on Eproc2 portal. The authority shall have the right to reject the bid partially or fully without assigning any reason what so ever.

PR. No. 007177 (B&C) 2026-27
This information is available on website www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar also
सुरक्षित जीवन अपनाओ, अपनी नियमित एच.आई.वी. जाँच कराओ।

SECRETARY
BSHB, Patna

**BIHAR POLICE BUILDING
CONSTRUCTION CORPORATION**
(A Government of Bihar Undertaking)
Corporate Identity No. (CIN) U452008BR19745GCG001126
Regd. Office: Kautliya Nagar, BSAP-5 Campus,
PS-Hawai Adda Thana, Patna-800014
Office: 0612 – 2223727, Email: policenigam@bihar.gov.in,
Website: <https://bpbcc.bihar.gov.in>, <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>
Short-Notice of Inviting E-Quotation – 05/2026-27

1. Designation and Address of Advertiser : Chief Engineer, B.P.B.C.C., Patna. 2. Date of Inviting Quotation: 04-07-2026 3. Period for download of B.O.Q.: 14-07-2026 to 28-07-2026, up to 17:00 Hours 4. Last date and time of submission (upload) of Quotation : 29-07-2026, 17:00 Hours 5. Place of sale of tender document : Only on website <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>, 6. Date, Time & Place of Pre-Bid meeting" : 15-07-2026 15:00 Hours at C.E. Office, BPBCC H.Q., Patna. 7. (a) Last date, time and place for submission of original instrument of EMD and cost of BOQ : 30-07-2026 15:30 Hours. As per clause 15. (b) Date & Time of opening of Quotation (Technical Bid): 31-07-2026, 16:00 Hours, (c) Date and time of opening of financial bid : After decision of Technical bid, 8. Period of BID Validity : 120 days, 9. Post of tender sanction officer : Competent Authority, 10. Details of Work:
Supplying fixing & installation of furniture & other items all complete job at different Police Station under Patna division

Sr. No.	Name of work	Name of Division	Rate Quotation (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs)	Cost of BOQ (in Rs)	Bid processing Fee	Time of completion of work
1	2	3	4	5	5	6	7
1.	Bapas Traffic PS, Traffic PS Gandhi Maidan, Railway PS Patna Junction, Musalipalle Model PS, Srishehnagar Model PS, Beur PS, Ghoshwari Model PS, Atmialagola Model PS & Pargura Model PS – Total – 09 Police Stations	Patna	As Quoted by Bidder (Inclusive of all taxes and F.O.R at site).	Minimum 2% of quoted amount.	30000	As per eproc2	03 Months

इस निविदा की अन्य विस्तृत जानकारी एवं आवश्यक शर्तें अधोहस्ताक्षरी के कार्यालय के सूचना पट एवं वेबसाइट www.bpbcc.co.in पर देखा जा सकता है तथा ई-निविदा-पत्र www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in से प्राप्त किया जा सकता है।
PR- 007174 (B & C) 2026-27
मुख्य अभियंता, पटना
उक्त सूचना state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

**Govt. of Bihar**
Municipal Commissioner ,Begusarai
Section - I: Short Notice Inviting Tender (NIT)
RFP for Selection of an Agency for the Implementation of Animal Birth Control (ABC) Program in Begusarai District of Bihar

Name of the District ULB HQ Begusarai
Address: Begusarai nagar nigam
Phone No: 06243450151 Email: bmcbe@gmail.com

RFP No:- 17

1.Municipal Commissioner of nagar Nigam Begusarai invites proposals from eligible firms for "Selection of an Agency for the Implementation of Animal Birth Control (ABC) Program in Begusarai District of Bihar",
2. Interested Consultancy Firms may download the complete Request for Proposals (RFP) Document, from website: <https://state.bihar.gov.in/urban>

-	PARTICULARS
1	Website for submission of bid/proposal Not applicable Separate bids to be submitted to the respective ULBs HQ at each district. (A bidder may choose to bid for multiple districts. For each district separate bids, Tender fee, Bid Security has to be submitted)
2	Mode of Submission Proposals/bids to be submitted in hard copies only to the respective district ULBs HQ (as per Annexure 3). A bidder is allowed to submit bids in more than one district subject to submission of separate tender processing fee and EMD / Bid Security for each district applied. Submission of Tender fee, Bid Security, payment proof, original copy of affidavit, declaration regarding Blacklisting and Power of Attorney as per RFP document along with the bid hard copies
3	Last date and time for Submission of hard copies of Technical Bid/proposal along with financial bid/proposal in separate sealed envelopes inside one envelop. 21/07/2026 up to 05:00 PM
4	Date and time of Pre bid meeting 17/07/2026 by 12:00 PM Meeting Hall , Nagar Nigam , Begusarai, Link: Please refer to Bid Data Sheet
5	Submission of bids through eproc portal Not applicable
6	Date and time of opening of Technical Bids 22/07/2026 at 03:30 PM at respective district ULB HQ
7	Date and time of opening of Financial Bids Will be intimated later to successful bidders by the respective district ULB HQ.
8	Method of Selection Least cost (rate per unit) selection method

1.Agencies/ Firms may download the complete Request for Proposal (RFP) Document, from website: <https://state.bihar.gov.in/urban>
For further details please visit website state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
PR- 007329 (B & C) 2026-27
नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।
Municipal Commissioner
Begusarai

**NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE**

Sh. Neeraj Sharmar S/o Subhash Chand/ Sr.Goods Train Manager/SSB (Residential add. Gopalgarh, Dist./ Tehsheel, Rowari, Haryana-123401) working as Sr.Goods Train Manager under SSI/SSB has been absent from duty without any intimation or sanctioned leave since 07.06.2024.
Communication has been sent to Sh.Neeraj Sharma S/o Subhash Chand/ Sr.Goods Train Manager/SSB on the address available in records via speed post on date 20.12.2024 but no response was received in this office till date.
Sh. Neeraj Sharma S/o Subhash Chand/ Sr.Goods Train Manager/SSB is therefore directed to report within 10 days of publication of this notice, failing which action will be taken against him as per extant rules.

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 2328/2026

**पर्यावरण, वन एवं जलवायु परिवर्तन विभाग
पटना जू प्रबंधन एवं विकास सोसाइटी**
(Phone – 0612 2217758, Email- patnaazobihar@gmail.com)
अल्पकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना सं०
07/e-PROC/PZMDS/2026-27

क्र० सं०	निविदा का विवरण।	परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य	अग्रघन की राशि
1	पटना जू प्रबंधन एवं विकास सोसाइटी के वित्तीय वर्ष 2025-26 के अंकेक्षण हेतु निबंधित ऑडिटर का चयन	रु० 1,000/- (रुपये एक हजार)।	रु० 10,000/- (दस रुपये)

पटना जू प्रबंधन एवं विकास सोसाइटी के वित्तीय वर्ष 2025-26 के अंकेक्षण हेतु ऑडिटर के चयन हेतु इच्छुक एवं अनुमति निबंधित चार्टर्ड अकाउन्टेन्ट फर्मों/अंकेक्षण संस्थाओं से ई-निविदायें निधारित समयवधि में ई-प्रॉक पोर्टल के माध्यम से विहित प्रपत्र में आमंत्रित की जाती हैं।
ई-निविदा e-Procurement Portal (<https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>) के माध्यम से समर्पित की जानी है। ई-निविदा <https://state.bihar.gov.in/forest> पर देखी जा सकती है। अधिक जानकारी के लिए दूरभाष संख्या 0612-2217758 पर सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।
सचिव,
PR- 007311 (Envir. & Forest) 2026-27
पटना जू प्रबंधन एवं विकास सोसाइटी
उक्त सूचना state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar से प्राप्त की जा सकती है।
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार।

**BHAGALPUR SMART CITY LIMITED**
(A Govt. of Bihar Undertaking)
Notice Inviting E-Tender
Second Call

Work Descriptions: E-Auction Tender Notice for Selection of agency for Operation & maintenance of River Front Development under Project Beautification of Barari Ghat and Development of Public Recreational Space at Jogsar Implemented under Smart City Mission.
Estimated Cost (Minimum Reserve Price): Rs. 30,00,000/- (Thirty Lakh only) inclusive of all taxes and GST.
Tender Processing Fee: As per e-proc norms <https://www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in>
Tender Documents Fee: Rs. 10,000/- (Ten thousand only).
Earnest Money Deposit: Rs. 60,000/- (Sixty thousand only).
Tender Schedule:

Sr. No.	Activity	Date and Time
1	Bid Submission Due Date https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in/	27-07-2026, 11:00 PM
2	Bid Open Date https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in/	28-07-2026, 02:30 PM
3	Submission end date of hard copy/ Physical documents mentioned in RFP. Address: Managing Director -Cum-CEO, Bhagalpur Smart City Limited, 4th Floor, Bhagalpur Smart City Building, Police Line Campus, Opp. Main Gate of Sandy's Compound, Bhagalpur - 812001	28-07-2026, 01:00 PM
4	Prebid Meeting Start Date. Venue Details: Conference Hall, Bhagalpur Smart City Limited.	14-07-2026 12:30 PM
5	Prebid Meeting End Date.	14-07-2026 02:00 PM
6	Prebid Query Submission end date and time. Email: info@smartcitybhagalpur.org	14-07-2026 10:00 AM

Note: NIT, RFP, Corrigendum (if any) etc. are also available on the official website <http://www.smartcitybhagalpur.org> for reference purposes only.
Chief Executive Officer
Bhagalpur Smart City Limited
PR- 007176 (B & C) 2026-27
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार

**बिहार सरकार**
कार्यालय, मुजफ्फरपुर नगर निगम, मुजफ्फरपुर।
निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना प्रारूप (Eproc-2.0 के माध्यम से)
मानक निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना प्रारूप ₹ 70.00 लाख से ₹ 2 करोड़ तक की राशि के कार्यों के लिए (डबल बीड पद्धति)
Website : <https://mymmc.org>, E-mail Id-muzaffarpur.ulb@gmail.com, mmc-muz-bih@nic.in, Control Room- 155304, 1800 345 1061, 7870031117
निविदा आमंत्रण की सूचना (ई-टेडरिंग द्वारा www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in.)
संख्या- NIT No.-04/MMC/2026-27

1. विज्ञापनदाता का पदनाम एवं पता
नगर आयुक्त, नगर निगम, मुजफ्फरपुर।
दिनांक-07.07.2026
2. निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना निर्गत की तिथि –
दिनांक-15.07.2026 से दिनांक 22.07.2026 के 15:00 बजे तक (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
3. परिमाण विपत्र प्राप्त करने की तिथि एवं समय
दिनांक-18.07.2026 को समय 13:30 बजे पूर्वान्ह/अपराह्न स्थान-नगर आयुक्त का कार्यालय, नगर निगम सभागार, मुजफ्फरपुर।
4. प्री बीड मीटिंग की तिथि एवं समय
दिनांक-22.07.2026 समय 15:00 बजे तक (www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
5. संवेदक द्वारा निविदा अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि –
दिनांक-27.07.2026 समय 11:00 बजे तक
तकनीकी बीड खोलने की तिथि –
तकनीकी बीड में सफल होने के उपरान्त निर्देशानुसार
6. तकनीकी बीड खोलने की तिथि
7. वित्तीय बीड खोलने की तिथि–
8. कार्य की विवरणी–

क्रम संख्या	कार्य का नाम	प्रारंभिक राशि (रु. में)	अग्रघन की राशि (online के माध्यम से) Website:- www.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in	परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य (online के माध्यम से) Website:- www.Eproc2.bihar.gov.in	Bid Processing fee (Through Online Payment हेतु प्रोसेसिंग शुल्क)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1.	वाई नो-11, 26 एवं 27 अन्तर्गत कटौतीगुल सक्की मंजी से छाता चौक मुख्य गल्ला निर्माण कार्य। (Re-Tender)	12388700.00	247800.00	10000.00	As per e-Proc2	8 Months
2.	वाई नो-26 अन्तर्गत छाता चौक काजी मोरामपुर थाना से सरकारी पॉलिटेक्निक कॉलेज होते हुए दाक नर्सिंग होम तक सड़क एवं गल्ला निर्माण कार्य। (Re-Tender)	9358700.00	187200.00	10000.00	As per e-Proc2	6 Months

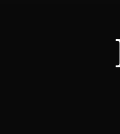
नोट:- Bidders Should submit Bid Processing fee thorough Online Payment as per Amount generated on Website www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
विस्तृत जानकारी state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर की देखी जा सकती है।
PR- 007325 (B & C) 2026-27
नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।
(रूपुराज प्रताप सिंह)
नगर आयुक्त,
मुजफ्फरपुर नगर निगम, मुजफ्फरपुर।

**NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE**

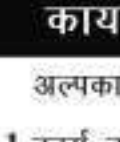
Dy.CEE(W), NWR, Ajmer on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tender for the following work up to 15.00Hrs. on the mention date: 1. **Tender No. : EL/50/08/2026-27** 2. **Name of work :** Repair, Servicing and overhauling of Greaves Cotton make Diesel Alternator Set 500kVA, 750V in Power Cars during POH at carriage workshop Ajmer. 3. **Approximate cost :** Rs. 56488049.14/- 4. **Earnest money :** Rs. 1129800/- 5. **Date & Time of closing of E-Tender Date & Time of opening of E-Tender :** 24.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs., 24.07.2026 at 15.30 Hrs. 6. **The details of above E-Tender is available on website :** www.ireps.gov.in 964-DI/26
Follow us on:              

**JAPIT**
Jharkhand Agency for Promotion of Information Technology
(An Autonomous body under Department of IT & e-Governance, Govt. of Jharkhand)
Ground Floor, Engineer's Hostel – I, Near Golchhakker, Dhurva, Ranchi, Jharkhand.
Phone - 0651-2401040, 2401067 Fax - 0651-2401040 Email - japn_doh@rediffmail.com

TENDER CANCELLATION NOTICE
(Ref. No. – GEM/2026/B/7417853)
The tender for "Selection of Service Provider for Supply, Installation, Commissioning and Maintenance of CCTV Based Surveillance System at Police Stations Buildings in Jharkhand" (Ref. No. – GEM/2026/B/7417853) is cancelled due to administrative reasons.
(PR- 376773)
Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer
JAP-IT
PR 384234 (Information Technology) 26-27 (D)

**GOVERNMENT OF JHARKHAND
Department of Labour, Employment, Training & Skill Development
Directorate of Employment & Training, Jharkhand, Ranchi.**
Letter No. 773
Dated 07/07/2026

**EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
Invitation to Participate as Anchor Industry Partner (AIP) under PM-SETU -
National Scheme for Upgradation of Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs)**
The Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), Government of India, has launched the **Pradhan Mantri Skilling and Employability Transformation through Upgraded ITIs (PM-SETU)** scheme with the objective of transforming the Industrial Training Institute (ITI) ecosystem into modern, industry-aligned and outcome-driven training institutions. Under the scheme, the Department of Labour, Employment, Training and Skill Development, Jharkhand, envisages to upgrade Hub ITIs with modern training infrastructure, advanced laboratories, digital learning facilities, and industry-aligned courses in emerging sectors. The Hub institutions will mentor, and support nearby Spoke ITIs to strengthen training delivery, industry linkages, and placement outcomes.
A key feature of the scheme is **industry-led governance through the formation of a Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV)** for each ITI cluster. The SPV will be established with participation of a credible **Anchor Industry Partner (AIP)** and the State Government for the management and strategic oversight of the Hub and Spoke ITI cluster. The industry partner will support planning and implementation of industry-aligned training programs, modernization of infrastructure, and strengthening of apprenticeship and placement linkages.
All interested participants may go through the **project concept note on the website** <https://www.jharkhand.gov.in/labour> Interested participants are requested to indicate their willingness to participate in the initiative. They may also share their comments, suggestions, or feedback on the proposed project through **email at director@et.jh@gmail.com or et.jh@gmail.com on or before 14.07.2026.**
Additionally, a Request for Proposal (RFP) will be floated soon by the Directorate of **Employment & Training, Jharkhand** to identify potential Anchor Industry Partners for the upgradation of ITI clusters in the State.
In this regard, a meeting with all interested participants will be held on **15.07.2026 at Room No. 308, Conference Hall, Directorate of Employment & Training, Nepal House**, for any clarification or deliberation.
Yours Sincerely,
Sd/- Director
PR 384279 Labour Employment and Training(26-27)D
Employment and Training, Jharkhand, Ranchi.

**कार्यालय कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, लघु सिंचाई प्रमण्डल,चाईबासा**

अल्पकालीन ई०-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-WRD/MID/CHAIBASA/ F2-09/2026-27(DMFT)
1.कार्य का नाम :-
(2nd Call)

क्र० संख्या	योजना का नाम	जिला	प्रखण्ड	प्रारंभिक राशि (लाख में)	परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य (रुपये में)	अग्रघन की राशि (रुपये में)	कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1.	नवागाम पंचायत के ग्राम मुंडा में बरजोम इकिर तक दृढ़ सिंचाई निर्माण।	पश्चिमी सिंहभूम।	झौकपाणी	249.368	10,000.00	499000.00	9 माह

नोट :- केवल ई०-निविदा(Online Mode) ही स्वीकार होगा।
2. विस्तृत जानकारी के लिए वेबसाइट WWW.jharkhandtenders.gov.in पर देखें।
3. वेबसाइट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि एवं समय :- 22.07.2026 के 11:00 बजे पूर्वान्हन से।
4. ई०-निविदा में भाग लेने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय :- 28.07.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक।
5. ई०-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय :- 29.07.2026 को 05:00 बजे अपराह्न।
6. परिमाण विपत्र का मूल्य एवं अग्रघन की राशि सूचना प्रोद्योगिकी एवं ई-गवर्नेंस विभाग झारखण्ड मंत्रालय, धुर्वा, राँची के आदेश सह ज्ञापक 120, दिनांक 03.10.2023 के अनुरूप (Online) प्राप्त की जायेगी।
7. निविदा आमंत्रित करनेवाले पदाधिकारी का नाम, पता, दूरभाष सं० एवं ई०मेल आई डी०- कार्यपालक अभियंता, लघु सिंचाई प्रमण्डल, चाईबासा/9572468424 ई०मेल & eemidchaibasa@gmail.com, eemidchai-cemr-jhr@nic.in
8. निविदा के B.O.Q की राशि घट-बढ़ सकती है तदनुसार B.O.Q के मूल्य एवं अग्रघन की राशि में बदलाव होगा।
9. प्रारंभिक राशि का 10 प्रतिशत से अधिक के दर से निविदित 1/4Quoted rate is more than 10% below the schedule rate 1/2 के परिपेक्ष में पथ निर्माण विभाग झारखण्ड राँची के पत्रांक 2146(S) दिनांक 09.09.2020 के शर्तावली के अनुसार निबंधित जमानत की राशि एकरारनामा करने के समय जमा करना अनिवार्य होगा।
10.निविदा निष्पादन Double Bid Envelope पद्धति से किया जाएगा Technical Bid में सफल निविदादाता का ही Financial Bid खोला जाएगा। उपायुक्त, पश्चिमी सिंहभूम का पत्रांक 1679, दिनांक 23.12.2022 के आलोक में निविदा डालने के समय चाईबासा जिलाअन्तर्गत किसी भी ize.My@foHkxx द्वारा आवंटित कार्य एकराति अवधि बीत जाने के बाद लंबित नही होने संबंधी शपथ-पत्र Affidavit देना होगा। निविदा के एक NIT में एक निबंधन पर दो से अधिक कार्य आवंटित नहीं किया जाएगा। वैसे संवेदक जो एकरारनामा में अंकित कार्य पूर्ण करने की तिथि तक योजनाओं का कार्य अधूरा रखे हुए हैं। उन्हें जिला अन्तर्गत चलने वाली किसी भी योजना में तब तक कार्य आवंटित नहीं किया जाएगा जब तक अपने पूर्व के कार्य को समाप्त न कर दें। जिला अन्तर्गत किसी भी विभाग का कार्य लंबित होने की सूचना यदि इस कार्यालय को प्राप्त होती है तो संबंधित संवेदक को कार्य आवंटित नहीं किया जाएगा।
11.निविदा खोलने के की तिथि से 5 दिनों के अन्दर निविदादाता द्वारा अपनी आपत्ति/दावा दर्ज कराये अन्यथा अवधि बीतने के पश्चात कोई भी आपत्ति/दावा मान्य नहीं होगा।
12.बिना कारण बताये किसी भी समय निविदा को रद्द करने का अधिकारी अधोहस्ताक्षरी को सुरक्षित रहेगा।
13-Technical Bid में Qualify करने वाले संवेदकों/ फर्म का ही Financial Bid खोला जाएगा।
14.निविदा शुल्क एवं अग्रघन की राशि का ई०-मुद्रातन संवेदक द्वारा जिस बैंक खाता से किया जाएगा। उसी खाते में अग्रघन की राशि वापस होगी। अगर बैंक खाता को बन्द कर दिया जाता है तो उसकी सारी जवाबदेही संवेदक की होगी।
हो / -कार्यपालक अभियंता
लघु सिंचाई प्रमण्डल, चाईबासा
PR 384277 (West Singhbhum)26-27*D

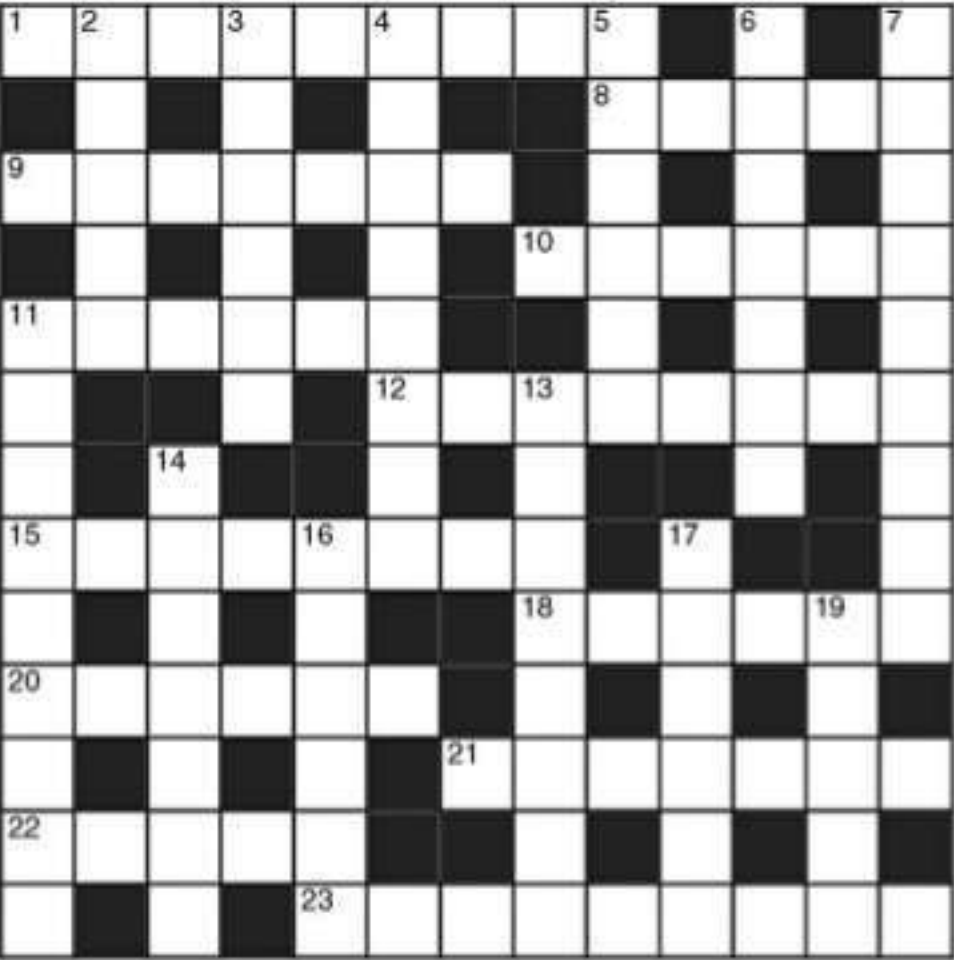
**NORTHERN RAILWAY
(E-Auction Notice)**

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi Invites e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for allotment of contracts of Water Vending Machines (WVMs) and Multi Purpose Stalls (MPS) at following railway stations/locations:

Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Cluster No.	No. of WVMs at Railway Stations
CTG-WVM-04-2026	23.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs.	I	Total 06 WVMs (01 WVM at Garhi Harsaru, 01 WVM at Patli, 01 WVM at Pataudi Road, 01 WVM at Palam, 02 WVMs at Delhi Sarai Rohilla Railway Station).
		J	Total 10 WVMs (04 WVMs at Meerut City, 02 WVMs at Modinagar, 01 WVM at Vivek Vihar, 03 WVMs at Delhi Shahdara Railway Station).
		H	Total 09 WVMs (02 WVMs at Jind, 02 WVMs at Narwana, 02 WVMs at Tohana, 02 WVMs at Jakhai, 01 WVM at Mansa Railway Station).
		A	Total 10 WVMs (01 WVM at Baraut, 01 WVM at Bagpat Road, 01 WVM at Noli, 02 WVMs at Shamli, 01 WVM at Rampur Maniharan and 04 WVMs at Muzaffarnagar Railway Station).
MPS-JULY-01-26	23.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs.	B	Total 11 WVMs (03 WVMs at Deoband, 03 WVMs at Sahibabad & 05 WVMs at Ghaziabad Railway Station).
		K	Total 09 WVMs (01 WVM at Okhla, 01 WVM at Tuglakabad, 01 WVM at Faridabad, 01 WVM at Faridabad New Town, 02 WVMs at Ballabh Garh and 03 WVMs at Palwal Railway Station).
		DEE	MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-163-25-2, MPS-DLI-DEE -MPS-133-25-2 MPS-DLI-DEE-MPS-134-25-2
		MUT	MPS-DLI-MUT-MPS-137-25-2
MPS-JULY-01-26	23.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs.	NZM	MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-122-25-1, MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-157-25-2 MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-126-25-2, MPS-DLI-NZM-MPS-159-25-2
		KUN	MPS-DLI-KUN-MPS-135-25-2
		MDNR	MPS-DLI-MDNR-MPS-147-25-2
		MTC	MPS-DLI-MTC-MPS-141-25-1
E-Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Station	Type of Asset
Advt-June-08-26	Start: 21.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs. Start: 21.07.2026 at 11:00 hrs.	Delhi Sarai Rohilla, Shakur Basti, Palam	Unipoles Zone-3
		Tuglakabad	Waiting Room
		Hazrat Nizamuddin	LED 360 Degree Screens.

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen : <https://ireps.gov.in/> (E-Auction-Leasing)
All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfill following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:
> Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module - Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module.
> Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details. > A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism. > The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions. > Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Bare cabin designed for the sea (9)
- 8 Irene may appear when he's around (5)
- 9 The strains show (7)
- 10 Smile when you say that! (6)
- 11 He gives everyone present a hand (6)
- 12 Value a quiet expression of approval (8)
- 15 To be sole model can be viewed as old hat (8)
- 18 Article shows Santa's named successor heading east (6)
- 20 Provides a home for a small charge (6)
- 21 Animal that may follow the ragtag in a rabble (7)
- 22 Result in directions being put to wrong use (5)
- 23 Anger is no use for thinking sense (9)
- DOWN
- 2 Divert a group of emus (5)
- 3 A drop of ice (6)
- 4 A row involving a battle over water (4,4)
- 5 In June the rates will be lower (6)
- 6 One kept in during school break (7)
- 7 An allusion to one's character and ability perhaps (9)
- 11 An extraordinary deed or act may get you this (9)
- 13 Exquisite soup mixed with rice (8)
- 14 See opus taking shape and give support (7)
- 16 Mail for the landlord (6)
- 17 Light beam (6)
- 19 Issue newly minted coins (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6034 ACROSS: 1 Sackbut, 4 Found, 7 Omen, 8 Madeline, 10 Pardonable, 12 Squibs, 13 Onward, 15 Battleship, 18 Outsider, 19 Hemp, 20 Sling, 21 Satiety DOWN: 1 Sloop, 2 Clear-cut, 3 Tiaras, 4 Freelances, 5 Unit, 6 Diehard, 9 Forbearing, 11 Cashmere, 12 Suitsors, 14 Athens, 16 Poppy, 17 Etui

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

___ opportunities are often the beginning of ___ enterprises

- Demosthenes (5,...,5)

GVA AE

CURST

AEMTLL

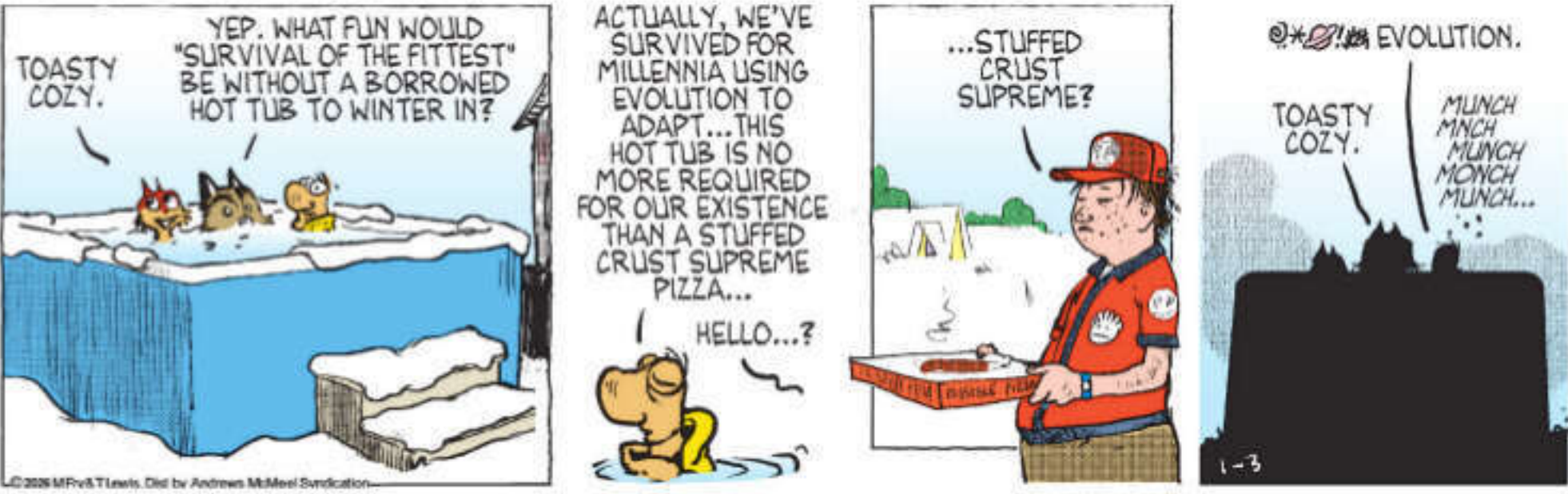
GNETUM

Demosthenes

ANSWER: Small opportunities are often the beginning of great enterprises

SOLUTIONS: Agave, Crust, Mallet, Nutmeg

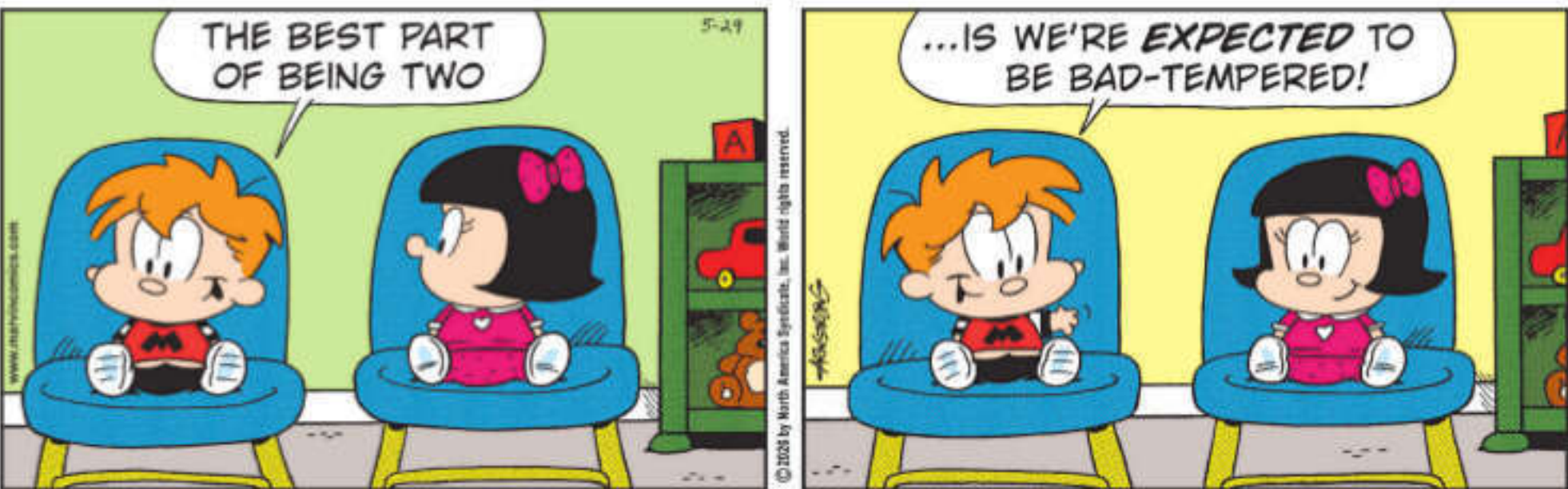
OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6373

3		1			9			
	8		4		6			
6	9	3		8	2	4		
	4	2		5	7			
	2	9		6	1			
9	5	8		4	3	7		
	3		6		5			
8			9			6		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6372

3	1	4	7	9	5	2	8	6
5	7	9	2	6	8	3	1	4
2	6	8	3	1	4	9	7	5
7	8	6	4	3	1	5	9	2
4	9	2	5	8	6	1	3	7
1	3	5	9	7	2	6	4	8
6	2	7	1	4	3	8	5	9
9	5	3	8	2	7	4	6	1
8	4	1	6	5	9	7	2	3

ROYAL STARS

- ♈

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20):

Keep your fridge stocked, because relatives and people from your past might be camped on your doorstep. This is a good time to tackle your home repairs. Tonight: Check your belongings.
- ♉

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21):

Allow extra time when you're travelling this week because Mercury retrograde will create breakdowns with cars, lead to missed buses and delays to your transportation plans. Tonight: You win.
- ♊

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21):

Delays to financial matters are likely, along with mistakes with your credit cards, or your bank accounts. Double-check all your financial dealings. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.
- ♋

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23):

Mercury is retrograde in your sign until July 23, that means you can finish old business; however, you have the disadvantage of suffering from goofy mistakes, delays, mixed-up communications and misplaced items. Oh well. Tonight: Friendships.
- ♌

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23):

Mercury retrograde might bring opportunities to explore spiritual issues from the past and reveal secrets about yourself. It might make you feel that you're not in control of your world. Tonight: You're admired.
- ♍

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23):

Old friends and acquaintances from the past are back in your world now. Some contacts that you will hear from might be through clubs, groups or organizations. The reconnection might be online, in person or in your dreams. Tonight: Explore and learn.
- ♎

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23):

Very likely that you run into authority figures from your past — in person, online or in your dreams. You might even have an imaginary conversation with someone. Tonight: Check your finances.
- ♏

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23):

Travel delays will be likely for some of you. Double-check itineraries and small details. This is a great time to study history and issues from the past. Tonight: Listen and cooperate.
- ♐

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22):

Double-check all transactions and financial negotiations with others, because Mercury retrograde will encourage errors. On the upside, it will help you finish matters related to inheritances and shared property. Tonight: Get better organized.
- ♑

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20):

Mercury retrograde will attract news about ex-partners and old friends. In fact, in some cases, you will encounter these people in person or online. You might hear about what they're up to, or they might come to you in your dreams. Tonight: Play.
- ♒

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19):

This particular Mercury retrograde will be challenging for you because it will affect your job, your work and even your health. Expect silly errors, misplaced paperwork, delays and equipment breakdowns. However, the good news is it can help you finish old projects. Tonight: Relax at home.
- ♓

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20):

Old flames are back in your world, either in your thoughts, your dreams, online or in person. Be smart and look your best when you go out. You'll feel better if you run into someone important from your past. Tonight: Interesting conversations.

UJVN LIMITED
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprise)
H. O. "UJJARWAL" MAHARANI BAGH, QMS ROAD, DEHRADUN - 248001, CIN No. U48110UP2019120003235486
Tels: 0135-2763501, 2763808, Fax: 0135-2763507, website: www.ujvn.com

Tender No.555

Date : 07.07.2026

Tender Time Extension Notice-1

Due to unavoidable circumstances the date of submission and opening of following tender invited by the office of the Executive Engineer (Maintenance), MB-II, Chinyalisaur (Uttarkashi) is hereby extended as follows:-

Tender No: 23/EE (M)/MB-II/2026-27

Name of work / Supply/Services: Overhauling and rewinding of ceiling fans in Shaktipuram Colony, Chinyalisaur

Last date for submission of bids: 15.07.2026 up to 16:00 Hrs.

Date of opening of bids: 17.07.2026 at 11:00 Hrs

For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website" www.ujvn.com"

Executive Engineer (Maintenance)

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

MAHARASHTRA STATE SEEDS CORPORATION LIMITED,
(PROCESSING MATERIAL WING)
Regd. Office : "Mahabeej Bhawan", Krishi Nagar, Akola 444 104 (Maharashtra)
Phone Off.: 18002338877 CIN No.U01200MH19765SGC018990
E-Mail : hqpmw@mahabeej.com . Visit us at : http://www.mahabeej.com.

Ref. No.: MSSC/PMW/2025-2026/08

e-TENDER - NOTICE

Sealed e-Tenders (In Two Bid System) are invited for the supply of following Packing Material required for Rabi-2025-26 Season.

Item No.	Name of the Item	Approx Quantity	Normal EMD Amount in Rs.	Limited EMD for SSI's etc. in Rs.	Cost of Tender paper in Rs. (Incl GST)
Printed & Stitched Non-woven Cloth Bags (With Handle)					
1.	Size 26 x 39 cm	0.10 Lakh	1300/-	650/-	200/-
2.	Thiram 75% WS/WDP (ISI Mark)	45 M.Ton	247000/-	100000/-	1200/-

Note : Note : e-Tender documents containing the terms and conditions of supply and detailed specifications can be downloaded from the e-Tendering portal of Govt. of Maharashtra at www.mahatenders.gov.in. Help desk No.7588609407/7588609668.The last date of online submission of e-Tender form is 14.07.2026 (Tuesday) up to 13.00 Hrs.

FOR M.S.S.C. LIMITED.
GENERAL MANAGER (P/E & PMW)

Akola Date : 07.07.2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Suraj @ Dayand S/o Sh. Rajbir Singh, R/o: 38/4, Sawan Park Extension, Ashok Vihar, Delhi and 43, Sawan Park Harijan Colony, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 81/2019, U/S: 498A/406/506/34 IPC, PS: Bharat Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Suraj @ Dayand** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Suraj @ Dayand** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Suraj @ Dayand of FIR No. 81/2019, U/S: 498A/406/ 506/34 IPC, PS: Bharat Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.08.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Neha Goel

Metropolitan Magistrat Mahila Court-02

North West Room No. 18 Ground Floor

Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8674/NW/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. PC. /84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Anand, S/o Rajkumar R/o Ghattu Ka Makan, 2nd Pusta, New Usmanpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence in case **FIR No.115/2019 Dated 30.05.2019 u/s 25 Arms Act, P.S. Kashmere Gate, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Anand** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Anand** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Anand of FIR No.115/2019 Dated 30.05.2019 u/s 25 Arms Act, P.S. Kashmere Gate, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.08.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Vaibhav Garg

Judicial Magistrate First Class-11, Central

Room No. 138, First Floor

Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8925/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 (ii) Cr. P.C.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Firdos S/o Sh. Hasim Alam R/o B-223 Gali No. 4, Ram Colony, Rajiv Nagar, Khajuri Khas, Delhi** have committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence under **FIR No. 482/2022 U/s 498A/406/34 IPC.**, has been registered at **PS: Bhajanpura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Firdos** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Firdos** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Firdos of under has been under FIR No. 482/2022 U/s 498A/406/34 IPC.**, registered at **PS: Bhajanpura, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.08.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Rishika Srivastava

Ld. JMFC(Mahila Court), Room No. 67

Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/9269/NE/2026

(Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Rambabu Yadav, S/o: Ram Prit Yadav, R/o: N 82/46, T Huts, Pumbari Road, Model Town, Delhi.** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 476/2022, U/s: 411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Model Town, Delhi** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Rambabu Yadav**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Rambabu Yadav**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Rambabu Yadav, FIR No.: 476/2022, U/s: 411 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Model Town, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.08.2026**.

By Order

Sh. Himanshu Sehloth

Judicial Magistrate First Class - 03

Distt. North, Court No.213

Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8668/NW/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vicky Abhishek Sinha, S/o: Dilip Kuamr Sinha, R/o: C/o Kanak Lata Pardhan, Boring Canal Road, Left Street of Anand Puri, Hanuman Mandir Opp. of Advocate Deepak Sinha, Anand Puri, Patna, Bihar** also at **C/o Meenakshi Khara 310, Jagriti Enclave, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CC No.: 6855/2016, U/s: 138 NI ACT, P.S. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Vicky Abhishek Sinha** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vicky Abhishek Sinha** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vicky Abhishek Sinha of P.S. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.08.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Amardeep Kaur

Ld. ACJM-03, North, Room No. 117,

Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/9054/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Nikhil S/o Ajay R/o H. No. F-7/64, W-49, T-Huts, Sultanpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **E-FIR No. 80073045/24 U/s 305/331(4)/317/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Raj Park, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Nikhil** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nikhil** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Nikhil in E-FIR No. 80073045/24 U/s 305/331(4)/317/3(5) Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, PS Raj Park, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.08.2026**.

By order

Ms. Aakanksha

Judicial Magistrate First Class-03

Room No. 107

Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/9010/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vicky Sachdeva, S/o: Banarsi Lal Sachdeva, R/o: B-63, First Floor, Shalimar Garden, Sahibabad Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 333/2016, U/s: 379/356/411/34 IPC, P.S. Hari Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Vicky Sachdeva** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Vicky Sachdeva** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vicky Sachdeva of P.S. Hari Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.10.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Moksha Bains

JMFC-II, West, Room No. 31,

Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

DP/8949/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rohit Gupta, S/o Praveen Gupta R/o Jhuggi S-228, Indira Camp-II, Sunlight Colony** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.222/2016 u/s 356/379 IPC, P.S. Sunlight Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rohit Gupta** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rohit Gupta** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rohit Gupta of FIR No.222/2016 u/s 356/379 IPC, P.S. Sunlight Colony, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **24.09.2026**.

By Order,

Divyam Lila

Judicial Magistrate First Class

Room No.508, Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

DP/9222/SE/2026

“

I will wake up tomorrow the same way I woke up today: with a clear conscience. I won three titles with Portugal. Before Cristiano, Portugal had never won a big trophy. The best trophy I won with the national team was 2016, which for me has the same dimension as the World Cup.

CRISTIANO RONALDO, AFTER PORTUGAL'S ELIMINATION

”

Spain end Ronaldo's dream



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 7

FROM THE shadows pounced Mikel Merino. He was not in the place he was meant to be. Yet here he was. Wiggling through half a space the tired Portuguese defenders had left unmarked. Latching onto a needle-through-an-eye pass of Ferran Torres and coaxing the ball past an unsuspecting Diogo Costa.

Merino is seldom the hero before a game, little reams of newsprint is spent on his utilitarian affinities to influence a game. But not for the first time, he made the difference for his team, the difference between an exhaustive extra time and potential tiebreaker. The difference between Cristiano Ronaldo living another day and bidding farewell to a tournament that seldom has been his.

When Fabian Ruiz took a hurried free kick, roughly 20 yards from Portugal's goalmouth, Merino was lumbering, as though something was pulling him back. Ruiz passed behind to Rodri in midfield, he was just a few yards ahead of Rodri. But by the time the midfielder slipped the ball to Torres, Merino had made his typical run from behind, in stealth. And when Torres slid a gorgeously weighted ball, Merino was in the place where the ball was meant to be. He collected the ball and nervelessly plucked the goal to end a game that struggled to fulfil its preordained quality, that slumped to an afternoon siesta in Dallas.

For 90 minutes, the forwards and wingers designated to score goals, men far more celebrated than Merino, had failed to locate that perfect space. Costa did dash to flap away a thunderbolt from Alex Baena, but most other saves did not test his reflexes or elasticity. Perhaps, Costa or his defenders did not expect Merino's anonymous run from the midfield. No one does, except when he rattles the goal.

Merino has made a career out of invisible intrusions for his club and country. Arsenal supporters would recount several such goals that have made him a cult hero; Spain owed to him for the goal in the Euros semi-final against Germany. His uncanny knack of scoring important goals had his Arsenal teammate Gabriel Martinelli call him "R9".

In its precision and nervelessness, the goal was quite like the numerous ones Ronaldo Nazario has stroked in his career. Soon after he scored the goal, he went to the corner flag and circled it thrice, a nod to his father Miguel Merino, a midfielder with a string of modest La Liga sides in the late and 90s. Yet, it was a moment that never happened. When he suffered a bone stress fracture and a rare hairline fracture in his right



Mikel Merino scored 6 minutes after coming on as a sub. AP

foot in January, he thought his World Cup dreams were over. "When they told me about my injury, I thought I would not be at the World Cup, but here I am," he said after the game.

For three months, he couldn't walk. He prayed and cried. Then the doctor conveyed he was recovering faster than he had expected. He resumed his training with Arsenal, even though he remained on the bench for the Champions League final. He checked out with Spain's manager Carlos de la Fuente whether he is in the World Cup scheme. He told him he will wait.

The manager knew that few could multitask as imperceptibly as Merino could. He could man any role in the midfielder, as an attacking midfielder a box-crasher, or a few times as the pivot; on the frontline, Arteta has deployed him as a false nine, an auxiliary striker and as centre forward. At Dortmund, he was commissioned as a left-sided centre back; in age-group tournaments for Spain, he was often the centre-back.

Arteta discovered that he has the requisites to be a centre forward, he is aerially strong, he is clever in giving his defenders the slip, and he's seldom wasteful, attributes that shone in his 15-goal season for Arsenal in 2024-25. "When he returned, I saw his desperation to get himself back into shape for the final (Champions League) and the World Cup," Arteta said. "He's another one that is going to push every boundary, sacrificing every little joy," he added.

In his race to get fit, he missed time with his newborn son, who is only two months old. "The injury, not seeing my little one grow: I used that as strength to get the best out of me. This is the product of the hard work my family always inculcated in me. I did my part. For it to happen at the last minute again, I am so happy," he said after the game.

The 29-year-old is not the archetypal Spanish midfielder stylist, has a limited passing range, has nothing flashy. But he could perform difficult roles. When he was introduced in the 85th minute, the manager had a clear plan. "Mikel can play that role, between midfield and attack. And we thought of what might happen if it went to extra time," he said.

It did not roll into extra time, because Spain had Merino, the king of shadows.



Cristiano Ronaldo was despondent after Portugal exited the World Cup with a 1-0 defeat to Spain in the Round of 16. AP



The loss to Spain was Ronaldo's eighth defeat at the FIFA World Cup. No player has lost more matches.



Ronaldo has scored zero non-penalty goals and produced zero assists in his ten knockout appearances.



Ronaldo had only 19 touches of the ball against Spain — the least among all 22 players who started the game.



Ronaldo had 17 shots in this edition, which is the most by a player without creating a single chance in recorded history.



Ronaldo ranks 18th in ground covered per 90 minutes among Portuguese players, ahead of only goalie Diogo Costa.

A 91st-minute winner closes the book on CR7



Ronaldo confirmed that the 2026 World Cup would be his last. AP

Sandip G
New Jersey, July 7

THE BIGGEST dream of Cristiano Ronaldo would remain unconquered forever. The man who guzzled most of the records and trophies that football could offer would slip into the sunset without its greatest prize, the World Cup. It was the dream, to kiss the Cup, to cradle it like a baby. It was this wish that kept him burning at 41, that made him rise above the aches and niggles of a sculpted but battered body.

After Portugal's 0-1 loss to Spain in the round of 16, his eyes were cold, almost numb. It was perhaps the moment he reconciled with his unfulfilled dream. He walked without emotion, immune to the commiseration of his own men, to the handshakes and hugs of the victorious Spanish team, including the gatecrasher of his dream, Mikel Merino, the man who scored in injury time. Perhaps he was drained, or simply grieving an arena that was never his.

"I'm sad to leave the World Cup this way," Ronaldo would say after the game. "As I said yesterday, I gave it my all, and I leave with a clear conscience. That's the life of a footballer. You have to move forward."

The World Cup was never his grandest stage. The numbers pale — 11 goals, only one of those in a knockout, and two assists in 26 games. Fewer goals than Miroslav Klose and Harry Kane, as many goals as Sandor Kocsis and Jurgen Klinsmann. His most memorable night came against Spain, eight years ago, when he slammed in a hat-trick against them in a group game.

But most days and nights in the tournament brought him pain and tears, misery and dejection. In six World Cups, the furthest he and his team progressed was in 2006. He could not inspire his country, in youth or middle age, the way he lifted club after club to dizzying heights. There are other legends who were denied the sweetest taste on a football field. Even more cruelly. Like Johan Cruyff and Roberto Baggio. But he was, rather he believes he was, no ordinary legend. Ronaldo without the crown and sceptre is akin to Caesar without the Empire.

If his wish ended at the legs of Merino, it had metaphorically come to a grinding halt long ago. The vaulting ambition blinded the reality that he had been a burden for his teammates, as well as for his own image. He ignored his body, his team, and the game changing around him. He was scoring goals, his fans and manager Roberto Martinez retaliated, but little else. Then the goals dried up too, the sign his time was over. Yet he insisted, and the manager, who deserves some slack, persisted.

The force, the whip and precision too have forsaken him, the tools with which he had counteracted his waning athleticism. His 15 attempts fetched only three goals — a brace against minnows Uzbekistan and a penalty against Croatia. Against Spain, he had three shots, none of which really bothered Unai Simon.

The first was his sweetest strike, but from an acute angle that Simon parried around the post. Moments earlier, he was distraught when Rodri's tug on his shirt inside the box went unpunished, even without a routine VAR check.

There was a flash of improvisation around the 40th minute. He received a headed ball across goal from Joao Felix, back to goal, but with a svelte touch, turned it goal-wards. But his shot had neither the power nor the placement to trouble Simon. Upon resumption, he won a free kick that Bruno Fernandes flapped over the bar.

Ronaldo was aghast, though his free-kicks have long lost their bite. A few times, Nuno Mendes sent him through, but he was beaten and outnumbered by Spain's defenders. Felix, after flitting past red shirts, pinged a long cross for Ronaldo. He stretched late to connect, and the shot died, his body rebelling against the mind's orders. For much of the remaining half, he was reduced to casting stink eyes at his own men, for the passes not given, the chances squandered.

No player perhaps wanted to win the game quite like Ronaldo. But, perhaps, no player stood between him and his dream more than Ronaldo himself. That was the cruellest paradox in Ronaldo's last act on the stage that never loved him back.

● BALL DON'T LIE

Silenced in Seattle: How Belgium and Lukaku made their football do the talking

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, July 7

THE FINAL say, and a last dance.

Romelu Lukaku had it all as he made a beeline to the stands, cupping his ear, asking the silenced Seattle crowd for a reaction. When none came forth, the Belgians formed a circle on the pitch and started to dance. Soon it became evident that it was less of a dance, and more of an attempt to mock the President of the United States.

Now that Donald Trump's powerplay didn't have the desired effect and the co-hosts were handed a timid exit, it was Belgium's turn to mock the Americans. They chose the dance that Trump once did at a rally — a dance that has since

then become a global meme, often used to denote the American president in poor light.

"Overturn this", read Belgium football's social media accounts with a picture of Lukaku running towards the crowd. The final word would not go to the Americans.

Afterwards, Belgian captain Youri Tielemans said that the previous two days had prompted the team to convene.

"Let's be honest: we held a meeting when we heard the news," Tielemans said after Monday's game, referring to Fofa Balogun's reinstatement for the match despite the red card in the previous match. "We told ourselves we needed to do our talking on the pitch. That's what we did today. I'm very proud of the team."

Their coach Rudi Garcia was forgiving in his words for Balogun, who, through no fault of his own, was dropped into the middle of the storm. "He came to talk to me; I really like that. ... It's not his fault, he's not the one to blame," Garcia said.

Ball don't lie

There is a slang in basketball that has transcended to everyday American-speak and now finds appropriate use. 'Ball don't lie' essentially translates to sporting karma. That when a referee or a higher authority makes a poor call, the sport and the actors in the middle of it usually course-correct, and that the purity of the sport trumps the forces that attempt to manipulate it.

Football is no stranger to



Belgium team celebrate their Round of 16 win over the USA. AP

poor refereeing calls, just like every other sport, but it has rarely seen state heads bullying the sport to give their teams an undue benefit. And lost in the fracas was the true triumph of the day — Belgium.

Garcia dropped Kevin de Bruyne but also chose not to put super-sub Romelu Lukaku in their starting eleven. They took an even braver call to not include Jeremy Doku.

Garcia acknowledged the

seminal moment that arrived towards the end of their Round of 32 game against Senegal. Belgium's golden generation would have to be the supporting act. Against the Americans, the young brigade led the way, and the old guard supported the shift in power ably.

Of their four goals on the day, two came from Charles de Ketelaere in the first half. It was a statement moment for the 25-year-old Atalanta striker. Struggling for goals for his country, Lukaku's late-game heroics were threatening his spot in the starting eleven.

Eight of Belgium's 13 goals at the World Cup so far have come after the 60th minute. A strong statement of intent was needed and Ketelaere delivered on the promise of youth. He scored in

the ninth minute and then helped Belgium take the lead again in the 33rd after the United States had equalised from a deflected freekick guided in by Malik Tillman.

Belgium's third goal came from 33-year-old substitute and long-time Club Brugge attacking midfielder Hans Vanaken in the 57th minute. And then the stage opened for Lukaku.

Lukaku's football gets as much mention as his background. Son of Congolese immigrants who struggled to make ends meet in Belgium, tales of his youth — his mother mixing water with milk, parents of other children asking for his ID because of his accelerated growth spurt at a young age — showed just how strong and resilient he had to become well within his

teenage years.

Lukaku has been Belgium's most forward-thinking, politically-conscious sporting product. He has, in the past, called for social media CEOs to sit together and formulate plans to combat racism directed at sports persons. He has called for diversity in sports' leadership positions. He recently talked about violence in the Democratic Republic of Congo. All through his efforts, the word coming back would be the same — stick to football.

On Tuesday, Lukaku let his football speak. When the USA were down by two goals, he smacked a shot from his weaker foot in the third minute of injury time. The USA were already down; Lukaku pushed them out. And then he talked his talk, and danced his dance.

Neymar's dad urges him to 'keep playing'



Neymar played only two of Brazil's five games. AP
Express News Service
Mumbai, July 7

NEYMAR'S FATHER has posted an emotional letter on Instagram, urging his son to "keep playing football" and "delight people once again," after Brazil's round of 16 defeat to Norway. Neymar da Silva Santos Sr., who is also his agent, wrote: "Oh, son... What a journey. What a beautiful path. Challenging. Often painful, but infinitely blessed. A decision made today does not define your entire story. "A dream that hasn't come true yet doesn't mean it's dead. The end of the story is never determined by a difficult moment..."

Neymar has remained silent on social media since Brazil's elimination. The 34-year-old had not played with his national team since October 2023, when he tore his anterior cruciate ligament and meniscus in his left knee while playing for Brazil. After some strong performances for Santos, the experienced forward made Brazil's World Cup squad.

"I watched the boy grow into one of the greatest players of his generation in history," Neymar Sr. said. "When I look back, I see much more than trophies, goals, contracts, or recognition. I see miracles. I see deliverance. I see promises being fulfilled. And when I look ahead, I remain just as certain. The best doesn't depend on age or circumstances. I want to ask you something as a father. Son, keep playing football."

Rodri says he is sorry for spat

Arlington: Spain midfielder Rodri expressed regret at celebrating in the face of Bernardo Silva after his former Manchester City teammate missed a late chance to equalise for Portugal in their heavyweight World Cup match.

Silva had a chance to take the Round-of-16 game — won 1-0 by Spain on Monday — to extra time but headed over the crossbar after six minutes of stoppage time. As the Portugal playmaker lay on the ground with his head in his hands, Rodri walked up to Silva and clenched his fist in a taunting gesture. "I made a mistake," the 2024 Ballon d'Or winner said, "because I celebrated when he had missed. I apologized to him immediately," Rodri said. AP

UNDER PRESSURE

The not-so-exact science of taking penalty kicks

Even the best strikers stutter before taking a penalty, as no method guarantees success

Sandeep Dwivedi
New Delhi, July 7

CRISTIANO RONALDO waits at the edge of the D. The Croatian goalkeeper stands still on the goal line at the other end. This is a wild-west face-off of the footballing kind. Here one shoots, the other saves. Between them sits the ball.

The next few seconds will decide the fate of the world's most famous footballer. Ronaldo's Portugal trails by a goal in this World Cup knockout tie's 67th minute, and for Ronaldo the clock could be running out for good. Should he kick right of the goalkeeper, or left? Pause the frame and check the statistics for the answer.

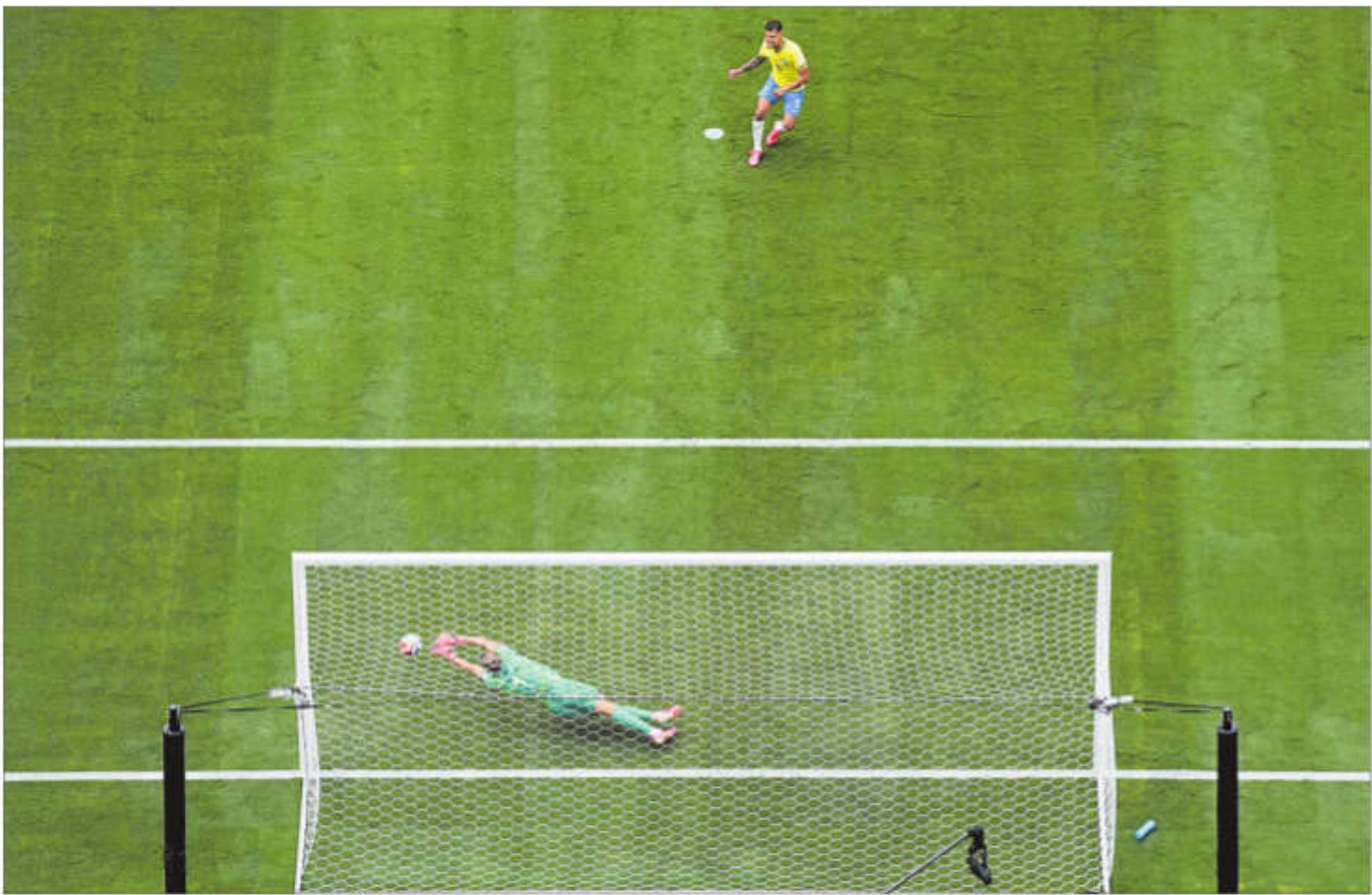
In his seminal book on football shootouts, *Pressure: Lessons from the psychology of the penalty shootout*, Norwegian researcher Geir Jordet gives the numbers. Going right, the chance of scoring is 70.7 percent; going left, virtually the same at 71.2 percent.

Counterintuitively, going straight down is actually the best option, with the chances of scoring climbing to 77.9 percent. The logic: most goalkeepers second-guess. With the ball rocketing towards them at pace, there's no time to react after the kick, so they must pre-decide, pick a side. Straight down is the easiest way to beat both keeper and odds.

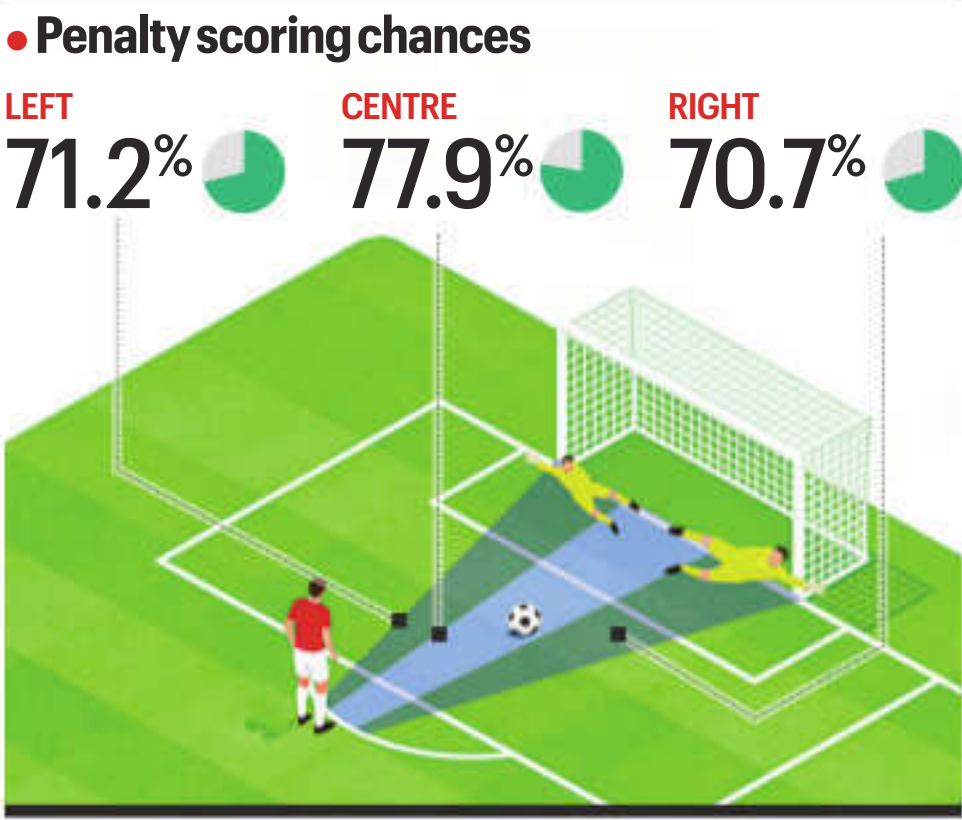
But goalkeepers have researchers too. What if they stand still? Then the straight kicks land in their laps. The save instantly turns the penalty-taker into a villain: a choker, a counterfeit Panenka.

Ronaldo took the biggest gamble of his life. He starts, then suddenly stops in his stride. The Croatian keeper dives to his right. Ronaldo's pause has done its job: he goes straight. Goal. 1-1. He, and Portugal, live to tell the tale.

Mohamed Salah, in the penalty shootout in the knock-out game against Australia, chipped the ball down the middle to beat the goalkeeper. Had he missed, his aura would have been dented. Salah wanted to deliver for his team on the big day and for that he was willing to take the risk. The brave Egyptian opted for the adventurous Panenka and his legend grew.



Norway goalkeeper Oerjan Nyland saves a penalty kick taken by Brazil's Bruno Guimaraes in their Round of 16 match. AP



Both Salah and Ronaldo had come close to joining football's hall of shame of unsuccessful penalty-takers, the cursed fraternity of men like Baggio, forced to relive their worst day every time they step outside. For some, even that wouldn't help.



Which raises the real puzzle: why do the best players in the world, men who can thread a pass through four defenders, sometimes come apart with nothing between them and the goal but a set of gloves twelve yards away?

"Why didn't you just whack it in?" This was Gareth Southgate's mother Barbara after her son missed that crucial penalty against Germany in the 1996 Euro semi-finals. A loving parent, but a natural reaction, and one echoed in living rooms across England that night. Bar-

bara's line would go on record, the familiar cry fans let out when a player fails to do what seems deceptively simple.

Days earlier, even Messi triggered this frustration when he dragged the ball wide of the post from the spot against Austria. Even Buenos Aires would have thrown up its hands watching their greatest player fail at football's supposedly easiest task.

Over the years, research scientists, neuroscientists, economists and pundits have all tried to crack this battle of nerves within a team game. What makes it fascinating is how little has actually been cracked. Every angle has been examined, but no one has solved the penalty. It remains the suspense drama that makes football's narrative richer, the ultimate test of coolness. A strange geometrical puzzle where nothing can work but anything can be handy. Even

Mrs Southgate's wise-with-hindsight instruction: "Why didn't you just whack it in?"



Hungary's captain and Liverpool's main man Dominik Szoboszlai truly believes in Mrs Southgate's "whack it in" approach. Son of a failed footballer and reformed gambling addict, Szoboszlai spent nearly five hours playing football every day since the age of six, logging his 10,000 hours before adulthood, with his father as coach and taskmaster. Besides being a skilful footballer, he became an expert penalty-taker: pick a spot, kick low and hard, make the goalkeeper redundant.

One story from his RB Leipzig days: facing PSG in a Champions League game where a goal would deny PSG a point. As Szoboszlai walked in to take it, Neymar tried playing mind games. He'd picked the wrong guy. "You going to score?" Neymar asked. "Yes." "Are you sure?" Szoboszlai, calm and matter-of-fact: "Yes. I never miss." He was right. Donna-rumma dived right; the kick went past him anyway, same direction, no contest.

How could Szoboszlai be so sure of himself? Training and temperament, perhaps, but this slam-bang approach comes with no guarantee. Jordet's book is full of cases where it didn't hold: England's Chris Waddle in 1990, too hasty on his run-up; Steven Gerrard in 2006, describing the wait before his turn as an unbearable countdown in his own head. Jordet's diagnosis is the same in both: dread, urgency, a desire

to end the wait and stop the pain.

So is the stuttered approach better? Not always. Nothing is etched in stone when it comes to spot kicks.



Marcus Rashford, another Englishman with penalty trauma, has his own stutter-penalty story. In his book, he writes about his miss in the Euro 2020 final against Italy, the game where he and the other players who failed to score, mostly Black footballers, were trolled brutally enough to question their future in the game. "Normally I don't get nervous when playing football," he wrote. "But that day, something was off, the brain wasn't telling me 'just try your best' like it normally did." Instead: "You have to be perfect." So he tried something different: a stuttering run-up, a pause on the way to the ball. It wasn't the instruction his feet were used to receiving.

Even the smartest penalty-takers, Messi, Harry Kane, have fluffed chances after their own stutter. Which brings us back to where we started: why do the most skillful footballers in the world keep failing to beat a six-foot goalkeeper guarding an eight-foot-high, twenty-four-foot-wide target?

Football's greatest thinker, the late Johan Cruyff, put it quite simply.

"They look so simple, that's why they're difficult." So next time someone who can't toss a crumpled paper into the bin says "Why didn't you just whack it in?", tell them to shut up.

{ SIDELINES }



A Paraguay senator racially abused Kylian Mbappé. AP

Prosecutors probing racist insults against Mbappé

FRENCH PROSECUTORS have opened an investigation into aggravated public insult and incitement to hatred or violence after a Paraguay senator racially abused Kylian Mbappé following Paraguay's loss to France at the World Cup.

The Paris prosecutor's office told The Associated Press on Tuesday that it launched the probe after the national unit for combating online hate received a complaint from the French Football Federation (FFF).

Celeste Amarilla, a senator from Paraguay's Liberal Radical Party, posted racist comments on X after Mbappé converted the winning penalty in France's victory over Paraguay on Saturday. She mocked the France captain's origins, upbringing, education and appearance. France

advanced to the quarter-finals where it will face Morocco on Thursday. Mbappé called her a "despicable woman" who was "unworthy" of serving in Paraguay's Congress.

The Paris prosecutor's office said "the remarks were allegedly made because of the victim's actual or perceived origin, ethnicity, nationality, race, or religion."

These offenses were punishable by up to one year of imprisonment and a 45,000 euros fine (\$51,000).

The Paris prosecutor's office can initiate an investigation into statements made abroad, given that the victim is a French national. Amarilla later issued an open letter in French and Spanish to Mbappé on social media, in which she said her problem was with the player, not the country of France. AP



Trump (R) and Infantino.

Lawmakers call for probe of FIFA chief Infantino

EUROPEAN LAWMAKERS are gathering support to launch an investigation of FIFA boss Gianni Infantino over his involvement in the decision to permit US striker Folarin Balogun to play despite an earlier red card. Balogun was shown a red card during the US victory over Bosnia on July 1, which normally would make him ineligible to play in team's next game, but FIFA lifted his suspension for a match on Monday after US President Donald Trump intervened. "Once again, we've seen Infantino and FIFA surrender to the demands of the Trump administration," the statement said. AP

Replay the 2002 final: Kahn's advice to FIFA

OLIVER KAHN has ventured his opinion on the controversy surrounding Folarin Balogun's rescinded red card, but with a sarcastic undertone. He has urged FIFA to retroactively rescind the suspension which prevented Michael Ballack from featuring in the 2002 final against Brazil. Balogun, the US frontman, was supposed to be suspended for the round of 16 clash against Belgium after being given marching orders in the previous fixture against Bosnia and Herzegovina. However, it was rescinded by FIFA following intervention from the American president, Donald Trump. Kahn has suggested FIFA to stage a rematch of the final in Yokohama. "I'd like FIFA to retroactively rescind the yellow card shown to Michael Ballack in the 2002 World Cup semifinal, the one that ruled him out of the final. And while we're at it, we might as well replay the final against Brazil," he wrote on Instagram. ENS

{ Z A D R A N 1 9 8 7 - 2 0 2 6 }

Afghanistan's first rockstar of fast bowling no more

Sandeep Dwivedi
New Delhi, July 7

THE SETTING helped. It was the 2015 World Cup, the eve of Afghanistan's match against Australia in Perth. Keeping his promise to meet after a tiring net session, the 6'2" pacer walked in with a swagger, running his fingers through his freshly showered, wavy hair like a movie star at a premiere.

"My height is very big, my hair is very big, and I have too much style," Shapoor Zadrán said, in broken English. It was his way of laying his calling card on the table between him and the reporters.

This was well before Rashid Khan's debut. Afghanistan lacked superstars and an identity of their own. They were counted among cricket's minnows, a flash-in-the-pan side, not yet the habitual giant-killers they'd become. Zadrán, though, carried no inferiority complex. He was evidence of a nation waiting to exhale. They lacked results, but never passion.

Zadrán bowled in the high 140s, throwing a piercing gaze at batsmen. He wasn't really his nation's poster boy so much as

its fantasy cricketer. Afghanistan loved aggressive players, and the sight of him striding in, hair flying like a cape, exuded hostility. "In Afghanistan, too much like in speed, too much like in the long run-up," he'd say, again caressing his hair.

The full-of-life Zadrán breathed his last away from home, in Delhi, on Tuesday, bedridden for months while battling a rare illness that chips away at the immune system, block by block.

Through the long fight, players and fans rallied around him. Teammates stayed by his bedside, promising all the help he needed. When he needed blood, cricket fans lined up to give it. But the popular Afghan would lose his battle.

The Afghanistan Cricket Board put out a detailed statement making clear his contribution to his country's cricket went well beyond the 80 wickets he took in 44 ODIs and 36 T20Is between 2009 and 2020. Zadrán sowed the seed of what has become one of world cricket's fastest-growing teams. The ACB called him a "foundation-laying figure of Afghanistan cricket," "a proud cricketer who stood at the heart of



Shapoor Zadrán was one of the most recognisable Afghanistn cricketers during the first decade of this century. REUTERS

Afghanistan's early cricket journey," and "a true source of inspiration for many young Afghan cricketers," adding that "his memory will forever remain alive in the hearts of the people of Afghanistan."

The 2015 World Cup was the finest hour of Zadrán's career. He took 10 wickets across the tournament. Afghanistan jerseys with his name on the back flew off the counters on match days. That day in Perth, the

dream destination for cricket's speed merchants, his excitement was hard to hide. They were playing the eventual champions the next day, but the hardcore Shoaib Akhtar fan matched his idol's own boast and bluster. When he said he'd blow away the mighty Australian top order, he sounded like he believed it.

The next day, he kept his word, somewhat.

He got the wickets of David Warner and Steve Smith, but only after they'd made 178 and 88 respectively. The boundaries he conceded along the way didn't dampen his pace or his spirit. He kept running in fast, banging the ball in short, kept throwing his hair back.

Zadrán grew up in Afghanistan's Logar province, a region best known for the long, brutal war between the US-trained mujahideen and Soviet-backed government troops.

Life was hard. Like many Afghan families, the Zadráns moved to Peshawar, in Pakistan, and it was there, as a teenager, that he first saw his inspiration on television. Shoaib Akhtar had a charisma that could hook any young cricketer, and Zadrán was hooked

the day he watched Akhtar bowl in Perth, a delivery flying clean over the wicketkeeper's head.

That day in Perth, Zadrán shared the memory again, rattling off names to make his point: "Dennis Lillee, Shaun Tait, Brett Lee, Ambrose, Walsh, Shoaib Akhtar, Wasim Akram, Waqar Younis, Shoaib Akhtar, too much bounce, too much speed."

Soon he grew restless, the pull of the Perth pitch too strong to resist for long. Once the team's rock star had wandered off, the media manager shared a few more nuggets, chuckling as he talked about Zadrán's sizeable female fan-base back home, and his surprisingly exquisite dancing.

"He is the one leading the Attan, the traditional Afghan dance, others make a queue behind him. It's a dance we do during festivals, weddings, and to celebrate wins. He did it when we qualified for the World Cup. He is outstanding. You can find him doing the Attan on YouTube," he said.

Afghanistan has lost its pied piper, the man everyone once lined up behind. He had you at hello. Now, he's said goodbye.

Gauff beats Pegula to reach maiden Wimbledon semis

Associated Press
London, July 7

COCO GAUFF fought back from a set down to reach the Wimbledon semi-finals for the first time after beating friend and former doubles partner Jessica Pegula 4-6, 6-3, 6-3 in an all-American Centre Court clash on Tuesday. The seventh seed and two-time Grand Slam winner will continue her adventure as the highest ranked player left in the women's singles draw but she was on the back foot initially against a fourth-seeded opponent.

In truth, Gauff was fighting herself almost as much as the American No.1. Playing in the Wimbledon quarter-finals for the first time, she made 17 unforced errors and served four double faults in the opening set. The 22-year-old got things back under control in the second set, although she still faced two breakpoints in the opening game, and halved the number of unforced errors.

The 2023 US and 2025 French Open winner led for the first time when she broke Pegula in the final set but her



Coco Gauff beat Jessica Pegula 4-6, 6-3, 6-3 on Tuesday. AP

older opponent was not beaten yet and broke back to 3-3.

Gauff, who will face either Naomi Osaka or Karolina Muchova in the semi-finals, replied with another immediate break, then held serve and Pegula fell at the first match point with a return to the net.

"Pretty insane, honestly," was Gauff's immediate reaction to the win. "Considering how I hadn't won a match on grass in

two years before this tournament, I'm definitely just really happy with how I played today. Jess is an incredible opponent and person and playing against her is never easy. I'm just happy to get through this one today."

Zverev advances

Alexander Zverev worked a longer shift than he would have hoped for in fierce heat as he returned to Centre Court on Tuesday to complete his fourth-round win over Jiri Lehecka and reach the Wimbledon quarter-finals for the first time. The German second seed had gone to bed the previous evening tantalisingly close to breaking new ground at Wimbledon, leading by two sets and 3-3 in the third when Wimbledon's strict 11 p.m. curfew halted his progress. On the resumption, a listless-looking Zverev lost 12 of the first 13 points to drop the third set but managed to re-focus to win 6-4 7-5 3-6 7-6(6).

Zverev double-faulted on a second match point in the tie-breaker but was spared further overtime as 13th seed Lehecka netted a backhand.